

Believing into God

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*Aquinas, Aristotle, and the Denaturation of Christian
Faith*

Xavier Ortiz Monasterio

Edited by Jorge Monasterio

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The complete archive of the author’s papers, including this manuscript in its original form, is preserved at github.com/jmonasterio/xavier-o-monasterio.

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A Note on the Text

Xavier Ortiz Monasterio (1926–2011) taught philosophy at the University of Dayton. He worked on this book between 1991 and 2000; it was left unpublished at his death, and untitled — the present title is the editor’s.

The manuscript comprises eight chapters, recovered from the author’s WordPerfect files and converted for publication. The conversions received a light editorial pass: conversion artifacts, misspellings, doubled words, and citation typos were corrected; the author’s style, wording, and argument were left untouched.

The manuscript breaks off in chapter 8, whose final pages are working notes rather than finished prose. Chapters 9 through 11 attempt to complete the argument as the author projected it, in his manner, from his own outline and from his closely related essays (*Revelation*, 1990; *Narrative*, 1990; and his engagement with Hans Frei, 1993). Each carries a note identifying it as a reconstruction.

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Chapter 1: Determinatio Distrahens

The purpose of this chapter is to determine whether Aquinas realized that in submitting the Bible to the regime of Aristotelian science he was distorting its nature and the nature of revelation and of faith. Bonaventure, for instance, realized that in the passage from the *credibile ut credibile* to the *credibile ut intelligibile* there was a *determinatio distrahens*—hence the title of my chapter—, though he seems to have also believed, however inconsistently, that the revealed loses nothing of its nature in the passage. Was Aquinas aware, as Bonaventure was, of such *determinatio distrahens*? If so, did he also think that the revealed came unscathed out of such passage? In either case, was he right?

Indeed, a further purpose of this chapter is to show that the passage of the revealed as revealed to the revealed as object of Aristotelian science is not innocent at all, that it amounts to a denaturation of the revealed, and that it entails significant consequences.

What are we talking about, exactly? The point can be easily suggested. Between the text of the Bible and the text of, say, Aquinas's *Summa Theologica* any reader would sense a profound difference. The former is, for the most part and very fundamentally, a narrative work—be it taken as a story or as history. The latter is a demonstrative work, consciously and willingly written under the influence of Aristotle's notion of science. In short, the Bible and the *Summa* are books of totally different literary genres. Nonetheless, supposedly, the subject matter of both is divine revelation. The question is whether in the shift from one genre to the other divine revelation

remains the same, or whether, on the contrary, it undergoes a substantive change, a change affecting its very nature.

As Chenu observes, the term “*Sacra doctrina*,” commonly used in the middle ages, is used without proper distinction to designate three different though closely related things, namely: divine revelation, the Bible, and theology. The same is true of St Thomas, according to Chenu: “... et ‘*doctrina sacra*’ conservera son equivocate jusque dans la langue de St Thomas” (p. 38). There is, however, at least a moment in which Bonaventure distinguishes clearly between the kind of book he is authoring when he writes a theological treatise and the kind of book the Bible is. The difference is, in Bonaventure’s terms, that the book Bonaventure is writing deals, as any other theological book does, with the *credibile ut intelligibile*, whereas the Bible presents the *credibile ut credibile* and as authorized directly by God. (It seems that Bonaventure distinguishes also between revelation itself and Scripture, for he writes: “*Credibile enim, secundum quod habet in se rationem primae veritatis, cui fides assentit propter se et super omnia, pertinet ad habitum fidei; secundum quod super rationem veritatis addit rationem auctoritatis, pertinet ad doctrinam sacrae Scripturae...; sed secundum quod supra rationem veritatis et auctoritatis addit rationem probabilitatis, pertinet ad considerationem praesentis libri, in quo ponuntur rationes probantes fidem nostram. Et sic patet quomodo differenter est fides de credibii, et libri de canone sacrae Scripturae, et praesens scriptura*” (p. 55).) There is, however, no *determinatio* *distrahens* or change in nature involved in the passage of the *credibile ut credibile* to the *credibile ut intelligibile*, for Bonaventure’s text (that is, a theological text) remains subordinated to the text of the Scripture; it is a case of mere *subalternatio* or subordination, apparently confirmed by the fact that “*les raisons (l’intelligibilite) ne valent que dans la foi*” and “*ne limitent pas le merite de la foi; elles en dilatent la delectation*” (p. 56). What did Aquinas think of this? Did he agree with Bonaventure? Did he see the text of his *Summa* related in the same way to the text of the Scripture? (Now, our first question is whether Aquinas was aware, in the first place,

that a *determinatio distrahens*, that is, a complete change in literary genres (with the consequent change in the reading of the texts) takes place between the text of the Bible and the text of his *Summa*.)

Subalternatio

Our first hint will come from the way in which Aquinas conceives of *determinatio distrahens* and of the *subalternatio* of theology to Scripture.

St Thomas considers the *subalternatio* of theology to scripture or to the revealed word of God in his short commentary on Boetius's *De Trinitate*. In theology the articles of faith play the role that the first principles play in Aristotle's *First Philosophy*. Hence theology can have a scientific character. However, there is a difference between Aristotle's first principles and the articles of faith that work as principles in theology: the former are *per se noti*, whereas the latter are not *per se noti* to the theologian; they are, so to say, *per se noti* to God, but not to the theologian; the theologian only believes them on God's authority. As a consequence, theology, for Aquinas, is not, strictly speaking, a science (an *episteme*), only a "quasi-science." "*La theologie est subordonnee a la science de Dieu*" (p. 78). The theologian aspires to the vision God has of Himself, inasmuch as such a vision is possible to a human creature, but it does not possess that vision here on earth; he *believes* the first principles of his science, he does not have intrinsic evidence of their truth as the philosopher has of the truth of the first principles of his science. Accordingly, there is no proper *subalternatio* between the Scripture and theology. What *subalternatio* means for Aristotle is a subordination of one science to another that does not imply a loss of the autonomy of the subordinated science within its proper field. For example, according to Aristotle, the physician borrows the principles of his science from mathematics. But for the physician himself these principles are not evident; he trusts the authority of the mathematician concerning the truth of those principles. In this sense, the theologian in respect of God is like the physician in respect of the mathematician. Hence, as there is subordination of medical science to mathematics, there is

also subordination of theology to God's science. This is what makes theology qualify as a quasi science. However, as Aquinas pointedly notes, the subalternatio of which Aristotle speaks obtains between sciences which have different objects. The object of mathematics is different from the object of the medical science. Thus, although the medical science is subordinated to mathematics concerning its principles, it is an autonomous science that works according to laws appropriate to its object, which is different from the object of mathematics. But in the case of theology it is not so. For the object of theology and of the Bible is one and the same. What the theologian studies in his science is what God has revealed. "Le rapport entre le croyant et Dieu est epistemologiquement et reellement tres different du rapport entre le physicien et le mathematicien" (p. 83), for the theologian himself is a croyant: "la foi n'est pas extrinseque a la theologie" (p. 84), precisely because what is revealed and believed is the same as what is theologized about. Thus the subordination of theology to the revealed is very different from that of medicine to mathematics. Medical science is an autonomous science; theology is not, it is intrinsically subordinated to the revealed. "Primaute de la parole de Dieu sur la theologie. L'episteme se trouve restreindre sa portee" (p. 84).

We might get a better understanding of this important point by reference to Bonaventure. For him there was a real difference between the object of faith (the *credibile ut credibile*) and the object of study of theology (the *credibile ut intelligibile*), and this difference accounted for the difference in literary genres between a theological treatise and the Bible. This amounts to saying that the revealed and the theologized about, though materially the same object, are different in their formal identity, for the revealed in theology is taken as object of scientific inquiry, whereas the Bible does not present the word of God as object of inquiry but as revealed. Of course, if Bonaventure is right, it would follow that the theologian, except for his principles, admitted by faith, would be totally independent from the revealed and totally free to treat it according to the logic of scientific inquiry. This Aquinas denies, because he denies the differ-

ence postulated by Bonaventure between that which the theologian believes (*credibile ut credibile*) and that which the theologian wants to understand (*credibile ut intelligibile*). For Aquinas they are one and the same.

But what, one might ask, is the import of these considerations to our problem? The connection will become clear by returning to the *determinatio distrahens*.

What Aquinas denies implicitly by affirming the identity between the revealed and the object of theology is that there is a *determinatio distrahens* in the passage from the text of the Bible to a theological text. In other words, between the text of the Bible and the text of the *Summa* there is only an accidental difference—a matter of different styles, we would say. (To quote Bonaventure, “*propter quod etiam novi theologi frequenter ipsam Scripturam sacram exhorrent tamquam incertam et inordinatam, et tamquam quandam silvam opacam*,” p. 54, note 4). The theologian, to put it in other terms, merely arranges the revealed material in a different order and puts under the form of clear, explicit and logically interconnected statements exactly the same truths that the Bible presents in disorder and under the form of stories or allegories rather than of statements. This amounts to saying that the difference between narratives and logical demonstrations is just superficial, for the same is meant by both, narratively and inordinately for common people by the Bible, systematically and logically for intellectuals.

It is difficult to say whether Aquinas would have agreed with what I just said if it had been put to him in those terms. But it seems to be a consequence of his treatment of the kind of *subalternatio* proper to theology and of his implicit denial of a *determinatio distrahens* in the passage from Scripture to theology.

Thus, the first indicator of a possible answer to the question whether Aquinas thought that there was or could be a denaturation of revelation in the passage from the text of the Bible to a theological text like his *Summa* is that he had no hint of such denaturation, the reason for this being that he took the Bible for a bad theological

Summa theologica, or the Summa Theologica for a better Bible, at least for well educated people.

Of course, I am the first to doubt that Saint Thomas ever thought such a thing, or even that he would have agreed with it if explicitly asked. The fact nonetheless remains that the indicator suggests that, in all logic, he would have had to agree. Let us now find out in what direction other indicators point.

Revelation and the Literary Genre of the Bible

Assuming, for the time being, that a consequence of Aquinas's views is that the Bible and the Summa mean the same, we may legitimately ask whether he would have thought that the ideal way for revelation to reach people is the biblical way or the theological way, that is, the way of the Summa. The interest of this question is that it will lead us to understand the way in which Aquinas conceived of revelation, on the one hand, and understood the literary genre of the Bible, on the other. As we will see, the two points are intimately related.

As to the way in which Aquinas conceived revelation, the case is fairly straightforward. Let us start with Part I, question 1 of the Summa, which deals with the nature and the domain of sacred doctrine.

It is necessary, he says in art. 1, that there should be a doctrine revealed by God besides the philosophical disciplines investigated by reason, because certain truths exceed human reason, and because what can be known of God by reason would be known only by a few. If we are to understand this text to the letter, revelation is a doctrine that gives us some knowledge about God. That Aquinas thinks so is clear, for he puts what we acquire through God's revelation on a par with what we reach through the natural use of reason in the philosophical disciplines, and what we reach through the latter is knowledge. Moreover, Aquinas explicitly speaks of the limited but nonetheless genuine knowledge about God obtained through the natural use of reason. What makes necessary that this knowledge be revealed rather than acquired through human effort is that, at least a portion of that knowledge exceeds the natural possibilities

of human reason. It seems, then, at least up to this point, that for Aquinas revelation is to be understood as knowledge about God. What God reveals is information about himself.

The second article explains that theology (sacred doctrine) is a science. This confirms our previous understanding that he sees the revealed as a kind of knowledge, for what is looked for in the practice of science—most certainly in the Aristotelian conception that Aquinas shares—is knowledge. That we are not misunderstanding Aquinas becomes evident when he explains to us that theology proceeds (like what Aristotle names science) from principles. Only, the principles on the basis of which theology works, unlike the principles of an Aristotelian science, are the knowledge that God himself has of himself. Now, principles, in Aristotelian science, are genuine principles, that is universal truths which are not based on any other truths and which, combined with other truths which themselves are not principles because they are not self-evident but discovered, can generate other truths. Now, immediately after stating that “sacred science is a science because it proceeds from principles made known by the highest science: the science of God,” (that is, the knowledge God himself has of himself), Aquinas contrasts these principles of theology with “individual facts, such as the deeds of Abraham.” This makes very clear that Aquinas has in mind revealed truths which actually work like principles, for they possess a universality which obviously truths about individual facts cannot possess. Not that God does not reveal knowledge about individual facts; but this knowledge cannot play the role of principles because of its particularity. Individual facts are not treated in sacred doctrine (theology? Scripture? revelation?) as its principal concern and its primary object, but rather as examples to be followed in our lives, as in the moral sciences, and also to establish the authority of those through whom the divine revelation, on which this sacred scripture or doctrine is based, has come down to us. (We should remark in passing the confusion between the three elements).

Article four defines “sacred science” as a theoretical and practical discipline, for it includes both theoretical and practical truths. In

both cases, clearly, what is transmitted through revelation is truths. But while some of those are purely theoretical—that is, just to be assented to by the intellect—others are practical in that they terminate in (or lead to) action. However, sacred doctrine is more theoretical than practical for two reasons: first, its main concern is the truths about God (the underlying assumption being that the truths about God do not entail actions, much as the truths of Aristotle’s First Philosophy don’t); second, because inasmuch as this science deals with human actions, it takes them for what they are, namely, pure means to lead us eternal life to the beatific vision or fully satisfactory and “perfect knowledge” of God which we will possess in eternal life.

Article five explains the peculiarity of sacred science: unlike the other sciences which derive their certitude from the natural light of human reason, this one derives its certitude from the light of divine science, that is, the knowledge God himself has, which cannot err. The reason for this peculiarity is that this science treats chiefly of things which transcend human reason. Thus the reason why some people doubt the articles of faith, that is, the principles of this science, is the weakness of the human intellect, not the weak quality of the principles themselves. And although this science does not need the help of any other sciences, for its principles are revealed, it uses the philosophical disciplines to help the weakness of our intellect, which is more easily led by what is known through natural reason.

Article 6 pursues the characterization of sacred science by contrast to the human sciences. Sacred science is better than philosophy and is the highest of sciences, because its object is “God as He is known to Himself” and revealed to us, whereas philosophy, insofar as it knows about God, knows Him not as He knows himself but only through its effects. Furthermore, since sacred doctrine is supported by divine revelation, *whatever in other sciences is contrary to the truth of sacred doctrine must be condemned as false*. In this sense, other sciences are judged by this one. In this connection, Aquinas deals with an important question concerning the nature of theology, for it has to do with *the problem whether theology is just a more systematic Bible or rather something vastly different*.

There are two ways of judging, declares Aquinas: by inclination and by knowledge. For instance, the virtuous man judges rightly of what is virtuous by inclination, because he is inclined to what is virtuous. By contrast, a man learned in moral science may judge rightly about virtuous acts, even if he has no virtue, because he has acquired knowledge of what is virtuous through study—and this is an instance of judgment by knowledge. The latter is the manner of judging proper to sacred science, for, though its principles come from revelation, it is acquired through study. Let us consider this.

Beyond any doubt, Aquinas sees the Bible as the immediate source of revelation, as far as the theologian is concerned, exactly as he assumes the Bible to be the immediate source of revelation for any other member of the Church. Such was the traditional view of theologians at the time, and the most cursory reading of Aquinas's *Summa* shows that such was his view too. In other words, the theologian is situated in respect to the Bible as any other of the faithful. Without faith, a theologian cannot be a theologian in Aquinas's sense, since the principles of theology come from revelation and are nothing else than the articles of faith.

Thus, both a theologian and a simple Christian read the same book with the same reverence. Now, assuming that both are equally intelligent and equally devout, are they in their reading after the same kind of understanding and, therefore, is the result of their respective readings the same? Or is there, rather, a genuine *determinatio distrahens* in the passage from the Christian's reading of the Bible to the theologian's reading?

According to Aquinas, there is no *determinatio distrahens*. True, as we just saw, the theologian's purpose is scientific rather than devotional. The theologian does not read the Bible to judge by inclination, that is, to put into practice his faith in his own life, as the faithful do, or to exhort himself and others to put their faith into practice, as the Christian preacher does, but to understand the Bible theoretically, to judge by knowledge, as one does with an object of study. But Aquinas is convinced that there is no fundamental differ-

ence between these two readings. The only difference between the theologian and the simple faithful is that the theologian comes to know explicitly and in detail what the simple faithful knows implicitly and in a general way (I, 1, art. ?).

The reason Aquinas does not see any *determinatio distrahens*, as we know, is because, unlike Bonaventure, he equates the *credibile ut credibile* with the *credibile ut intelligibile*.

But what Aquinas means by *intelligibile* is what Aristotle means by *intelligibile*, that is, what can be object of science as Aristotle understood the word science. Indeed, that is why, with the appropriate distinctions, Aquinas contended that theology could be integrated within the map of the Aristotelian sciences at least as a quasi-science.

This presupposes, however, that two conditions obtain: (1) That what is revealed by God is analogous to what the Aristotelian scientist comes to know through the use of reason; and, (2) that the activity by which the faithful (the theologian included) accepts what God reveals is analogous to the activity by which the scientist accepts what reason discloses. And this is exactly what Aquinas thinks is the case.

Concerning (1): What God reveals is analogous to what the Aristotelian scientist comes to know through the use of reason. Indeed it is the *knowledge* God has of Himself, primarily, and, secondarily, of what we need to know and do to reach in heaven the vision of the truth that will make us eternally happy; this is analogous to the *knowledge* that the Aristotelian scientist acquires, so much so that the articles of faith play within theology the role that the Aristotelian principles play within Aristotelian science, that the *certainty* the theologian has of his first principles is comparable and superior to the certainty the Aristotelian scientist has of the first principles of his science, and that the *vision* of the object revealed (that is, God) we will have in heaven is of the same structure as the vision the Aristotelian scientist has of his object. The difference that makes theology into a quasi-science rather than a full-fledged science

is that the certitudes of the theologian rest, not on immediate evidence, but on the evidence God Himself has of what he reveals and is accepted by the theologian on his authority.

As for condition (2): the act of faith is analogous to the act by which the scientist accepts what is disclosed by reason. Indeed, it is an act of the intellect and it consists in assent. On this point, the difference that makes theology into a quasi-science rather than a full-fledged science is that the assent of the faithful is not prompted by immediate evidence but by God's authority.

There is, therefore, not the slightest doubt that Aquinas considered the Christian revelation as analogous to the object of Aristotelian science. But, if to this we add that Aquinas identified the Christian revelation with the content of the Bible, the unavoidable implication is that he had to conceive the Bible as a book of science, essentially, in that the Bible contains that portion of the knowledge God deemed necessary for our salvation.

The Bible as a Scientific Book

It is on this precise point that the medievals had to struggle with a number of thorny difficulties, all of which boil down to the obscure but powerful—and perhaps not unjustified—feeling that in the passage from the Bible to a *Summa Theologica*, in spite of all of Aquinas's assurances to the contrary, there is a *determinatio distrahens* that distorts absolutely God's revelatory undertaking, what is revealed to us by God, and the nature of the faith by which Christians submit to His revelation.

Before considering in detail the difficulties encountered by the medievals and the particular solutions proposed by Aquinas to those difficulties, it might be useful to attend to one implication of Aquinas's notion of the Bible. And, to clear what might be a cumbersome and useless problem, it is important to realize that neither for Aquinas nor for his contemporaries was it in doubt that whenever the literal (as opposed to the allegorical or spiritual) sense obtained in the Bible, what the Bible said was historically true to the letter (see I, q. ?, a. ?). In other words, it would be totally anachronical

to project on the medievals our modern sense of historical criticism and our consequent trend to classify as mythical whatever happens to dissonate with our modern sensibility (such as, for instance, the miracles narrated in the Bible) and for which there is no independent historical confirmation. Of course, the medievals were not unaware of the existence of different literary genres within the Bible; they were not tempted, for instance, to take the parable of the prodigal son for an actual historical occurrence. Furthermore, they were aware, too, that many of the ‘truths’ of the Bible, particularly those which referred directly to Yaweh, were necessarily figurative ways of expressing in anthropomorphic language what could not be otherwise expressed. As explicitly stated by St Thomas, when “the arm of God” is mentioned in the Bible what is meant is not a bodily member but God’s power (I, q.?, a.?). In short, saying that the medievals were convinced that whenever the literal sense obtained what was written in the Bible was true does not mean that they thought that every passage of the Bible was historical, but that every passage was true or contained a truth intended by the author within the proper field of the literary genre employed.

But it is important to explore more in depth the sense of the truth of the Bible the medievals had, and Saint Thomas in particular. For Aquinas, as we already know, what the Bible contained was God’s knowledge to be accepted by us as absolutely true on His authority. In this regard, all the Bible and every portion of the Bible was true, because all of it was “God’s word,” that is, “*what God said*,” “*what God stated*.” For instance, the prodigal son’s parable is itself true only in the parabolical sense, that is, in the sense defined by the parabolical literary genre, but that Jesus told that parable is true in the historical sense. Another instance: the psalms attributed to David in the Bible are true in the way in which songs are true (as genuine expressions of David’s love and reverence for God, which give us a model for our own adoration of God), but that David composed and sang those songs to God is true in the historical sense, for it is literally stated in the Bible. Of course, when the literary genre of a biblical passage is strictly narrative (for instance, the sacrifice

of Isaac), then the passage is simply true, though if it involves God's actions it will necessarily be expressed in anthropomorphic, that is, figurative rather than literal, terms.

For the moment, I want to focus on the narrative genre, for it raises particularly thorny problems. Consider the book of Job. Is it a historical book, or rather a protracted parable?

For Aquinas, the issue appeared thusly. A passage of the Bible "is called history when something is simply related" (I, q.?, a.?). By simply related he seems to mean that the passage is related by the author of the Bible, not related by one of the characters of the Bible to other characters of the Bible. For instance, the parable of the prodigal son is not simply related, for the parable of the prodigal son was related by Jesus to other characters of the Bible, in this case, Jesus's audience. But that is not the case of the story of Job, which is therefore simply related. And, for Aquinas, when a passage is simply related, its meaning is "literal or historical." "Literal or historical" sense is "the first signification, by which words signify things" (I, q.?, a.?), that is, it is the primary signification of words, for it is the signification by which words refer directly to the things they signify. Now, since the Bible is supported by God's authority or indirect authorship, "nothing false can ever underlie the literal sense" (ibid.). In fact, this is why, as I remarked above, the biblical psalms as such possess the kind of truth that accrues to that literary genre, but that David composed and sang those psalms is literally or historically true, for in the latter case we are confronted with something that is simply related, and nothing false can underlie what is simply related in the Bible. Thus, for Aquinas who identifies the literal with the historical sense, that is, what the passage means literally with its historical truth, the book of Job which is simply related is historically true. And that is that.

Let us make a step ahead. For Aquinas, truth and falsity are, as they are for Aristotle, qualities that accrue exclusively to judgments, primarily, and secondarily to statements insofar as statements are expressions of judgments. The reason for this is that only judgments

involve an affirmation or negation of what is the case, that is, only when someone judges does he commit himself to the truth of what he judges. In other words, a judgment is a grasp of what is the case as being the case and as a commitment on the part of the judging person to the case being that. Thus, seeing, which is not judging, is neither true nor false, for when I see a prestidigitator bring a rabbit to his hand out of thin air, that is what I see, but that is not what I judge to be the case; only when I judge that to be the case do I commit myself to the truth of what I saw, and only my judgment is true or false. (On this whole question, see Lonergan, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*). If this is so, however, that is, if only judgments are true or false and if the natural expression of judgments is statements, it follows that the Bible is true or false primarily insofar as it makes statements. And that, indeed, is what Aquinas seems to think. For what he means by simply related is simply stated, and that is the reason why he says that only the literal sense, that is, the sense of statements, of the simply related can be the basis for arguments, for arguments are composed of stated judgments, which are necessarily true or false, while parables, psalms, laws, etc., are neither true nor false in the primary sense of truth or falsity.

For Aquinas, then, the first sentence of the Bible—"In the beginning God created heaven and earth"—is simply related and, therefore, literally true. The same is the case with the narration of Abraham's sacrifice (as it was with the narration of Job's adventures). It is important to remark, however, that the first sentence of the Bible is a *statement*, whereas the episode of Abraham is a *story*. Now, *this is a distinction of which Aquinas had no inkling at all*. This is evident from the fact that, for him, literal or historical sense are one and the same sense. But is this correct?

According to Aquinas himself, the literal sense is the only sense from which arguments can be drawn. What Aquinas has in mind by "argument" is not in doubt: it is a rational process by which from premises which are known to be true (be it on the basis of evidence or, as is the case in theology, on the basis of God's authority) a conclusion follows logically which is itself necessarily true. Since

theology is an argumentative science, and theology is Aquinas's central interest, what interests him primarily in Scripture, as a theologian, is the literal sense, for it is the only sense which cannot be underlied by anything false and from which arguments can be drawn.

But it is obvious that from a story, be it historical or fictional, no argument can be drawn, for it is obvious that a story as such, that is, a whole story as a unit, cannot function as a premise. The conclusion we have to draw is that Aquinas is wrong in identifying the literal sense with the historical sense.

But we have to be more precise. What Aquinas means by literal sense is the sense of statements, for the literal sense is the only sense from which arguments can be drawn, and arguments can be drawn only from statements. How then could Aquinas, who was remarkably keen, ever confuse the literal sense with the historical sense? The answer is, I believe, that *at least in the Bible's case, he reduced the historical sense to the sense of statements, that is, to what he called the literal sense, because he understood narrations to be composed of statements.*

Indeed, the *grammatical* form that narrations take is that of statements. That is their "surface" form. And any narration can be broken into a series of affirmative or negative statements whose truth can be disputed out of the narrative context of which they are a part and, if accepted as true, can be used as premises in an argument. For instance, from the statement that God ordered Abraham to sacrifice to Him his son the argument could be built that God's orders do not fall under the constraints of human morality. But the question is whether, as Aquinas seems to have assumed as a matter of fact and as it continues to be often assumed by us, there is such a statement in the Bible—or, what amounts to the same, whether what appears in the biblical narrative under the grammatical form of a statement functions actually as a statement within the narrative within which it appears.

Before attempting to answer this question we have to understand why Aquinas actually took the direction he took in his interpretation of the Bible. As we know from the history of the theological controversy that took place in the XIIIth century, the question was whether the Bible, which was equated with divine revelation, could be accommodated to the framework of an argumentative science of the Aristotelian kind. The answer given by Aquinas was affirmative, since he understood revelation to consist in God's sharing of his *knowledge* with us (and knowledge is a matter of judgments expressed in statements), and faith to consist in an intellectual act of assent to the revealed divine judgments which are absolutely certain by their very nature.

Had the nature of revelation been different, it would not have fitted the strictures of Aristotelian science and theology would have been impossible as a science. But why was Aquinas so sure that revelation was of the nature he took it to be? Because he equated revelation with the content of the Bible, and he took *the Bible for a book whose fundamental literary genre was doctrinal, that is, composed of statements*, since by definition the Bible contained God's revelation and God's revelation, being a transmission of his knowledge, that is, of his infallible judgments, necessarily had to be expressed in statements.

To say that Aquinas took the Bible for a book whose fundamental literary genre was doctrinal amounts to saying that he understood it as implicitly prefaced by the words "This is what God has *stated* to us about himself and about what we need to know for our eternal salvation," for only declarative sentences, that is, either affirmative or negative statements, can properly convey knowledge, be it divine or human. It is not surprising, then, given Aquinas's Aristotelian presupposition, that he would find the Bible in its most fundamental passages to be composed of either simple statements, such as "In the beginning God created heaven and earth," or of long series of statements called narrations.

Is the Literary Genre of the Bible Doctrinal or Narrative?

We may now return to our question whether what appears in the biblical narratives under the grammatical form of statements functions actually as statements within the narrative context in which it appears. One has little trouble understanding the first sentence of the Bible as “God has said that in the beginning He created heaven and earth” as a statement by God, that is, as something which functions not only grammatically but semantically as statement, since it transmits to us God’s own knowledge. But is the story of Abraham’s sacrifice composed of a series of genuine statements, that is, of semantic units that function semantically as statements? Of course, if one approaches the Bible with Aquinas’s preconceived idea that the Bible contains “what God has *said*” (either Himself directly, or indirectly by means of the inspired author), the temptation to hear the story of Abraham as “God has *said*” that “God came to Abraham and told him to go to the mountain and to take a few branches, etc.” is irresistible. But, as a matter of fact, that is not what the text says and means, at all. In the case of the first sentence of the Bible there is indeed a statement, but in the case of the story of Abraham’s sacrifice there is a story, not a statement.

Admittedly, as any other story, this one, too, can be broken into a series of statements, which in a non-narrative context would function as statements, such as “God told Abraham to go to the mountain with Isaac,” and “Abraham went to the mountain,” and “Abraham took Isaac with him to the mountain,” etc. But that is not what the Bible does. The Bible narrates what happened in an encounter between Yaweh and Abraham.

Let us take this from another angle.

The actual recipient of God’s revelation, in this particular case, was Abraham. But, contrary to Aquinas’s notion of revelation, what was transmitted to Abraham was not a statement of God about Himself or about anything else, which would have to be the case if revelation consisted in the transmission of God’s knowledge.

That is what *Aquinas* did in the classroom when he taught the material condensed in his *Summa*. Indeed, in order to teach his students that, say, theology is a science, he raised the question whether or not theology is a science; then, in order to make them realize that the question expressed a real concern, he presented to his disciples the reasons to doubt that theology could be a science; then he explained the reasons that made it evident to him that theology was indeed a science, and he ended by showing his students that the reasons he had originally mentioned to doubt that theology was or could be a science were in fact insufficient. In this way *Aquinas* transmitted to his students a piece of his knowledge about theology. And if his students followed his explanation attentively and were persuaded by it, they came out of the lesson with a piece of knowledge, which they expressed in a statement: ‘Theology is a science,’ which was exactly the knowledge *Aquinas* had and had wanted to share with them. Well, this is *the model Aquinas had in mind for divine revelation and for faith*.

Revelation was a form of classroom teaching. God had certain pieces of knowledge He wanted to share with us. The only difference is that God, unlike *Aquinas* the teacher, did not give us the reasons that would make evident for us the knowledge he transmitted to us, so that we assent to the knowledge transmitted not by virtue of the evidence but by virtue of God’s authority. But how does this apply to Abraham’s case?

Assuming that God wanted to share with Abraham, and through Abraham with us, certain pieces of his knowledge, which were the pieces of knowledge to be transmitted in that classroom lesson?

The Scripture says that God ordered Abraham to go to the mountain. According to *Aquinas*, that is a statement, and since it is a statement of the Scripture whose author is God, we are supposed to believe it, that is, to assent to it on God’s authority. But certainly that was not what Abraham was supposed to believe, for God had so far taught him nothing and made no statement at all; He had just given him an order, expressed under the grammatical

form of an imperative, not of a statement. And an imperative does not express any piece of knowledge to be assented to or dissented from, and susceptible of being either true or false; an imperative expresses an order to be obeyed or disobeyed. And Abraham's faith did not consist in assenting to the statement that God had given him an order, which is something which can only be assented to or dissented from; Abraham's faith consisted in going to the mountain in obedient response to God's order. But this is to say that what was going on in the biblical scene is very different from what was going on in Aquinas's classroom. For in giving an order God was giving an order, not making a statement. Which is to say that if Aquinas read God's order to Abraham as a statement, he misunderstood the passage, for in the passage the words "God ordered Abraham to go to the mountain" do not function as a statement but as an order. To a reader who reads the Bible with Aquinas's Aristotelian glasses it may sound as a statement about God, but neither did God make such a statement nor did Abraham's faith consist in assenting to a statement that neither God made to him nor the Bible makes to us.

The case becomes even more evident if we consider the next biblical sentence: "And Abraham walked to the mountain." Aquinas certainly thought that what he had to believe as a believer was this statement. But certainly Abraham's faith did not consist in believing that he was walking to the mountain, but in actually walking to the mountain in obedience to God's command. The reason is that what appears in the Bible, if the biblical narrative is broken into statements, under the grammatical form of a statement, does not function in the narrative as a statement which expresses a piece of knowledge by God or by the immediate author of the Bible, but as a narration, that is, as a dramatic presentification of Abraham's faithful walking to the mountain in obedience to a divine command, and as a portion of a total scene whose final outcome will be the divine action of stopping Abraham from sacrificing Isaac and of furnishing in his stead a sacrificial lamb. And how a scene of this kind, which is what the Bible is about here, can be taken for a piece of divine knowledge and capable of functioning theologically as a premise in

an Aristotelian syllogism is something that is, to say the least, highly problematic.

With what precedes I do not claim to have firmly established anything. I merely claim that there are very good reasons to suspect that, in his eagerness to read the Bible with Aristotelian glasses and to see it square with the demands of the Aristotelian notion of science, Aquinas may have unwittingly denatured revelation and faith, and that in understanding the narratives of the Bible as collections of statements rather than as narratives, which was a necessary condition for them to fit the mold of an Aristotelian science, he submitted the Bible to a genuinely *distrahens* determinatio.

Chapter 2: Aquinas's Synthesis: Half Aristotelian, Half Christian?

We would incur the risk of badly misunderstanding Aquinas if we are not clearly aware of his theological intentions, of the historical juncture at which he conducted his reflection, and of the particular way in which he conducted it due to the historical juncture at which he happened to work.

Aquinas and the Fathers of the Church

Aquinas was a Christian theologian. As a Christian, Aquinas participated in the living tradition of the Catholic Church—a tradition that both lived the faith and reflected on the faith lived. Aquinas himself lived that faith intensely, and nothing was more important to him than being one of the faithful and belonging to the community of faith.

As a theologian, that is, as a member of the Church with a particular function within it, his task was to carry on the reflection on the faith of the community, the faith of the faithful. The shape in which the Christian reflection reached him was the reflection of the Fathers of the Church, represented very particularly by its most systematic and brilliant expositor, Saint Augustine, whom Aquinas in his theological writings incessantly takes as one of his fundamental points of reference. Nothing could have been farther from Aquinas's theological intentions than to overthrow the reflection of the Fathers on the faith he passionately shared with them and to substitute it for a different one of his own. What he intended was to deepen, to complete, to correct when needed, and to actualize the

reflection of the Fathers; not to do away with it, or even to ignore it. In short, Aquinas saw himself as a further ring in the chain of a long reflective tradition and intended his own reflection on faith to remain in full continuity with that of the Fathers. Hence his reverence for their authority. [He made of the argument from their authority one of the basic tools of the theologian]. Hence, too, his constant care to show the continuity of his results with those of the Fathers, and above all with those of Augustine, whenever possible.

The Aristotelian Revolution

Aquinas's circumstances, however, were very different from those of the Fathers. He happened to live in the thirteenth century, not in the early ages of his Church. This is to say that his reflection on faith was conducted at the historical juncture at which the rediscovered works of Aristotle were exerting a tremendously powerful impact.

It is not easy for us, who live in the twentieth century and under such different cultural conditions, to understand that impact and its revolutionary consequences that were to transform the cultural landscape of the Western world. Just the quick pace at which the bulky and numerous books that compose the Aristotelian corpus were translated into Latin in the course of only fifty or sixty years suffices to give us an idea of the eagerness with which the intellectuals of the time received them. Why this fascination with Aristotle who, after all, is not precisely what one would call an "easy" thinker?

The idea of the early Middle Age as a "dark" period, in terms of its intellectual level, may have been greatly exaggerated, particularly by those for whom, by definition, religious faith is a form of obscurantism. Since practically all the schooling that took place during that period was conducted by the Catholic Church and, for the most part, devoted to the education of her priests, those who identify religion with obscurantism will almost fatally be prone to exaggeration. The fact remains, nevertheless, that, compared to the glorious cultural peaks of ancient Athens and Rome the early Middle Age represents, indeed, a regression. It should not be forgotten, however, that only those who had been schooled by the Church were prepared to

understand and translate Aristotle's works so eagerly—and all of them were clerics. Had their level of intellectual development and openness, which they owed to their schooling, been as “dark” as it is supposed by some to have been, the colossal cultural revolution produced by the introduction of the Aristotelian corpus starting in the late years of the twelfth century would have not occurred. But it did occur. And the word revolution is not too strong to characterize what actually happened. What happened, exactly, and why?

An image may help us. We may compare the Christian culture that prevailed in the ‘civilized’ European world in the twelfth century to a planetary system that gravitated around one sun—the Catholic faith. People understood themselves and the world in terms of the Catholic faith, for they had no other possible way. What the introduction of Aristotle's work brought about was another sun, another gravitational center, another possibility for people to understand themselves and the world. The new sun was reason, as incarnated concretely in Aristotle's views.

What is fascinating in this story, and what explains the medieval intellectuals' fascination with Aristotle's works, is that the new sun did not appear to them as another sun—a colossal mass extraneous to their planetary system with a different and powerful gravitational pull of its own, but rather as a moon of *their* own sun, a moon which had been missing and came to complete and give to *their* planetary system the perfect balance it had lacked until then. Indeed, most of them perceived Aristotelian reason as having a gravitational pull of its own, by which they were powerfully attracted, but a pull that was compatible with, complementary of, in certain ways legitimately independent from, in certain other ways subordinated to, the pull of their faith.

Were the people exposed to the pull of the Aristotelian mass, and who gravitated toward it all the more eagerly in that they saw things in the way I just described, right in their interpretation? Perhaps. In any case, that seems to be what actually happened and why the introduction of Aristotle's works exerted such a powerful impact.

Since our primary interest here is what happened within the field of theology in particular, it may be useful to attempt to put ourselves in the shoes of the theologians of the time. They were—at least the theologians with whom we will be concerned certainly were—people of profound faith. In fact, their very faith favored their enthusiasm for Aristotle. After all, for them, their faith was true, by definition. Thus, if what Aristotle had to say had any grain of truth, it had to be compatible with their faith, for the Creator of the universe could not possibly contradict Himself. If, on the other hand, something, or much, or even all of what Aristotle said proved to be incompatible with their faith, it would be, by the same token, false and would be recognized as such by them. Thus, their very faith protected them against the danger of falling unwittingly or beyond the proper limits under the gravitational pull exerted by the new mass. Moreover, nothing in Aristotle's works necessarily implied that his views were supposed to supplant Christian revelation, to whose benefits he had had no access. If his writings indicated little sympathy for any revelation coming from above, that was understandable and even admirable on the part of someone who had not had the chance of being exposed to the only faith that was true. All Aristotle claimed was that he proceeded on the basis of rational evidence. This, again, was a positive point in his favor, since he had comparatively little to say on matters even remotely related to the revealed truths. At any rate, when he did, he could be easily corrected by those who possessed the true faith, precisely because they possessed the truth in those particular matters, thanks to divine revelation. On the other hand, Aristotle had much to say in purely human matters about which the Christian faith had nothing to say. Would it not make sense to learn from him in these matters which are independent of religion? Finally, the greatness of Aristotle lay, not only in what he had said, but in the way in which he had put human reason to use in order to reach the knowledge he had reached. Would it, then, not be a great idea to learn his method from him, not only to carry knowledge of human matters farther, if possible, than he had been able to, but even to apply his rational method to revealed matters in

order to come to understand them better, insofar as they could be understood?

Such was, it seems to me, the approximate frame of mind in which the Christian theologians, from the last quarter of the twelfth century on, confronted the advent of Aristotle's works. Of this we will find numerous traces in the chapters to come, and very particularly in Aquinas. Their faith itself fostered their enthusiasm. And this explains the eagerness with which they devoted themselves to the study of Aristotle.

Aquinas and Aristotle

Thomas Aquinas was born in 1225, the approximate date at which the question concerning the scientific status of theology was formally raised for the first time, as we shall see later. This is to say that he entered the field of theology at a time when the Aristotelian fire had already taken and was burning powerfully. Because of his early and decided inclination for the clerical life, he was exposed to the fire at a rather early age. And, certainly no less than any of his contemporaries, he liked the heat.

His most admired master, as well as his confrere in the Dominican Order, was Saint Albert the Great. As to where Saint Albert stood concerning Aristotle, there is no room for doubt. Indeed, in the passionate controversy then raging among theologians as to the advisability or even the possibility of integrating Aristotle's views into the theological reflection of the Church, Saint Albert stood unequivocally and enthusiastically for the affirmative answer to those questions. Just as an indicative and picturesque instance, it is worth quoting the rather vehement words in which Albert castigated one of the anti-Aristotelians who had dared to criticize those "who having learned well to speak the spiritual language of theology, speak nonetheless in theological matters the barbarous and corrupted philosophical language" (p. 29, note 3). Here goes Albert's response:

"There are ignoramuses—particularly in the Dominican Order, where nobody checks them—who speaking the blasphemous lan-

guage of obtuse animals *oppose the use of philosophy [in theology]* by every conceivable means.”

“Quidam qui nesciunt, omnibus modis volunt impugnare usum philosophiae, et maxime in Praedicatoribus, ubi nullus eis resistit, tamquam bruta animalia blasphemantes in iis quae ignorant.” (p. 29, note 4).

Aquinas’s own stand regarding Aristotle, though always moderate and almost cold in tone, is no more in doubt than that of his master. Not for nothing does Aquinas in his writings always call Aristotle by the highly honorific title of “*the* Philosopher.” [There is, of course, no article in Latin, but, as is in the nature of Latin, the presence or absence of what we mean by the article is clearly indicated by the context]. Actually, perhaps more so than any other of his contemporaries and predecessors, Aquinas took to heart and carried to its culmination the project of integrating Aristotle’s views into the theological reflection of the Church.

That Aquinas had a highly favorable view of Aristotle is, then, beyond dispute. Equally beyond dispute is the fact that he strongly favored, promoted, and contributed in large measure to carry out the integration of Aristotle’s views into theology. What is disputable and, at least in my opinion, not often understood is what this integration really involved and the kind of consequences it would have. Let us take a first stab at this very complex matter.

Aquinas’s Aristotelian Synthesis

It may be said that the theological task to which Aquinas devoted himself consisted in translating the idiom of faith—that is, the idiom of the Bible and of the theological reflection of the Fathers—into the Aristotelian idiom. But this formulation can do only on condition that we be fully aware of what such a translation from one idiom into the other involved. For it certainly involved much more than saying in new words, that is, in the words used by Aristotle, what the Bible and the Fathers had said in other words. Indeed, if all that was to be borrowed from Aristotle was his vocabulary, and if that is all Aquinas did, it becomes totally unintelligible why there was

so much passion involved in the controversy between Aristotelians and anti-Aristotelians at the time; moreover, such a trivialization of the matter would reduce Aquinas's genius to practically nothing and, thus, render unexplainable the tremendous significance of his work as well as the enormous influence he in fact exerted. Actually, the integration of Aristotle into theology involved much more than a change in vocabulary. What was that much more?

For reasons that cannot become quite clear until we are fairly familiar with at least certain portions of Aquinas's theological works, it is not easy, and perhaps it is simply impossible, to reconstruct securely Aquinas's world-view. For it all depends on whether he really had *one* world-view composed of two halves that fitted with each other harmoniously and without contradiction, or, rather, he had *two* incompatible world-views without realizing it. Needless to say, the two views to which I am referring, or the two halves of the one view, are the Christian and the Aristotelian.

While acknowledging the difficulty of my reconstructive task, then, I will proceed without further ado to offer a characterization of a world-view which, I think, Aquinas would perhaps have legitimately refused to identify with his own, but which at least he could not have dismissed off-hand as an inconceivable, totally wrong-headed attribution. At any rate, this characterization will have the advantage of bringing us to the point of understanding what *might* have actually been involved in translating the idiom of the Bible and of the Patristic reflection into the Aristotelian idiom.

According to this characterization—and if it turns out to be a caricature, certain Scholastics and modern Thomists are responsible for it—*Aquinas's world-view was composed by two harmonious halves, one of them contributed by Aquinas's Christian side, that is, by his Christian faith and tradition, and the other by his Aristotelian side, in the way to be now described.*

In Aquinas's eyes, Aristotle, working on the data naturally accessible to human intelligence and under the strictures of human reason left to its own strength and devices, had contributed an

approximately correct understanding of the human being and particularly of human reason, on the one hand, and of the whole of reality as it is naturally accessible to human reason, on the other hand. This came to constitute one of the halves of Aquinas's world-view.

The other half originates from Aquinas's Christian faith. It is a view of reality as it is accessible to faith. What Aquinas received from his faith was an enlarged understanding both of human reason as capable of reaching through grace what exceeds its natural powers, and of the human being as created, redeemed, and led by the Spirit.

It is to be remarked that the continuity between the two halves that constitute the world-view I am attributing to Aquinas is such that each of them is the complement of the other. Concerning human reason, revelation completes what Aristotle could not know, namely, that human reason aided by God's grace is capable of faith, that is, of 'knowing' in a way that escaped Aristotle, and of knowing certain things that Aristotle could not know. Concerning the rest of reality, again, that is, of what is either already known or at least knowable (indeed, for Aquinas as well as for Aristotle "reality" amounts to "what is knowable"), revelation completes what Aristotle could not know, namely, the reality of a God Creator, Redeemer, and Inspiring, and of the human being as created, redeemed, and led by the Spirit.

This world-view is *ONE* view, though clearly composed of two different halves: what Aristotle knew and taught us, and what God knows and revealed to us. What Aristotle knew was, in this view, for the most part correct, though radically incomplete. In other words, Aristotle knew much about human reason and its possibilities, but not all, and he knew much about the rest of reality, but not all. Thanks to Aristotle, we know, through reason, all that Aristotle knew, and thanks to revelation we know, through faith, what Aristotle did not know.

The two halves match almost perfectly: reason is complemented by revelation while keeping its autonomy within its proper realm,

and the knowledge imparted on us by revelation is complemented by the knowledge we reach through reason, without revelation losing its autonomy within its proper realm. No less important, perhaps, there is, in this world-view, a profound analogy—though by no means anything even remotely suggesting a comparable worth, much less an equality in roles—between *Aristotle and God*. Both of them share knowledge with us, Aristotle through teaching, God through revealing. The former teaches what reason can know naturally, the latter what reason supernaturally elevated by grace can ‘know in faith’, here on earth, and will know in full vision in heaven.

Whether or not this was actually the world-view that Aquinas himself came to have as a result of his contact with Aristotle, which is a point that will be discussed later, it can hardly be denied that this is the way Saint Thomas has been understood by many, particularly among the late Scholastics and the modern Thomists. Hence their elation at the Thomistic synthesis between faith and reason, which preserved the rights of reason without sacrificing faith and the rights of revelation without sacrificing reason, which gave to Caesar what is Caesar’s and to God what is God’s, which preserved the best that Antiquity had produced in terms of thought and truth, which left the pagan Aristotle close to the entrance to Christianity and which, so to say, baptized the Aristotelian system in all the truth it contained. [SEE GILSON, MARITAIN, ETC.]

A Half-Christian, Half-Aristotelian View?

So far we have been considering Aquinas’s world-view in itself. It is time we turn our attention to the process through which *Aquinas* reached it. Indeed, *the world-view of which I have been speaking was not, and could not be, Aristotle’s view, for it involves divine revelation and what we come to know through it, of which Aristotle knew nothing and which he would have rejected. Nor could Aquinas inherit this world-view through the works of the Church Fathers, for they were unacquainted with its Aristotelian half. Whatever the world-view the Fathers of the Church had, if indeed they shared a world-view in common, it certainly was not this one.*

In other words, insofar as this world-view was Aquinas's view, it became his view thanks to a synthesis of two world-views. Either he, or somebody else, or a succession of people achieved the synthesis without which this world-view could not exist. And this prompts us to ask an important question, closely related to the issue of the translation of one idiom into another. The question is the following:

Is the world-view I am attributing to Aquinas a half Christian and half Aristotelian world-view, as it often is assumed to be?

Such an idea presupposes that a world-view is something that exists by itself, whereas in fact, as we just realized, this world-view was the result of an active synthetic process carried out by someone who had to be conversant in two idioms, the idiom of the Christian faith and the Aristotelian idiom. Moreover, *a world-view, in the sense in which we are using this word, performs the vital function of enabling the person who is said 'to have' it to find his or her bearings in life by reference to that view.* Because of this, it is rather difficult, at least for me, to fathom how a world-view can be half-Christian and half-Aristotelian. Aristotle was an Aristotelian, and lived accordingly. The Fathers of the Church were Christians, and lived accordingly. But *neither could Aristotle have lived as the Fathers of the Church while remaining an Aristotelian (that is, given his world-view), nor could the Fathers of the Church have lived as Aristotle while remaining Christians.* In short, the answer that the view I am attributing to Aquinas was half-Christian and half-Aristotelian is unintelligible, for it could not have possibly functioned as a world-view. We have, therefore, to explore the other two possible answers to our question.

A Christian World-View, or an Aristotelian World-View?

Here we are coming to terms with the real meaning and significance of the issue of "idioms" and their translation into one another. *What is meant by "idioms," in the context of the discussion in which we are engaged, is equivalent to "world-views." Translating one idiom into another amounts to translating one world-view into another.*

However, since world-views are not just a matter of words, since they amount to whole systems of conceiving reality and living within it, the word “translating” can hardly do for our purposes, for a world-view cannot be translated into another world-view. A world-view can be enriched by elements of another world-view, insofar as these elements are capable of being transformed and assimilated into it. And, *thus, the question that arises in a concrete case in which there is a synthesis of two world-views, which is the case we are considering, is which was the world-view that prevailed in the synthesis.* In other terms, which of the two world-views involved in the synthesis was the one that incorporated into its own system the elements of the other. Or, to put it as concretely as possible: did Aquinas, in the process of achieving or appropriating his synthesis, christianize certain Aristotelian elements in order to incorporate them into the Christian world-view, or did he rather Aristotelianize certain elements of the Christian world-view in order to integrate them into Aristotelianism?

It is my opinion that *Aquinas himself was totally unaware of the problem as I just formulated it.* And, I consider it to be beyond doubt that his allegiance to the Christian faith was such that, had he been aware of the problem, he would have forcefully expressed his intention of incorporating the assimilable elements of Aristotelianism into Christianity; not the other way around. I am, furthermore, certain that, insofar as he was conscious of having achieved a synthesis between Christianity and Aristotelianism, he thought that he had incorporated the assimilable and valid elements of the Aristotelian world-view into Christianity; not the other way around. Finally, I am certain that the members of the powerful school of thought he was instrumental in creating, known by the name of Scholasticism, who themselves explicitly claimed that Aquinas had achieved a synthesis between Christianity and Aristotelianism, would have said, if confronted with the problem I have raised, exactly the same that Aquinas would have said. For all that, I will maintain that the issue cannot be settled by decree, as it seems to me to have been so far, or by an appeal to Aquinas’s good intentions

and those of his followers; that the issue remains open until one or the other of the two possible answers is shown to be supported by the available data, or until it is shown that the notion of one view composed of two halves makes sense and is supported by the available data; and, finally, that the issue is important enough, not so much because of Aquinas himself but because of the influence he has had, as to bear investigation.

To put my cards on the table—not without much trepidation—at this initial stage of my research, I have a strong suspicion *that in fact Aquinas's synthesis failed. That what he left behind was not a synthesis at all—the kind of world-view composed of two harmoniously fitting and complementary halves I described above—but rather an impossible mixture of Christian and Aristotelian elements that survived in tension with each other and were bound to split in time. That the tension is already detectable and at work in Aquinas's own works. That in the cases in which Aquinas's successors, being less attached than Aquinas himself to the Christian faith than to Aristotelian reason, found unbearable the tension between the incompatible elements, they found themselves forced to sacrifice their faith to Aristotelian reason. That in the case of those who, being as attached as Aquinas was to the Christian faith, found unbearable the tension between the incompatible elements, they found themselves forced to take refuge in a degraded 'Christian' faith that amounted to a blind, purely emotive trust which could hardly be identified with the faith of the Fathers of the Church. That, finally, in the case of those who peacefully lived from Aquinas's failed synthesis, that is, the Scholastics, it tended to result in a kind of bad theology that was Christian only in name, and in a bad philosophy that was philosophy only in name.*

Having squarely put my cards on the table, I proceed to broach *the method to be followed in the coming chapters*. First I will revisit the famous, ardent, protracted controversy that took place among Christian theologians as to the nature of theology. If my thesis is approximately correct, it should throw some light on what was really at stake in the controversy and why it was so passionate. Then I will

examine some of the fundamental positions taken by Aquinas, to show that the tension among incompatible elements is at work in his own works. Finally, I will explore some of the disastrous effects of Aquinas's failed synthesis among his successors.

Chapter 3: From Christian Meditation to Summa Theologica

In the course of the last quarter of the Twelfth century and the first half of the Thirteenth a profound change took place within theology. It is important for our purposes to grasp what that change involved.

The *Summae Theologicae* and the Fathers' Christian Reflection

A practical way of beginning to appreciate the reality of the change, if not immediately its depth and its importance, is to realize that it manifested itself concretely in the emergence and multiplication of *Summae Theologicae*, of which Saint Thomas's own is only one among many others. Nothing even remotely similar to them had previously appeared in the theological landscape.

The *Summae Theologicae* were theological treatises that studied in a systematic way the whole of Christian revelation and Christian life, in which the positions taken on each particular issue by their respective authors were justified by means of argument, and the positions rejected were demonstrated as false or unacceptable also by means of rational argument.

The novelty of this theological approach cannot be appreciated unless one contrasts it with the theological reflection—or should we rather say Christian meditation—of the Fathers of the Church. The Fathers seldom wrote theological treatises properly so called. For the most part, their reflection on Christian revelation and Christian life took the shape of written commentaries on the text itself of the

Bible, and still more often of face to face sermons to the assembled people in the course of which the Fathers explained one passage or another of the Bible. There was nothing particularly systematic to their theological reflection; they just followed the narrative order of the Bible, or took occasion for their public meditation from the particular biblical passage at hand. Much less was there an attempt on the Fathers' part to furnish rational justifications of the views they held. They saw no need to demonstrate the validity of their views because, to start with, they were not aware of having any views of their own. What they were doing, or at least assumed they were doing, was to explain God's word, which they themselves accepted as such unquestioningly, to other Christians who themselves also accepted God's word unquestioningly, by virtue of their faith. Thus the Fathers had no need to prove or justify anything by means of argument, for both they and their audience shared the same faith. In some comparatively rare cases, though—Saint Augustine's *De Malo* is an example—they focussed on one or another issue in particular to refute doctrines that they considered dangerous or gravely erroneous; by the same token, they presented and defended what they took to be the right view, the genuinely Christian view, the view of faith. This sort of writing might, in certain regards, be considered as a theological treatise. If so, however, we are dealing with a theological treatise of a very different kind from that of a *Summa Theologica*. What is different?

First of all, these Patristic 'treatises' dealt only with one or a few issues, whereas the *Summae* aimed at a systematic study of the whole of the Christian faith and the Christian way of life. Secondly, these 'treatises' do not attempt to demonstrate the validity of the particular views held by their authors, for they hold those views by virtue of their Christian faith, and they do not think that God's word needs justification in order to be accepted, or even that it can be justified by purely rational means. What the authors of these 'treatises' do is to show that those who hold a different view have strayed from revealed truth and are, therefore, necessarily wrong. In other words, their authors do not aim at proving or demonstrating

the validity of the views they hold; rather they argue on the basis of the views they hold in faith, whose validity is for them indisputable, since it is nothing else or less than God's word. Insofar, therefore, as the authors of those 'treatises' give arguments, the arguments are not meant to prove the views they hold. They are meant to disqualify the views they reject and *others* hold, either as being different from the views of faith (in case the people who hold those views claim to be Christians), or (in case the people who hold those views are not Christians, and therefore would not care if their views differ from Christian revelation) as being false. For instance, Augustine argues that evil cannot be attributed to God as its author, and that a God to whom evil could be rightly attributed would not be God, certainly not the God of the Christian faith. There is, then, in these 'treatises,' some use of purely rational argument, but it is addressed exclusively to those who do not share the Christian faith.

Saint Anselm: Toward a New Theological Approach

With *Saint Anselm*, in the eleventh century, a transition in the direction of the *Summae* starts taking place. For the first time ever, at least in a deliberate and systematic way, a Christian thinker opens the way to a distinction between the realm of faith and the realm of reason, and attempts to demonstrate by purely rational argument a truth he holds in faith.

As a Christian, Anselm believes that God exists. However, he does not believe that on the basis of any argument, but as part and parcel of his Christian faith. He believes in God's existence without having any merely rational proof for it, and he would continue to believe it even if it happened to be undemonstrable, for his faith does not rest on demonstration but on revelation. However, he inquires whether God's existence can be rationally demonstrated, not in order to believe it, but because he believes it and wants to explore the intelligibility of his faith: "Non enim intelligo ut credam, sed credo ut intelligam." The conclusion of his inquiry is that God's existence can be rationally demonstrated, in such a way that any

intelligent pagan, confronted with Anselm's demonstration, should be rationally constrained to assent to God's existence.

Whether or not Saint Anselm is right concerning the validity of his rational demonstration of God's existence, there is a striking novelty to his approach. What is new in this momentous step is that, for the first time, a Christian transforms what he believes by faith into object of study, that is, of merely rational consideration, and submits it deliberately to the standards of reason.

A fissure has appeared that was not clearly visible before, at least not in the awareness of Christian thinkers. A Christian has faith and has reason. As a faithful, the Christian *believes*. But as a rational creature, he can also apply to the objects of his belief the intelligence received from God and come to *know*. Correlatively, what is divinely revealed can be considered as object of faith and as object of study, that is, of merely rational inquiry that leads to knowledge.

Of course, when the Christian seeks knowledge and takes what he believes as a faithful as object of study, he places himself—at least methodically—in respect of the object of his inquiry (which he otherwise accepts in faith) exactly as someone who does not have faith, for the fact that he has faith cannot count in the process of attaining knowledge. Correlatively—at least methodically—he submits what he believes by faith to exactly the same rational demands that any other possible object of knowledge. In other words, the Christian has entered the field of reason which he shares with those who do not believe—a field in which the arguments given by the Christian will be judged and carry weight according to the standards of reason exclusively, and in which the divinely revealed which the Christian accepts in faith will be submitted to and judged by the same standards as any other object of inquiry.

It bears remarking that, on the part of the Christian thinker who so exposes himself and what he believes, this bold move implies a supreme confidence in the harmony between the realm of faith and the realm of reason. By this I mean, not that *the Christian thinker necessarily expects that all he accepts in faith is rationally demon-*

strable, but that nothing of what can be rationally demonstrated can contradict what he holds in faith, for if that happened to be the case the Christian would find himself in the impossible quandary of having to accept in faith what he rationally knows to be false. At any rate, unless the harmony between the realm of reason and the realm of faith be perfect, Anselm's bold move implies a possible tension in the Christian between what his faith and his reason demand of him.

Both, this confidence in the harmony between the data of faith and the data of reason on the part of those who engage in the direction followed by Anselm, as well as the possibility of conflict between the data of faith and the data of reason are important, as it will appear later. They should, therefore, be kept in mind.

Saint Anselm, however, did not stop at this bold step. He also introduced another change. Having induced—whether consciously or unconsciously—the transformation of what he accepted in faith, that is, God's revelation, into object of study, he could submit it to the demands of reason, not only or even necessarily to demonstrate its truth, as was the case with God's existence, but also to explore its rational implications beyond the limits of faith. Thus, as a concrete instance, in his *Cur Deus Homo?*, Anselm explores such questions as the reasons God could have had to become man, and even whether God would have taken our flesh if Adam had not sinned. *Obviously, this goes beyond the actually revealed, that is, beyond the realm of faith.* Of course, these are questions that can be raised only by believers, but they are nonetheless questions whose answer is to be reached by purely rational means applied to the data of faith, and whose answer, if properly supported by reason, will constitute knowledge rather than faith.

It may be said that Saint Anselm inaugurated the movement toward theology as an independent discipline whose field is constituted by the data of revelation, but which considers the data not as embraced in faith, but rather as object of study to be known insofar as it can be known both in itself and in its rational implications. In this discipline, what is accepted in faith becomes object of study.

It may well be, however, and there are good reasons to think that such was indeed the case, that Anselm himself had no clear idea of the distinction his practice implied between what is embraced by faith and what is considered as object of study, or even that he had effected a transformation of divine revelation into object of rational inquiry. A performance or practice often precedes the realization of its novelty and of its implications.

We will be in a position to appreciate the novelty of Saint Anselm's theological practice by contrasting it with that of the Fathers. For the Fathers of the Church did not treat what they held in faith as object of study, if by this we understand object of merely rational inquiry, but as what it was for them—that is, as object of faith. *The Fathers reflected on their faith as it was for them as faithful*, whereas Anselm reflected on his faith (which he believed as one of the faithful), not as his faith was for him as one of the faithful, but as *object of study, as object of rational inquiry for any rational person*. Another way of putting the same: the Fathers' theology was *Christian* reflection on revelation as revelation; the theology Saint Anselm inaugurates is rational reflection on the data of revelation as object of rational inquiry. Of course, *the theologian gets the data of revelation from his faith*, and without faith he would have no motivation whatsoever to work on those particular data; the fact, nevertheless, remains that the theologian works on them as he would work on any other data subject to rational inquiry. Now, not only was this an extraordinary novelty, but one that was bound to have extraordinary effects when Anselm's practice would be generally adopted, institutionalized in theology, and carried much farther under Aristotle's influence. However, we still have some way to go before we reach the age of the *Summae Theologicae*. For if the *Summae Theologicae* belong within the theological tradition whose beginnings are theoretically traceable to Saint Anselm, in addition they incorporate other changes that took place between approximately the third quarter of the twelfth century and the middle of the thirteenth century. These changes are closely related to the progressive assimilation of Aristotle's philosophical works, rediscovered

and introduced into Western Europe during that period. To those changes we turn now.

Theology Comes of Age

For all practical purposes, Saint Anselm's bold steps exerted little impact on the theological practice. The case would have been different if Aristotle's philosophical works—as distinguished from his logical works, from which Saint Anselm undoubtedly benefited—had already prepared the soil. But that was not the case. Thus, till the middle of the twelfth century, theology remained centered on Scripture and for the most part continued to proceed after the Fathers' example.

A first modification of importance took place then. Though relatively unimportant in itself, this modification undoubtedly contributed to start a process that would accelerate in time. It was introduced in a most innocent way by *Peter the Lombard*, who collected in a more or less systematic way organized by subjects what the Fathers had said about each of the subjects he included in his work. His work was the famous *Liber Sententiarum*, which became very quickly, and remained for a long time, *the* theological textbook. Of course, this innovation involved a certain systematic order in the theological studies which was not to be found in the writings of the Fathers themselves and much less in the Bible. But, in addition, a far more sweeping change took place shortly thereafter with the division of each subject into a number of questions. For *the approach by questions—by quaestiones, as they were called—consecrated and made it a matter of course the shift from the Christian reflection on revelation as revelation to the rational reflection on revelation as object of rational inquiry*. And what characterizes the *Summae Theologicae* that started appearing at the beginning of the thirteenth century was, not only that they incorporated the treatment of the material by subjects, and that they attempted to cover systematically the whole field of theology, as indicated by the very name *Summa Theologica*, but, above all, that each of the subjects

was explored through the method of ‘quaestiones.’ The latter point is so important that it deserves careful scrutiny.

What is what the medievals understood by a “*quaestio*”? A question, of course. But the word, in our context, has a technical meaning. It is the question of a *theologian*, where the word “theologian” is to be understood in the sense inaugurated by the practice of Saint Anselm. This is to say that *it is a question raised by someone who has faith, but who is inquiring about his subject-matter not as object of faith but as object of rational interest, and who is therefore seeking an answer that satisfies the demands of reason and constitutes a piece of knowledge, not an item of faith.* In other words, it is a matter of reaching answers supported by evidence, which when expressed in words will take the shape of ‘reasons,’ which when logically combined will take the shape of ‘arguments’ that ideally will terminate in a rational conclusion to which assent cannot be denied. In other words, it is a matter of strict demonstration, if possible, or at least of persuasive evidence.

True, given the particular subject matter of theology, the argument of authority will continue to have in this discipline a place that it cannot have in any other discipline. After all, theology is primarily an inquiry on what has been actually revealed, and only secondarily on what can be deduced or hypothesized from what has been revealed. The fact remains, however, that *the argument of authority is genuinely an argument*, that is, a rational procedure in the pursuit of knowledge. For, in theology conceived in this way, the result that the argument of authority is meant to produce is intellectual assent—nothing else and nothing less—, and intellectual assent is precisely what any rational argument is meant to produce in any field of knowledge. As Aquinas himself will explain later, authority in theology plays the role played by evidence in other sciences. For what prompts the assent of the practitioners of other sciences is the evidence that supports that to which they assent, and what prompts the same intellectual response on the theologian’s part is the authority that supports that to which the theologian assents. Suppose, for example, that a theologian is working on the subject of

the sacraments, and in particular on the sacrament of matrimony as indissoluble. The “question” this theologian will raise is whether the sacrament of matrimony is indissoluble. How will the theologian reach the answer to his question? By an appeal to Scripture; in this particular case, to Christ’s authority who stated that, in the New Covenant, matrimony is indissoluble. Grasping the authority of Christ that supports the fact that the sacrament of matrimony is indissoluble is what prompts the theologian’s intellectual assent to that fact, much as grasping the fact that a certain gas he is analyzing produces the effects that characterize, say, oxygen, is what prompts on a chemist’s part the assent to the fact that the gas he is inquiring about is oxygen. What the chemist gains thanks to the evidence is knowledge, and what the theologian gains thanks to Christ’s authority is knowledge, which is precisely what the intellectual act of assent yields in both cases, though evidence and authority are very different in nature.

Why go into such elaborate explanation of a rather simple point? Because the point is important. Indeed, *the introduction of the “question” into the theological method, together with the process of rational discourse of which the question is only the first step, manifests the progressive institutionalization of the practice of theology as decidedly a form of rational inquiry and, consequently, of the treatment of revelation not as it stands for the faithful but as it stands for the faithful as a rational inquirer.*

Actually, already at the beginning of the thirteenth century, *the distance and the radical difference between these two modes of dealing with revelation is reflected clearly in the curriculum of the great Universities.* Indeed, there are now two totally independent chairs instead of one. In one of them, the Holy Scripture serves as textbook and its text is read and commentated by the master in a manner reminiscent of the days of the Fathers. In the other, by contrast, taught by the “*lector Sententiarum*,” the textbook is the Lombard’s *Liber Sententiarum*, but frankly treated in the scientific spirit of the *quaestio*. It is, then, a course in which revelation is dealt with as object of rational inquiry, where the master raises his own

questions, takes his own stands, furnishes his own reasons for the stands he takes, and debates the positions of those who disagree with him, much as Saint Thomas will do in his own *Summa*.

Another academic exercise periodically held, called “*Quaestiones Disputatae*,” reflects the popularity of the new theological approach. It is a public debate in which the “lector sententiarum” chooses an issue he wants to settle, discusses it with colleagues and with students of theology from what in modern parlance we would call ‘a scientific point of view,’ and puts an end to the debate by giving his own “*determinatio*,” that is, his personal solution. The way Chenu expresses the character of the master’s *determinatio* makes the point well: “We might say that it is a sort of scientific conclusion grounded on ‘reasons’ and carrying [scientific] authority” (p. 25). The importance taken by this public exercise since the early thirteenth century is also suggested by Chenu: “Albert the Great, Bonaventure, Thomas Aquinas, and already before them William of Auxerre (+ 1231) and Philip the Chancellor (+ 1236) entertained disputed questions” (p. 26). As to the extraordinary popularity gained by the new theological approach, it can be gathered by the following plaintive comment of Roger Bacon’s in 1267:

“... bacularius, qui legit textum, succumbit lectori sententiarum, Parisiis et ubincunque, et in omnibus honoratur et praefertur. Nam Parisiis ille qui legit sententias habet principalem horam legendi secundum suam voluntatem, habet et socium et cameram apud religiosos. Sed qui legit bibliam caret his et mendicat horam legendi secundum quod placet lectori sententiarum. Alibi qui legit sententias disputat et pro magistro habetur. Reliquus qui textum legit, nec potest disputare; sicut fuit hoc anno Bononiae, et in multis aliis locis, quod est absurdum. Manifestum est igitur quod textus illius facultatis subiicitur uni summe magistrali. Sed primo hoc est statutum cuiuslibet facultatis.”

“Nam omnis alia facultas utitur textu suo solum et legitur textus in scholis, quia scito textu sciuntur omnia quae pertinent ad facultatem. Quia propter hoc sunt textus facti, hic longe magis, quia

textus hi de ore Dei et sanctorum allatus mundo, et est ita magnus quod vix sufficeret aliquis lector ad perlegendum eum in tota vita sua, secundum quod magis legunt. Deinde sancti doctores non usi sunt nisi hoc textu; neque sapientes antiqui, quorum alios vidimus, ut fuit dominus Robertus episcopus Lincolnensis et frater Adam de Marisco et alii maximi viri...; et tunc legebatur aliquando, sicut liber Historiarum solebat legi, et adhuc legitur rarissime. Et mirum est quod sic est exaltatus liber sententiarum, quoniam liber Historiarum est magis proprius theologiae” (Chenu 27, note 1).

The analysis of the consequences entailed by these changes will have to be left for a later chapter. For the moment, our purpose is to follow the evolution we have been studying through its culmination, which was reached with the *Summae Theologicae*.

The Aristotelian Revolution

By the early years of the thirteenth century the teaching of theology by “*quaestiones*” was already the well-established method practiced in the leading centers of learning, particularly in the most distinguished Universities—Paris, Oxford, and Bologna. One may wonder why the field of theology changed so little immediately after Saint Anselm, and started changing so much and so rapidly by the second half of the twelfth century. The answer seems to be: because the change was not prompted by Saint Anselm’s works but by the philosophical works of Aristotle.

Through Boetius Aristotle’s *Categories* had gained currency in Western Europe since the century. I have already indicated that Saint Anselm undoubtedly benefitted from the integration of that aspect of the Aristotelian corpus into the theological culture of his time. A long time would elapse, however, till the bulk of Aristotle’s works would enter Western Europe and begin exerting their influence. Starting late into the twelfth century, first the second part of the *Organon* (Analytica, Topica, Elenchi) and then the rest of the Aristotelian corpus reached Europe’s consciousness. It may be said without exaggeration that they created a tidal intellectual wave and produced what cannot be characterized but as a genuine cultural

revolution. For our limited purposes and oversimplifying a highly complex matter, it will suffice to consider a few of its effects that are of special interest.

One of them, undoubtedly, was the clear consciousness acquired by the people who became familiar with the Aristotelian works of what the use of reason left to its own strength, that is, unaided by any revelation, was capable of accomplishing. Another no less important effect is that it brought to the full consciousness of intellectuals, and certainly of theologians, the distinction between revelation and reason. Thirdly, given the impressive results achieved by Aristotle, theologians, no less than those who worked in other fields of knowledge, could not help but being overwhelmed by the desire to incorporate into their respective fields the use of the reason whose power Aristotle's works had revealed to them. This explains much of the rapid evolution that took place in theology in the two centuries we have been studying. Not all of it, however, and not fully. For the assimilation by the medievals of the Aristotelian corpus was not limited to the rational structure of the Aristotelian approach; they also assimilated, and no less eagerly, much of the substance of the Aristotelian system and, particularly, of his epistemology. And for our purpose it is necessary to get at least a general idea of those components of the Aristotelian system whose assimilation into theology had significant effects. One of the components is the Aristotelian notion of science. Another is the Aristotelian taxonomy of the sciences. Finally, the Aristotelian notion of the human being.

The Aristotelian Notion of Science

Scientia, in one of the main acceptions in which Aristotle uses the word, is synonymous with knowledge. But what Aristotle calls knowledge is much more restrained than what we call knowledge in our everyday parlance. Actually, it is rather close to what today we would call 'scientific knowledge,' for two reasons. First, it is the kind of knowledge that results from the grasping of compelling evidence that the case is so as it is stated to be. In other words, Aristotelian "knowledge" results from a rational process that involves

understanding and discursive thinking; not from guessing, wishing, or believing. Either it is reached rationally, or it is not the knowledge that Aristotle equates with science. Secondly, what Aristotle means by “knowledge” is explanatory knowledge. A mere collection of facts is not “knowledge” in the Aristotelian sense, for facts explain nothing; on the contrary, they are in need of explanation. Aristotelian “knowledge” is, as the medievals translated it, “*knowledge per causas*,” that is, knowledge that explains what needs explaining because it involves genuine understanding of its object.

An already constituted science is a corpus of knowledge about the object of the science. The knowledge embraced by a science is expressed in true statements, which in their turn are expressions of judgments. What characterizes these statements, *in the ideal case*, and, therefore, what characterizes the judgments of which the judgments are the expression, is, in the first place, not only that they are true, but that they are necessarily true, for they are not true by chance but because they express the judgment of a person who has rationally compelling evidence to judge that the case is as judged and stated. Secondly, the statements that constitute a science are universal statements. They are universal because what the statement states as true applies to all the possible particular cases. A statement that expresses knowledge of a particular case or of a few particular cases as such is not a scientific statement, is not part of a science, in Aristotle’s sense, even if it is true, for it lacks the universality that characterizes scientific statements. Thirdly, the statements that constitute a science are statements about what is *necessarily* the case, for they express the grasp by the judging person of the essential traits of the object of the science, which will therefore necessarily be the same in all particular cases, in all particular places, and at all particular times. In fact, it is this grasp of the *essential* traits that Aristotle means by knowing “*per causas*.”

A further important point. As already remarked, a constituted science consists of statements and only of statements. Why so? Because only statements express judgments, and judgments are the only human acts of which truth and falsity can be predicated, the

only human acts which involve a truth-claim. Fears, desires, etc. are neither true nor false, nor do they involve any truth-claim whatsoever. Only judgments are and do.

I have been referring to *the ideal case* of science. This implies that all the judgments that constitute that corpus of knowledge have been grasped as being necessarily true by virtue of their rationally compelling evidence. But this grasp may obtain in two ways: either by immediate intellectual vision, as is the case with the “principles” of the science, or by means of a discursive process which leads as a necessary conclusion to the necessary truth of a statement which is not self-evident or evident in itself. Thus, to give a *merely suggestive* example, the basic axioms of Euclidean geometry are self-evident and neither need nor can be proven otherwise than by grasping their necessary truth in their very self-evidence, whereas each of the statements that express theorems is the result of a discursive process that leads to the grasp of its being necessarily true. In the ideal case of science, then, all the judgments that compose the science have been grasped as being necessarily true, either through their immediate self-evidence or through discursive reasoning. But it is important to realize that not all aspects of reality lend themselves equally to their scientific apprehension and, consequently, that not all sciences can realize or even approximate the ideal in the same degree. This point will be more clearly seen when we come to the Aristotelian taxonomy of the sciences and will be of interest when we discuss Aquinas’s idea of theology as a science.

A last characteristic of the Aristotelian notion of science that needs to be alluded to here is that a science is constituted by an orderly and systematic constellation of statements. In other words, there is, so to say, an internal logic to a science, by virtue of which all the statements which constitute it are interconnected and hierarchically ordered, for they express a synthetic understanding of the different aspects of the object of the science. To give an example, Euclidean geometry starts with axioms, which play in it the role of principles, and proceeds from the simpler to the more complex in its presentation of the theorems, so that the whole constitutes the

unified, interconnected, synthetic system we identify as “Euclidean geometry.”

The Aristotelian Taxonomy of Sciences

I now come to the Aristotelian map of the sciences. In fact, Aristotle traces—or, rather, gives rough indications of—several different maps in different places of his writings, depending on the matter he is considering and the particular standard he is using at the time. In a first map, the supreme place is occupied exclusively by “metaphysics” or what Aristotle himself calls “first philosophy.” It occupies the top because, its object being Being as such, metaphysical knowledge is the most universal of the sciences. Indeed, because metaphysical knowledge is explanatory knowledge of all actual or possible reality as such, it pervades all the other sciences insofar as their respective objects are real. All the other sciences, compared to metaphysics, are particular, in that their respective objects of study are restrained. In addition, by virtue of the very degree of abstraction at which the metaphysician works, which is the highest degree of abstraction, the universality and the necessity of his judgments—which is, as we know, what constitutes knowledge as knowledge—, as well as their explanatory power, are the highest, in Aristotle’s view. In this map, therefore, metaphysics occupies alone the supreme place, and all the other sciences are inferior and subordinated to it.

There is, therefore, one Aristotelian hierarchical map of the sciences from the point of view of their universality, certitude and explanatory powers. However, Aristotle traces, or at least suggests, two other maps that interest us.

Aristotle classifies or hierarchizes the different sciences by the standard of the dignity of their respective particular objects. In this hierarchy, at least implicitly, the science of God, that is, of the Causa Prima, occupies the top and a level all of its own. But there is also a hierarchy among the other particular sciences, and in this sub-hierarchy the science of the human being as human occupies

the place of choice, then the sciences that deal with other animates, and finally the physical sciences.

The third map establishes a hierarchy among the sciences according to the degree to which they can approximate the ideal of science with which we began. The determinant division here is between the theoretical and the practical sciences. Theoretical sciences, *grosso modo*, are those that aim at the pure intellectual satisfaction that the possession of knowledge produces and which, if and when fully successful, terminate in full and perfect knowledge of their respective objects, the contemplation of which is the highest human aspiration. Needless to say, in this map, again, metaphysics comes at the top. Mathematics would most probably qualify as second, given its peculiar degree of abstraction and its epistemic advantages, and the other particular theoretical sciences—the science of the human being as human, the sciences of the other animates, and the sciences of the inanimates—would occupy a third level. But there would be in this map a fourth and lowest level occupied by the “practical sciences.” The reason for this comparative inferiority is, in Aristotle’s eyes, double. On the one hand, the purpose of the practical sciences, as indicated by its name, is practical. In other words, unlike the theoretical sciences, their aim is not contemplative fruition of knowledge, but action. And since, in Aristotle’s eyes, the ideal science is the one that aims at pure knowledge whose contemplation is the ultimate aspiration or goal of the human being, it is only natural for Aristotle to place the practical sciences that lead to action rather than to contemplative knowledge at the lowest echelon in the hierarchical map of the sciences. In addition, the practical sciences barely deserve the name of science, since the knowledge obtained by its practitioners is only true “for the most part.” The most important practical sciences are ethics, which deals with individuals, and politics, which deals with societies. And it is clear to Aristotle that, because such sciences necessarily have to deal with the particular and take place and time into account, the conclusions reached in those disciplines cannot compete with the theoretical sciences in terms of certainty, universality, necessity,

and explanatory power. The ‘knowledge’ obtained in the practical sciences is knowledge only in a feeble analogical sense and barely deserves the name of knowledge, for in those fields different people will make different and even conflicting judgments about the same object, and also will make different judgments in different societies, or even within the same society at different times.

Some Aspects of Aristotle’s View of the Human Being

The last aspect of the Aristotelian system we need to consider, however briefly, concerns his idea of the human being. From the logical point of view, Aristotle sees the human being as falling with animals under the same logical genus, but constituting a different and unique species because of its rationality. From the ontological point of view, he sees the human being as composed of two substances—the body and the soul or *anima*. The two together, however, constitute only one being—a human being—because the soul is the sole substantial form or principle of operation of the whole, from which all the activities of the human being either proceed directly or to whose direction they are subordinated. It is, therefore, on the study of this principle of operation that Aristotle concentrates in his *De Anima*, the name under which the medievals translated Aristotle’s treatise on the human being as human.

Oversimplifying very heavily again, the Aristotelian soul has two characteristic activities which manifest two distinct faculties: the intellect and the will. The intellect’s function is intellective or cognitive. Its role is to know whatever can be known—that is, what is actual or possible, “being” and “beings”—through true judgments (of which we already spoke above). In other words, the intellect is naturally orientated toward being as knowable. The will, by contrast, is an appetitive rather than cognitive faculty, for it desires or tends toward the being apprehended by the intellect, not under the aspect of its being knowable but under the aspect of its being good or rationally desirable. Between these two faculties there is a hierarchy, for the will is subordinated to the intellect in two ways. First, since the will is not by itself a cognitive faculty, it can only

desire what is known through a cognitive faculty, and it can only desire rationally what is known through a rational faculty, namely, the intellect. Second, the supreme or ultimate goal of the human being is to attain the highest good, which is the contemplative fruition of the knowledge of what is knowable; in this way, too, the will is subordinated to the intellect, in that *the highest good it can desire and pursue is knowledge, to which the desire and pursuit of all other goods ought to be subordinated. Not without reason, therefore, has Aristotle's view of the human being been characterized as intellectualistic.* Indeed, other views of the human being are possible, and have actually been proposed by other philosophers (starting with Plato), in which neither is the intellect distinguished from the will in the Aristotelian manner, nor is the supreme goal of the human being to attain knowledge. The fact is, however, that the views assimilated by the medieval theologians with whom we are here concerned were Aristotle's views. And this brings us to the conclusion of this chapter.

Aristotle and the *Summae Theologicae*

For our quarry throughout it has been the novelty of the phenomenon of the emergence and multiplication of the *Summae Theologicae* in the thirteenth century. And now we can understand it fully. The *Summae* both incarnate a new way of practicing theology, and, at the same time, present the results achieved through the new method. And because both the way of practicing theology as well as the theological knowledge achieved in that way are very deeply marked by Aristotle's influence, they could only emerge at the time that Aristotle's works became known and started creating a colossal cultural wave.

The *Summae*, then, are concrete attempts at practicing theology *scientifically*, understanding this term in its Aristotelian sense. Because of this, they differ at least in tone, in structure, and in scope from the Fathers' Christian meditation. Had the Fathers, even the most philosophically alert of them, had the opportunity to become acquainted with Saint Thomas's *Summa Theologica*, the least one

can say is that they would have had a very hard time understanding it. Assuming, however, that they had reached that point, the interesting question for our purposes is whether or not they would have found Aquinas's undertaking in harmonious continuity with what they themselves had done, and would have recognized their Christian faith in the faith presented by Aquinas in his *Summa*, as Aquinas certainly assumed they would. Of course, the answer to these questions is closely related to the answer to be given to the fundamental question I raised previously: *Did Aquinas baptize Aristotle, to the extent that Aristotle's views can be baptized, or did he rather—not only unintentionally but unwittingly—distort the Christian faith to accommodate it to the heterogeneous demands of the Aristotelian system?* A rapid examination of the controversy that raged in the thirteenth century concerning the possibility of assimilating the Aristotelian views into theology will contribute to prepare us to tackle these problems.

Chapter 4: On the Scientific Character of Theology

As we already know, the triumph of Aristotelianism in the theological schools of the great European universities, from which it filtered down and spread in time, took place between the fourth quarter of the twelfth century and the middle of the thirteenth. The process, however, was not a smooth one, by any means. Not only were there many who strongly opposed what they perceived as a radically unacceptable theological change, but even some of the very people who went along with the Aristotelian wave and actively contributed to the assimilation of Aristotle's views and method into theology had serious reservations about the change they themselves were contributing to bring about. In this chapter I intend to follow the process through which theology ended up with a place on the map of the Aristotelian sciences, and to examine the objections raised—as it turned out, futilely—against such a result.

One common characteristic of the *Summae Theologicae* from about 1225 on is that they open with the question whether theology is a science. Alexander de Hales is most probably the theologian who inaugurated this practice (Chenu p. 37, note 4) in his teaching and later integrated it into his *Summa*. He will constitute our starting point.

Alexander de Hales

Astonishingly, from the very way in which de Hales develops his answer to the question “*utrum [doctrina theologiae] sit scientia*” (is theological doctrine a science?) it becomes evident that what he un-

derstands by “*doctrina theologiae*” is, not the text of his own or other *Summae*, but the text of the Holy Scripture. I find it astonishing, for it would seem rather difficult, at least for twentieth century people, to ask seriously whether the Scripture is a scientific work in any sense, given its literary genre. Indeed, the Bible is clearly not a work of inquiry, that is, it does not aim at knowledge reached by means of supporting evidence compelling rational assent. Be it as it may, the basis on which de Hales answers his own question is the analogy he finds between the Bible and Aristotle’s *Prima philosophia*. According to him, the Bible is, by the nature of its object, which is God, superior to Aristotle’s *Prima philosophia*, which deals with being as such. Now, Aristotle placed the science of being at the top of his taxonomy of the sciences because of the dignity of its object, which is the cause (in Aristotle’s sense) of the objects of all the other sciences. For this reason, rather than calling *Prima philosophia* by the common name of science, Aristotle called it by the special name of “wisdom” (*sapientia*). Thus, argues de Hales, because the object with which the Holy Scripture deals is God, who is the cause of all causes and the effect of none, the Holy Scripture can properly be considered as the supreme *sapientia* or wisdom.

It would seem, at first sight, that de Hales has answered his own question affirmatively and considers the Bible as a scientific work comparable and even superior to Aristotle’s *Metaphysics*. He makes, however, two significant remarks concerning the difference between Aristotle’s supreme science and the Scripture, which should give us second thoughts. He observes, in the first place, that Aristotle’s *Prima philosophia* addresses the intellect, while the Bible addresses what we might call ‘the heart,’ for it “moves” its reader to love and fear God. Secondly, Aristotle reaches the knowledge conveyed in his *Prima philosophia* by means of logical reasoning that renders evident or demonstrates what Aristotle says and, therefore, compels the rational assent of his reader, whereas the Bible does not proceed in this way. Thus, though the Bible, in a sense, deserves the highest place as a *Sapientia* in the Aristotelian map of the sciences,

in another important sense it does not belong there at all. Here is de Hales's conclusion in answer to his question:

"Theologia igitur quae perficit animam secundum affectionem movendo ad bonum per principia timoris et amoris, proprie et principaliter est sapientia. Prima philosophia, quae est theologia philosophorum, quae est de causa causatorum, sed ut perficiens cognitionem secundum viam artis et ratiocinationis, minus proprie dicitur sapientia. Ceterae vero scientiae, quae sunt de causis consequentibus et causatis, non debent dici sapientiae, sed scientiae." (Chenu, p. 39).

De Hales's constitutes the first formal or explicit answer ever given to the question whether theology can qualify as a science and deserves a place among the Aristotelian sciences. Because it is the first answer it deserves special attention.

Concerning the Aristotelian influence on theologians, we find ourselves at an already advanced stage of that influence. Indeed, the question raised clearly refers, under the name of *scientia*, to Aristotle's notion of science, and this presupposes a high degree of familiarity with Aristotle's works on the part of the author and of his audience. But this is not to say enough. Actually, the very way in which the question is asked shows that de Hales is interested in finding a place for theology within the Aristotelian framework rather than in finding room for the Aristotelian notion of science within the framework of the Christian view, for it is Aristotle's views on science which are taken as the point of reference by which the worth of theology is to be determined, rather than the worth of the Aristotelian view of science being determined by theology. Now, this is a first, powerful indicator that the idea that what took place at the time was an assimilation of the Christian view to the Aristotelian one rather than the other way around may not be totally groundless.

Secondly, at least at this point, the question is raised in a highly equivocal way. For, as we just saw, what de Hales is really asking is not whether the result of the intellectual elaboration carried out by the theologian on the data of faith can qualify as an Aristotelian

science, that is, as scientific knowledge, but whether the content itself of the Holy Scripture can be considered as scientific knowledge. Obviously, this confusion of theology with divine revelation is, or at least may be, an equivocation with grave consequences, if not clearly dispelled in the further elaboration of the question by the authors of other *Summae*. And the fact is that it will not be dispelled. The theologians we will study will refer equivocally, under the name of *sacra doctrina* (or other similar names, such as de Hales's "*doctrina theologiae*"), sometimes to divine revelation (usually identified with the Bible's content), sometimes to the intellectual elaboration by the theologian on the data of faith—which is quite another thing and what at least today we understand by "theology." The same equivocation will plague Aquinas. As Chenu remarks concerning de Hales, in the first place, and then his successors,

"... on s'aperçoit que 'doctrina theologiae' veut dire en realite (et Alexandre emploie effectivement le mot, art. 4) 'sacra scriptura.' De fait, c'est bien de la revelation et de son contenu qu'Alexandre etudie l'objet et les caracteres... Ce n'est que peu a peu que *doctrina sacra* s'etendra a deux choses, *de maniere indifferenciee*: la revelation elle-meme, puis l'effervescence intellectuelle qu'elle suscite...; *et le mot conservera alors son equivocate technique jusque dans la langue de Saint Thomas*" (p. 38. My emphasis).

My last comment is in reference to de Hales's own answer to the question he raises. It amounts, for all practical purposes, to saying that the revealed word of God, that is the Holy Scripture, cannot possibly qualify as an Aristotelian science for at least two reasons: because it does not follow the Aristotelian approach that leads to what Aristotle calls knowledge, that is, to judgments reached on the basis of rationally compelling evidence, and because by its nature it is not meant to satisfy the purely intellectual desire to know, which is what Aristotelian "knowledge" does, but to move us to love and fear God. Thus, to add, as de Hales does, that the Holy Scripture is a superior Sapiaientia than Aristotle's *Prima philosophia* is really incongruent. For it boils down to comparing apples to oranges and, while denying that they have anything in common, since one is

revelation and the other knowledge, to declaring nonetheless that apples are superior to oranges. What de Hales could and should have concluded is, rather, that revelation and reason constitute radically different, totally heterogeneous orders between which no comparison is possible, and, thus, that neither can revelation be judged by the standards of Aristotelian reason, nor can the products of Aristotelian reason be judged by the standards of revelation. Or, more concretely, that it is as absurd for the Christian theologian to evaluate the Bible by the standards of Aristotelian reason, as it would be absurd for the Christian theologian as such to evaluate Aristotle's *Prima philosophia* by the standards of Christian revelation.

Such, indeed, would seem to be the unavoidable conclusion *if* theology is identified with the revealed word of God, which is what de Hales did. But what if it is identified with the intellectual elaboration on the data of faith? Can theology, in that case, qualify as an Aristotelian science? The answer to this question will depend on what other medieval theologians understood by "theology" when they raised the question whether theology is a science. And we will have to wait for that answer, for there is another important aspect of de Hales's views which we have not explored yet.

De Hales identifies theology with the Scripture. However, given that the Scripture is a book or a collection of books that do not address the intellect alone but rather move us to love and fear God, he asks indirectly whether the particular literary genre of the Scripture, so different from that of the *Metaphysics* of Aristotle, does not impose on the theologian a totally different approach than that demanded of the philosopher as Aristotle conceives the philosopher. His concrete question is whether the Scripture follows the scientific method, that is, the Aristotelian method: *An modus sacrae Scripturae sit artificialis vel scientialis?* (Chenu, p. 40). His answer, translated into contemporary language, is that the literary genre of the Bible is radically different from the literary genre of, say, Aristotle's *Prima philosophia*. The Bible proceeds by way of narratives, metaphors, images, examples, exhortations, commands,

etc., and, thus, it “moves” us, whereas Aristotle proceeds as a rational inquirer by way of definition, argument, discursive reasoning, and logical conclusion, and, thus, it addresses the intellect. As a consequence, the theologian’s approach to the Scripture has to be different from the approach of the philosopher. What the Bible conveys is God’s revelation, not what Aristotle calls knowledge, and what the theologian has to look for is being moved by God’s revelation, not the knowledge the philosopher looks for to satisfy his intellect. (Chenu, p. 40).

De Hales’s point is that if the Bible is not a book of science but a book of revelation, as he had already suggested in the first part of his chapter, then, correlatively, theology is not a scientific endeavor, a rational inquiry meant to attain knowledge, which is what he points out now. The Christian scrutator of the Scriptures is not engaged in a scientific endeavor, but in a religious one. This seems to imply that the attempt to read and treat the Bible as a scientific book, when already its literary genre so obviously demands a different reading and treatment, would amount to misunderstanding it totally. Equally, the attempt to transform theology, which is a religious endeavor, into a scientific one might not only denature theology—that is, the traditional Christian scrutiny of the Scripture—but might result in a hybrid discipline that is neither religious nor scientific, a discipline whose conclusions might not qualify as scientific since they involve elements of faith, and might not qualify as matters of faith either since they supposedly constitute knowledge.

Why have I devoted so much attention to de Hales’s treatment of the question whether theology can qualify as an Aristotelian science, though his views happened to be shortly superseded by other views that ended up carrying the day? In the first place, because in inaugurating the practice of raising the issue of the scientific status of theology he contributed powerfully to strengthening the already widespread longing to find a niche for Christianity in what appeared to be the map of the truth. The fact that all the future *Summae Theologiae* after de Hales’s, Aquinas’s included, followed his practice witnesses to the influence he actually exerted. Secondly, because,

though for all practical purposes de Hales's answer to the question is negative, he nonetheless opened the door to the hope of an affirmative answer by asserting, however incongruously, that *doctrina theologiae* is a *sapientia*, that is, of the same kind as Aristotle's *Prima philosophia*. Thirdly, because the reasons that led de Hales not to identify *doctrina theologiae* with either a scientific text or with a scientific endeavor, contain in a nutshell the explanation of the resistance opposed to the assimilation of Aristotelianism into theology that we will presently study. Finally, because the consideration of those reasons will furnish us the opportunity to realize what was really at stake in the assimilation of Aristotelianism, and thus to understand what the triumph of Aristotelianism consecrated by Aquinas's work really represented.

The Reluctant Non-Aristotelians

It is a common place among modern admirers of Saint Thomas —ETIENNE GILSON being one of the most outstanding—to view those who resisted the avalanche of Aristotelianism as obscurantists or fideists radically opposed to rationality in general. Such a view, in my opinion, is wrongheaded. For the fact is that many of the very people who actually contributed to the final triumph of Aristotelianism in theology, starting with Alexander de Hales, were among those who expressed grave reservations based, not on an irrational conservatism, but on a deep understanding of their Christian faith. Whether or not they were right, their voices deserve to be heard, were it not but in order to understand what really was at stake in the final triumph of Aristotelianism.

Is de Hales an obscurantist? He evidently possesses an at least passable knowledge of Aristotle's views on science and is open enough to the Aristotelian current then gaining force as to inquire whether there is any room for divine revelation within the Aristotelian framework. At the same time, however, he is a Christian who reads the Bible as a Christian, that is, he understands the Bible as God's word. He finds—probably much to his regret—that the Bible and the Aristotelian scientific undertaking belong in radi-

cally different and irreducible orders. Does he arbitrarily invent this radical difference out of the blue? By no means. Aristotle's philosophical works aim at and yield knowledge. The Bible does not demonstrate anything; it reveals. Aristotle's works address the intellect, exclusively; the Bible talks to the heart, moves the Christian to love and fear God. Even the most cursory examination of Aristotle's *Metaphysics* and of the Bible shows that their literary genres are different and irreducible to each other and have, therefore, to be approached in radically different ways. Theology, therefore, cannot legitimately—and ought not attempt to—become a scientific discipline. Are these the reservations of an obscurantist blindly opposed to progress, or rather the serious reasons of a reluctant non-Aristotelian?

At any rate, de Hales was by no means the only one to express reservations of this sort. A number of theologians, no less eager than him to assimilate Aristotelianism, found themselves constrained nonetheless to rein their enthusiasm, for the same reasons and for others. What did they have to say?

William d'Auxerre (+ 1231), of whom de Hales was the most distinguished disciple [SEE P. 60], opened the way to the assimilation of Aristotelianism into theology. In the preface of his *Summa Aurea* (1220) [see p. 34], he struggles to understand the theological endeavor in which he himself is engaged. He makes the first step toward the future formulation of the question whether theology is a science—though he himself did not ask the question explicitly—by pointedly justifying the use of rational argument in theology.

Which are the grounds for this justification? In the first place, insofar as the faithful are concerned, rational argument helps to confirm what they embrace by faith, without doing away with their faith (for their faith rests on God's authority, not on the reasons that confirm their faith). Furthermore, the use of reason leads the faithful to the understanding of what they believe, as well as to the defense of their faith against the attacks of the heretics. Finally, con-

cerning the non-Christians of good will, the use of rational argument may contribute to open their spirits to faith.

“Triplici ratione ostenditur fides. *Prima* est quia rationes naturales in fidelibus augmentant fidem et confirmant....Cum autem habet quis veram fidem, et rationes quibus ostendi possit fides, mens non innititur primae veritati propter illas rationes, sed acquiescit potius illis rationibus quia consentiunt primae veritati et ei attestantur.” (p. 35).

“...fides est illuminatio mentis ad videndum Deum et res divinas, et quanto magis illuminatur, tanto clarius videt anima non tantum quod ita est sicut credit, sed quomodo ita est, et quare ita est ut credit; quod est *intelligere*” (ibid.).

“*Secunda* ratio est defensio fidei contra hereticos.”

“*Tertia* est promotio simplicium ad veram fidem.”

D'Auxerre goes even farther. Not only is the use of rational argument legitimate in theology, but there is an analogy between the role played by the articles of faith in theology and the role played by the self-evident principles in Aristotelian science:

“Quarto modo dicitur fides *argumentum non apparentium* propter articulos fidei qui sunt principia per se nota... quoniam si in theologia non essent principia, non esset ars vel scientia. Habet ergo principia, scilicet articulos...” (p. 59).

Yet, this Christian so evidently open to the powerful Aristotelian current, realizes nonetheless that there is a radical difference between the Aristotelian *scientific* principles and the articles of faith. For the former are self-evident, whereas the latter are assented to in faith on the basis of God's authority and, therefore, are not genuinely scientific:

“Habet ergo principia, scilicet articulos, qui tamen solis fidelibus sunt principia, quibus fidelibus sunt per se nota, non extrinsecus aliqua probatione indigentia” (p. 59).

As a consequence, d'Auxerre balks at treating divine revelation as object of rational inquiry. Like de Hales, who closely followed him on this issue, he thinks that divine revelation belongs in an order that transcends the order of reason and, consequently, demands a special approach:

“Propeter hoc bene dictum est a quodam [Simon of Tournai, about 1090 (p. 35, notes 2 and 3)], quoniam apud Aristotelem argumentum est ratio rei dubiae faciens fidem; apud Christum autem argumentum est fides faciens rationem.”

As to the appropriate approach to revelation, given its radical difference from the Aristotelian order, d'Auxerre is rather vague:

“Volentes ostendere rationibus res divinas, ex convenientibus rationibus procedemus, non ex eis quae sunt propriae rerum naturalium; ideo enim decepti sunt heretici, quia rationes proprias rerum naturalium volebant applicare rebus divinis.” (pp. 31-32).

What exactly d'Auxerre has in mind when he speaks of the reasons or reasoning that are appropriate when one deals with revelation is far from clear. From one passage one gathers that what he rejects is rational demonstration of the revealed, for that would do away with faith and its merit; moreover, it would contradict what Saint Paul says about faith:

“... Dicit Apostolus, Hebr. II, quod fides est *argumentum*, supple probans, non probatum, et non conclusio. Magistri ego, imo etiam sancti Patres, perverse videntur agere, cum rationibus humanis nituntur probare fidem vel articulos fidei, cum fides secundum Apostolum sit tamquam probans non probatum, argumentum non conclusio. Videntur etiam evacuare meritum fidei; quia dicit Gregorius: Fides non habet meritum ubi humana ratio praebet experimentum...” (p. 34, note 1).

But, then, how does this square with what d'Auxerre said about the uses of rational argument in theology? How else is the faith of the faithful going to be rationally confirmed if it is not through demonstration? And how else are the non-Christians of good will

going to be attracted to faith? I, for one, doubt that he had a clear answer to these questions. What cannot be doubted is that, in spite of his justification of the use of reason in theology, d'Auxerre rejects the right to treat divine revelation as object of rational inquiry. He may not be capable of articulating clearly the reasons for this refusal, but refuse he does.

Eudes Rigaud, who in 1245 succeeded de Hales as “regent” of the school of the Franciscan Minors in Paris [p.41], does not go any farther than d'Auxerre and de Hales, basically for the same reasons. In his *Quaestiones* (circa 1245) [see p. 62], he raises the issue “*utrum theologia sit scientia*” [p. 63]. Following d'Auxerre, he establishes the analogy between the articles of faith and the Aristotelian scientific principles, but also the dysanalogy between them. Following de Hales, he calls theology a “*sapientia*.” He goes even further than the latter in the Aristotelian direction, in that, explicitly accepting the use of deductive reasoning in theology, he speaks of the conclusions reached by the theologian. Realizing, however, that both the articles of faith and the conclusions reached by the theologian are dependent on faith rather than on rational evidence, he concludes that theology is not a science in the Aristotelian sense (*scientia simpliciter dicta*) but “a science of faith” (*scientia fidei*):

“Igitur theologia quantum ad acceptionem illarum dignitatum, quae menti hominum sunt impressae, quas etiam ab aliis scientiis non mendicat, dicitur sapientia quasi cognitio altissimarum causarum; sed quantum ad conclusiones ex illis principiis illatas est scientia, unde simpliciter et necessario oportet illas credere; sed ratione cognitionis illarum suppositionum attenditur acceptio fidei. Ulterius quantum ad conclusiones consequentes ex illis suppositionibus est scientia non simpliciter, sed fidei, quia illas supponit” (p. 63).

The school of theology of the University of Paris was not alone in its attempt to assimilate Aristotelianism. A similar struggle was taking place on the other side of the Channel. Fishacre, who occupied the chair of theology at Oxford from around 1236 to 1248,

struggled, too, with the issue of the scientific status of theology, though less directly and in a less sanguine way than others of his contemporaries. Like de Hales, by whom he clearly is influenced, he identifies theology with the Holy Scripture. And, like de Hales, he sees the Scripture as a sort of *sapientia* superior to all the Aristotelian sciences. More pointedly, however, than de Hales, he zeroes in on a reason for this superiority, namely, the certitude of what the Scripture says, which is far greater than that of a scientific demonstration: “Minimum et incertissimum hujus scripturae verbum certius est conclusione certissimae demonstrationis” (p. 48). This point should not be forgotten, for we will find it again when we come to Aquinas. For the rest, Fishacre agrees with de Hales, and specifically with his view that the Scripture is not a scientific work because it does not follow the Aristotelian scientific procedure: “Non decurrit a premissis ad conclusionem.” Again, the resistance to the Aristotelian wave is not prompted by obscurantism but by a rather convincing reason.

Kilwardby, who succeeded Fishacre at Oxford in the chair of theology and occupied it from 1248 to 1261, underscores the difference between divine revelation (that is, Scripture) and the scientific endeavor. In both we find truth, but in one there is truth by revelation, in the other by discovery that involves rational heuristic steps:

“Duplex est modus scientiae. Unus divina inspiratione, alius humana inventione... Ab utriusque haurit veritatem. Sed veritas huius scripturae tantum desuper hausta est per inspirationes, non per rationes. Aliae autem humana investigatione inventae sunt. Et ideo istae scientiae quae humana ratione perquirunt verum, necesse est definire, dividere et colligere.” (p. 51).

Again, then, the persuasive objection raised by de Hales and repeated by others against the scientific character of theology, at least when it is understood as divine revelation, prevails against the allure of the Aristotelian wave.

But, then, asks Kilwardby, how is this compatible with the current scholarly exercise of *disputationes magistrales*, which obviously

proceed by rational argument that leads to conclusions supported by evidence but “not contained in the canon”? This is extremely interesting, for here he is clearly speaking of theology understood as rational elaboration on the data of faith. Unfortunately, Kilwardby’s answer is extremely superficial and does not add anything to the justification of the use of reason furnished long before by d’Auxerre. Theology, he says, does not really need this kind of inquiry; it uses it simply because it happens to have the good effect of confirming the truth of faith: “Hoc facit non propter hujus scientiae necessitatem sed propter aliorum infirmitatem, videlicet ut affectus infirmorum iuvetur et roboretur fidelium et informetur affectus perversorum saltem mediante aspectus illuminatione. Unde non facit hoc quia ille modus sit necessarius sacrae scripturae, sed nobis” (p. 51).

What, then, is Kilwardby’s final stance concerning the scientific status of theology? It is very similar to de Hales’s. The latter, going against the conclusion that his own premises imposed, had left the door open to the possibility of considering *doctrina theologiae* as a science by equivocating on the Aristotelian word *sapientia*. As for Kilwardby, he does something equivalent by applying the word *scientia* to the Bible. There is, however, an important difference between the two. Whereas de Hales does not seem to have realized that he was using “*sapientia*” in a very different sense than Aristotle, Kilwardby is perfectly aware that he is using the word *scientia* in a totally different sense than Aristotle. And his mastery of Aristotle’s is such that it leaves him no room for illusions as to the possibility of accommodating divine revelation to the strictures of the Aristotelian framework. Indeed, as he pointedly argues, the content of the Bible has nothing at all to do with the sort of universal and rationally necessary judgments and with the kind of logical reasoning that are essential constituents of what Aristotle calls *scientia*. Thus, the Bible is as little a work that Aristotle could have accepted as scientific as Aristotle’s *Prima philosophia* is a work that a Christian could identify with divine revelation. In Kilwardby’s own words,

“Theologi et sancti scitum dicunt omne quod mente cognoscitur, sive credatur sive videatur; sed Aristoteles nihil dicit scitum nisi

conclusionem causaliter demonstratam, et hoc requirebat necessitas doctrinae quam docebat. Quia enim humana ratio investigando non invenit verum nisi decurrendo a termino ad terminum per medium, et hoc non est universaliter possibile nisi ab universali ad aequae universale verum particulare, propterea posuit scientiam esse habitum conclusionis et ab universalibus exire; et quia non est certa cognitio in humana inventionem, nisi fuerit causa, medium, et necessaria causa talis effectus, ideo dixit scientiam esse ex hiis quae non possunt se aliter habere, et esse demonstrativam et causalem. Principiorum autem cognitionem non posuit huiusmodi esse, nec debuit; et illam vocat intellectum, quia certa sunt ex se luce veritatis propriae, praeter universalia praecedentia vel causas demonstrativas.

“In theologia igitur, quia non est facta notitia humanae inventionis, et dico de canone Biblicae, sed divina inspiratione, non oportet illam esse ex universalibus. Et quia certa est ex ipsa veritate per se quae intra inspiravit eam, non oportet esse ex aliquibus praemissis universalibus causis vel demonstrationibus, quae nequeunt aliter se habere. Unde illae rationes de Aristotele sumptae nec contingunt sacram scripturam, nec usquam locum habent nisi in scientiis humana investigatione inventis” (p. 52).

The Anti-Aristotelians

I have called the theologians so far studied “reluctant non-Aristotelians.” One senses, indeed, that all of them, having been exposed to the rational appeal of Aristotle’s works, are eager to find room for theology within the Aristotelian vision. Yet, their very Christian understanding of revelation and faith prevents them from doing so. They are not, by any means, anti-Aristotelians; they are, reluctantly, non-Aristotelians. By contrast, the people whose voices we will hear now, are definitely opposed to the Aristotelian avalanche that is already overcoming the European universities.

The word avalanche seems appropriate to characterize what the influence of Aristotle did in the space of a few years and what disturbed so much the anti-Aristotelians already in the early years

of the thirteenth century. In the courses of philosophy, where, understandably, the text itself of the Holy Scripture has no direct role to play, Aristotle's texts are all the rage; what the Aristotelians find unacceptable is that matters of faith are vivisected according to the Aristotelian method and evaluated by the Aristotelian standards. Moreover, after such training, the students arrive to the study of theology already sold to Aristotle's system and Aristotle's ways. To topple this, in the schools of theology the chair of Scripture is relegated to the worse places and times, and those who teach that course are neither honored nor listened to. In striking contrast, the course of what we might call today speculative theology substitutes the Scripture with *Summae Theologicae*, deals with *quaestiones* that have little to do with the Scripture, treats revelation as any other object of rational inquiry, reaches conclusions that are not matters of faith, gets allocated by the authorities of the universities to the best places and times, and those who teach that course enjoy not only popularity among the students but also the respect and favor of those in authority.

This is the situation that the anti-Aristotelians find scandalous and try desperately to correct. Already before the end of the twelfth century, [THE BISHOP?] Stephen of Tournai informs the Pope that, in the courses of theology,

“...novas recentesque summulas et commentaria firmanitia super theologia passim conscribunt, quibus auditores demulceant, detinenat, decipiant, quasi nondum suffecerint sanctorum opuscula patrum, quos eodem spiritu sacram scripturam legimus exposuisse, quo etiam composuisse credimus apostolos et prophetas... Disputatur publice contra sacras constitutiones de incomprehensibili deitate... Individua Trinitas et in triviis secatur et discrepatur...” (pp. 29-9).

Jean de Saint-Gilles, the first Dominican professor at the University of Paris, reacts bitterly in 1231 against the intrusion of Aristotelianism in theology:

“Quando tales veniunt ad theologiam, vix possunt separari a scientia sua, sicut patet in quibusdam qui ab Aristotele non possunt in theologia separari, ponentes ibi auricalcum pro auro, scilicet philosophical quaestiones et opiniones” (p. 29).

Eudes de Chateauroux, chancellor of the University of Paris from 1238 to 1244, laments the invasion of theology by the Greek philosophers to whom theologians have “sold themselves” (p. 29).

And, in 1247, as [PAPAL?] delegate, he condemns the Parisian practice of using in theology an approach that has its proper place in the domain of philosophy (p. 30).

Oxford is no different from Paris. Robert Grossetete, himself one of the translators of Aristotle, writes a letter to the faculty of theology, around 1240, condemning the abuse of relegating to a poor second place the study of the Scripture itself, as well as the approach employed by theologians, “which does not follow the practice of the Fathers and of tradition” (p. 28, note 1).

It was in this climate that, already in 1228, Pope Gregory IX had addressed a heart-felt letter to the faculty of theology of the University of Paris, in a futile attempt to stop the Aristotelian avalanche. He complains about “the adulterous mixture” of philosophical doctrines with faith, and about a reduction of faith to reason that renders faith “more or less useless and superfluous,” and does away with the merit of faith, “for faith can have no merit if it is demonstrated by human reason” (pp. 29-30). Obviously, the Pope’s appeal had little impact and failed to contain the irrepressible Aristotelian passion of theologians either in Paris or elsewhere.

The litany of complaints of the anti-Aristotelians continued, nevertheless, uninterrupted until well into the second half of the thirteenth century, that is, until the time when, due in no small part to Aquinas’s genius, the Aristotelian tide finally carried most everybody. I will quote only one late voice, that of Roger Bacon. In 1267, in another portion of the text already cited in a previous chapter,

he decries the displacement suffered by the text of the Scripture in favor of the new methods:

“Item, impossibile est quod textus Dei sciatur propter abusum libri sententiarum. Nam quaestiones quae quaeri deberent in textu ad expositionem textus, sicut fit in omni facultate, sunt iam separatae a textu... Et ideo qui legunt textum non exponunt eum, quia non quaerunt quaestiones proprias et necessarias textui intelligendo” (p. 28, note 1).

Bacon repeats the same in his *Compendium studii theologici*:

“Quamvis autem principalis occupatio theologorum deberet esse circa textum sacrum secundum est, ut probatum est multipliciter in priori parte, quod tamen a quinquaginta annis theologi principaliter occupati sunt circa quaestiones, quod patet omnibus per tractatus et summas..., non sic circa sacratissimum textum Dei: propter quod proniores sunt theologi ad recipiendum tractatum de quaestionibus quam de textu” (p. 28, note).

From the quotations I have given of the anti-Aristotelians one might get the impression that their resistance was of the purely fideistic kind, since, unlike the non-Aristotelians, they do not seem to give arguments for their resistance to the assimilation of Aristotle into theology. But that is not so, in fact. What differs is simply that the arguments of the anti-Aristotelians are less formalized, for they constitute an appeal “ad hominem,” as it were, to theologians who share with them the same faith. That the rational approach they follow differs from that of the Fathers of the Church, that it separates the issues from their scriptural context, that there is little or no place for the text itself of the Holy Scripture in their studies—these are genuine arguments that should give pause to those who identify themselves as members of the Church and perform a teaching function within it. Given that the “reluctant non-Aristotelians” had already given powerful reasons against the assimilation of Aristotelianism into theology, there was no point for the Aristotelians to repeat their arguments, for they were widely known; alluding to them was sufficient. Thus, for instance, in mentioning that an

approach that is legitimate in purely philosophical matters may not be so in theology, Eudes de Chateauroux, addressing himself to theologians who are perfectly familiar with the works of d'Auxerre and de Hales, has no need of saying more.

Only Bacon, I think, adds something new to the arguments of the non-Aristotelians. For he suggests (in the text quoted in a previous chapter), that when the theologians sold to Aristotle deal with Scriptural texts, they do not understand them as portions of a narrative work, which is the way the Bible is meant to be read and used to be read (“sicut liber Historiarum solebat legi”), and (in the texts quoted in this chapter) he points out that this misunderstanding of the Bible is an unavoidable effect of the method of *quaestiones*. We will have to remember this important remark when the time comes to evaluate the arguments for and against Aristotelianism in theology. Presently, however, in order not to interrupt the progress of this chapter, we will proceed to listen to the voices of the full-fledged Aristotelians, represented at their best, perhaps incidentally, by Saint Bonaventure, more insistently and systematically by Saint Thomas Aquinas.

The Aristotelians

It may be surprising to some readers to see Saint Bonaventure, the DOCTOR MELIFLUUS, classified among the Aristotelians. Certainly, such works of his as the *Itinerarium*, where love of the biblical text, symbolism and personal piety play such an important role—and those are the works through which the DOCTOR MELIFLUUS is particularly known and got his distinctive title—can hardly be considered as Aristotelian in any conceivable sense. It should not be forgotten, however, that in his COMMENTARIUM IN SENTENTIAS? (1250-1254) Bonaventure was the first, even before Aquinas, to define the theological undertaking as genuinely scientific and different from the Christian reading of the Scripture. In so doing, he undoubtedly made one of the most important contributions to the assimilation of Aristotelianism into theology, whatever

else he may have done or written. To that work, exclusively, I will be referring here.

Bonaventure does not ask directly whether theology is a science. He is studying the Lombard's *Liber Sententiarum*.

His question concerns what today we would call the literary genre of *that* book, which obviously is very different from the literary genres found in the books of the Bible: "Quae causa formalis quive modus procedendi sit in his libris Sententiarum" (p. 54, note 2). The question itself is raised in terms of the Aristotelian notion of "formal cause," which is an indicator that Bonaventure has in mind Aristotle's views on science. What Bonaventure is asking comes to this: What is distinctive in the way in which the Lombard proceeds, which makes of his book a theological book rather than any other kind of book, and so different, in particular, from the biblical books? Bonaventure's answer is that, unlike the Bible, which contains or exemplifies such different literary genres as "revelativus, praeceptivus, orativus, symbolicus, etc.," the Lombard's book exemplifies only one particular genre: "modus procedendi est perscrutatorius et inquisitivus." In other words, the Lombard's undertaking is clearly scientific; it aims at obtaining knowledge—nothing else. The point becomes even more clear if, with Bonaventure, we further ask what exactly is the role played by the author in the case of the *Liber Sententiarum*: "Quae sit causa efficiens sive auctor hujus libri" (p. 54, note 1). In the case of the Bible, the real author, as Aquinas will later say following the use of his times, is God. But certainly, as Bonaventure realizes, God did not inspire the Lombard's book. Nor is the Lombard's book a mere repetition of the text of the Bible, not even a mere repetition of the commentaries of the Fathers on the Bible. The Lombard is not a mere compiler or collector of the sentences of the Fathers. He is a real author of a very distinctive book that aims at gaining knowledge, a theological book for whose insights and possible mistakes the Lombard is responsible. What the Lombard writes is not revelation; it is theology, that is, human knowledge concerning matters related to God, reached through rational means.

If this interpretation is correct, Bonaventure is the first of the medieval theologians to distinguish clearly between the text of the Bible understood as God's revelation and the intellectual elaboration on the data of faith. The former is revelation; the latter, theology. Moreover, on the basis of that distinction, he also is the first to answer the question whether theology is a science with a definite and unequivocal "yes." Am I interpreting Bonaventure correctly? What he has to say about the specific subject-matter of theology suffices, I think, to dispel any reasonable doubt:

"Possumus et unico vocabulo [subjectum theologiae] nominare: et sic est *credibile* prout tamen *credibile* transit in rationem *intelligibilis*, et hoc per additionem rationis; et hoc modo, proprie loquendo, est subjectum in hoc libro" (p. 55).

For Bonaventure, then, the subject-matter of theology is what is revealed by God and object of faith (*credibile*), *but under the specific modality of its intelligibility*, and this transformation takes place because of the rational approach employed by the theologian (per additionem rationis). Such, in particular, is the case with the Lombard's book. And, lest we be confused, Bonaventure, in reply to an objection, pointedly makes the distinction between revelation as object of faith (*credibile ut credibile*) and revelation as object of rational treatment (*credibile ut intelligibile*). Actually—and very sagaciously—Bonaventure makes a previous distinction concerning revelation, for revelation can be understood either as it is when God reveals directly, or as it comes to us through the Bible. (This seems equivalent to the nowadays common distinction between "revelation" and "inspiration"). The former possesses directly and immediately the authority of God who is Himself the Truth and the source of all truth (*habet in se rationem primae veritatis*); to Him the faithful give their immediate assent (*propter se*), and that is what faith primarily is (*pertinet ad habitum fidei*). The latter, that is, revelation as identified with the content of the Holy Scripture (*pertinet ad doctrinam sacrae scripturae*), has the special characteristic of being authorized by God (*super rationem veritatis addit rationem auctoritatis*). By contrast, the *credibile* that is the subject-

matter of theology is characterized by its being object of rational inquiry rather than of faith (addit rationem probabilitatis), as is the case with the Lombard's book, where reasons are given to prove or demonstrate faith. In this way it becomes clear how faith in God (fides de credibili), the Holy Scripture (libri de canone sacrae scripturae), and a theological book like the Lombard's (praesens scriptura) differ.

The text is so important, and so important, too, that my interpretation be checked against Bonaventure's own words, that full quotation is in order:

“Credibile enim, secundum quod habet in se rationem *primae veritatis*, cui fides assentit propter se et super omnia, pertinet ad habitum fidei; secundum quod super rationem veritatis addit rationem *auctoritatis*, pertinet ad doctrinam sacrae scripturae, de qua dicit Augustinus quod ‘major est ejus auctoritas quam humani ingenii perspicacitas’; sed secundum quod supra rationem veritatis et auctoritatis addit rationem *probabilitatis*, pertinet ad considerationem praesentis libri, in quo ponuntur rationes probantes fidem nostram. Et sic patet quomodo differenter est fides de credibili, et libri de canone sacrae scripturae, et praesens scriptura” (p. 55).

Bonaventure now has an answer—how valid remains to be inquired in a further chapter—to an objection that had been raised by many an anti-Aristotelian irritated and saddened by the fact that the *Summae Theologicae* had displaced the Scripture in the study of theology at the universities. The objection boiled down to the following: If, obviously, the text of the Scripture is not a scientific text (for it does not use the approach characteristic of the books that purport to convey knowledge), how can the *Summae* that purport to convey “knowledge” DISPLACE SOMETHING TOTALLY DIFFERENT, NAMELY, REVELATION? Bonaventure's answer, based on his distinction between Scripture whose subject matter is object of faith, and theology which aims at knowledge, comes as a reply to an objection:

“Modus procedendi in parte scientiae debet esse uniformis modo totalis scientiae; *sed modus procedendi in sacra scriptura est typicus et per modum narrationis*; cum ergo liber iste [WHICH ONE?] pertineat ad sacram scripturam, non debet procedere inquirendo” (p. 56, note 1).

In short, the Scripture uses symbolism and narration (and such other literary genres as exhortations, prayers, commands, etc.) because it conveys revelation, not knowledge, whereas the books of theology use the approach typical of rational inquiry because they are scientific books that aim at knowledge.

This may well explain why the literary genres of the Scripture, on the one hand, and of the books of theology, on the other, are so different, as remarked by a number of non-Aristotelians and Anti-Aristotelians. But, I submit, it does not explain at all why theology has displaced Scripture from its central place in the curriculum, since by definition theology is a totally different and independent endeavor. How can the Christian reading and commentary on the Scripture, which had previously occupied the central place in the curriculum, be legitimately substituted by a discipline that, avowedly, is different and independent from revelation? Might not, then, the anti-Aristotelians have had quite a point in rejecting such displacement? The least that can be said for the moment is that Bonaventure’s notion of theology as a scientific endeavor tends to strengthen the anti-Aristotelians’ position.

Moreover, from the sharp distinction carved by Bonaventure between revelation and scientific theology other important questions arise. Are the results of theological inquiry to be taken as matters of faith? Does not theology, in proving or demonstrating what the faithful accept through faith, do away with faith and its merit? What, in fact, are theologians: people who believe, or people who know?

Bonaventure grounds his answer on a detailed analysis that applies to the particular case of theology Aristotle’s views on the subordination that exists between certain sciences. His analysis is all the more noteworthy because Aquinas will refer himself to the

same Aristotelian theory of subordination. Bonaventure calls the subordination of one science to another by the latin name of *subalternatio*, as will Aquinas later. According to Aristotle [in the chapter on immediate propositions, *Post. Anal.* lib. I., ch. 2, 72 a 14-20, and in the chapter on the difference between demonstrations quia and propter quid, *Ibid.*, ch. 13, 78b 35-39; CF. CHENU, P. 72, NOTE 1], a science is subordinated to another when it takes certain of its basic principles from that science without actually demonstrating them or verifying directly their self-evidence. Thus, as an example used by Aristotle himself [WHERE?], medicine is subordinated TO MATHEMATICS BECAUSE IT USES MATHEMATICAL PRINCIPLES (AT LEAST IN ARISTOTLE'S VIEW), WITHOUT MEDICINE HAVING AS ITS PROPER TASK TO DEMONSTRATE OR VERIFY THEM, FOR THE PHYSICIAN IS NOT A PROFESSIONAL MATHEMATICIAN. In this case, there is subordination properly so called of the medical science to mathematics, that is, genuine *subalternatio*, for the validity of the results reached in the medical science depends on the validity of the mathematical principles used in the medical science. There is, however, another case of merely apparent subordination, because the *apparently* subordinated science *really* changes the meaning of the principles it borrows from the subordinating science by transferring them, as it were, to a different order of meaning—or, to use more modern expressions, to a different “game” (Wittgenstein), or to a different “paradigm” (Kuhn). Now, according to Bonaventure, the latter is what happens in the case of theology in relation to revelation. Theology is a scientific endeavor—a matter of obtaining by purely rational means what Aristotle calls “knowledge.” It is true that theology borrows its fundamental data from revelation. But the orders of revelation-faith and of scientific inquiry-rational assent are radically heterogeneous, that is, constitute different “games,” different “paradigms.” There is, in Bonaventure's language, a *determinatio distrahens*, a shift of paradigms, in the passage from the regime of faith to that of science. *The revealed truths borrowed by theologians do not function within the theological “game” as revealed truths but as objects of inquiry;*

thus, theology is not related to faith by ties of real subordination. Revelation is revelation; theology is a science, not revelation, “because what we embrace in faith we embrace because of [divine] authority, but what we understand we owe to reason” (p. 56, note 2). Here is Bonaventure’s analysis:

“Liber iste [Lombardi] ad sacram scripturam reducitur per modum cujusdam subalternationis, non partis principalis; similiter et libri doctorum qui sunt ad fidei defensionem. Quod patet sic: quia non quaelibet determinatio trahens in partem facit subalternationem scientiae, set determinatio quodam modo *distrahens*. Nam scientia de linea recta non dicitur subalternari geometriae, sed scientiae de linea visuali, *quoniam haec determinatio quodam modo trahit ad alia principia*. Quoniam igitur sacra scriptura est de credibile ut credibili, hic est de credibili ut de facto intelligibili, *et haec determination distrahit*—”nam quod credimus debemus auctoritati, et quod intelligimus, rationi“—, “hinc est quod sicut alius modus certitudinis est in scientia superiori et inferiori, ita alius modus certitudinis est in sacra scriptura et alius in hoc libro; et ideo alius modus procedendi...” (EMPHASIS ET SUBQUOTATIO] (p. 56, note 1).

With admirable lucidity, as already suggested by the last part of the quotation, Bonaventure seems willing to assume all the consequences of having so radically distinguished theology from revelation. Thus, his answer to the first of the questions raised above is categorical: the conclusions reached by theologians are not themselves matters of faith, because science and faith constitute different “games” or “paradigms.” Hence, the Lombard’s book, being a theological, that is, a scientific book, has to be judged on its own rational merits—that is, by the same standards Aristotle would use to judge any of the scientific conclusions reached in the field of any of the sciences that figure on his map. Again, consistent with himself, Bonaventure also answers that the knowledge reached in theology does not do away with faith and its merit, for the realms of faith and Aristotelian reason constitute different “games” or “paradigms.”

All of a sudden, alas!, the consistency of Bonaventure falters. What if the Christian theologian reaches rationally a conclusion that contradicts his faith? Bonaventure's answer is that the theologian can—and should—fall back on his faith (p. 56, and note 3).

But does Bonaventure realize that, if faith and reason constitute different “games” or “paradigms,” there is no possible contradiction between them? Obviously not. Moreover, he affirms that the conclusions reached in theology do not do away with faith or with its merit, since the orders of revelation and of theology are radically different. This is perfectly consistent with Bonaventure's denial of a real subordination of theology to revelation. But, then, how can he matter-of-factly state, as he does, that the conclusions reached in theology increase the delectation (*delectatio*) of faith? After all, if theology does not have anything to do with faith, for it is a radically different game, it also follows that it can contribute nothing to the “game” of faith—not even an increase in its *delectatio*.

Be it as it may, that is where Bonaventure stands. He has placed theology, at least to his satisfaction, on the Aristotelian map of sciences. But the price he would have had to pay for it is admitting that faith has nothing to say to reason, and that reason has nothing to say to faith. This is a consequence that we will have to examine very carefully in the next chapter. At any rate, Bonaventure, who obviously does not quite realize that this consequence is entailed by the removal of theology from the regime of revelation to the regime of science, balks at it—however illogically. Will another Aristotelian, Saint Thomas Aquinas, solve more satisfactorily the difficult and rather momentous problems involved in launching theology into the Aristotelian scientific orbit?

For Aquinas's complete and fully mature answer to the question whether theology is a science we will have to go to his *Summa Theologica*. But first we will explore a couple of his earlier works, where some of the seeds that will ripen in the *Summa* are planted.

In the PREFACE to his Commentary of the Lombard's *Liber Sententiarum* (1254) [SEE P. 42] Aquinas deals, as Bonaventure

was doing at about the same time, with the difference in the literary genres of the Scripture and of theological works. Quoting Boetius's principle "*Eruditi hominis est de unaquaque re, prout ejus natura exigit, sermonem habere*" (an intelligent person speaks the language required by the nature of the thing at stake), he applies it to the Scripture, on the one hand, and to the theological work, on the other. Scripture employs such literary genres as narration, metaphors, arguments, commands, exhortations, etc., whereas the literary genre exemplified in theological works is the argumentative genre, exclusively. Saint Thomas explains the variety of biblical literary genres by the fact that the Scripture is a book of revelation, not of scientific inquiry:

"Principia hujus scientiae sunt per revelationem accepta; et ideo modus accipiendi ipsa principia debet esse revelativus ex parte infundentis, ut in visionibus prophetarum, et orativus ex parte recipientis, ut patet in psalmis. Sed quia, praeter lumen infusum, oportet quod habitus fidei distinguatur ad determinata credibilia ex doctrina praedicantis..., oportet modus istius scientiae sit narrativus... etc." (p. 66, first quotation).

This formulation is highly confusing. Indeed, the opening words, "the principles of this science are received from revelation," suggest that Aquinas is speaking of the subject-matter on which the theologian will proceed to elaborate intellectually. It turns out, however, that the "scientia" to which Aquinas is referring is the Holy Scripture, for the rest of the paragraph deals with the literary genres of the Bible. What Aquinas seems to mean, in this connection, is that the Bible is a work that contains God's revelation and the response of the faithful to it. Hence, its fundamental literary genre is both "revelativus," on God's part, and "orativus," on man's part. Aquinas adds, however, rather incongruously in my opinion, that, since faith cannot be faith without something in particular being believed, the Bible has to be a narrative.

Unfortunately, things do not get any better in Aquinas's treatment of the issue of literary genres. He observes that a number

of other literary genres—or should we call them sub-genres?—are found in the Bible: “narrativus, symbolicus, argumentativus, praeceptivus, comminatorius, promissivus, etc.” (p. 43). Most of these, with the exception of the “argumentativus,” are not primarily conceptual. Why did God express His revelation in such forms rather than, say, in mere plain statements? The answer given by Aquinas is that God’s revelation accommodates our human nature, which cannot reach the intelligible directly but only through the mediation of the sensible. This is rather odd, for two reasons. First, since the theologian is human, too, and speaks to other human beings, one would expect that Aquinas would say that the same variety of literary genres found in the Scripture should be employed by the theologian, for the theologian no more than anybody else can reach the intelligible directly but only through the mediation of the sensible. Yet, of all the literary genres employed in the Scripture, the only one that the theologian will use is the argumentative one. One hardly sees why it should be so. Second, the argumentative genre differs from all other literary genres in that it is purely conceptual, that is, it addresses only the intellect; but of course it addresses the intellect by means of sensible words, no less than any other literary genre. Why, then, should the Bible employ a variety of literary genres, if the argumentative one is no less accommodated to our nature than the others? In short, I find it very difficult to understand why exactly Aquinas excludes from theology all literary genres except the argumentative one. But that is what he does, for good or bad reasons. Actually, I suspect that the unnoticed reason why Aquinas privileges the argumentative genre is that it is the only literary genre that can accommodate the demands of Aristotelian science. In other words, if theology is to be placed on the map of the Aristotelian sciences, its literary genre has to be argumentative. At any rate, since the issue of literary genres will be taken up again by Aquinas in the *Summa*, there is no point in lingering on that issue now.

More interesting is the systematic way in which Aquinas, in his Commentary of the Lombard’s book, develops the analogy suggested by d’Auxerre between the articles of faith and the Aristotelian

scientific principles. His treatment of this analogy reveals Aquinas's mastery of Aristotle's views. He compares the "lumen infusum," thanks to which the articles of faith are believed, to the "lumen intellectus agentis," by virtue of which Aristotelian principles become self-evident (p. 64, first quotation, and p. 65, first quotation). In addition, Aquinas carries the analogy between the articles of faith and the scientific principles farther than any of his predecessors; for, in his view, though the articles of faith do not possess for us now the self-evidence of Aristotelian principles, they will possess it when we come to contemplate God face to face in heaven:

"... Ad secundum dicendum quod termini principiorum naturaliter notorum sunt comprehensibiles nostro intellectui: ideo cognitio quae consurgit de illis principiis est visio; sed non est ita de terminis articulorum. Unde in futuro quando Deus videbitur per essentiam, articuli erunt ita per se noti et visi sicut modo principia demonstrationis" (p. 65, third quotation).

A last important point. Following Rigaud's traces, Aquinas explicitly acknowledges the use of deductive reasoning to reach conclusions in theology. Characteristically, however, even in this connection he stresses the analogy between theology and Aristotelian science:

"Sicut habitus principiorum non acquiritur per alias scientias, sed habetur a natura, sed acquiritur habitus conclusionum a primis principiis deductarum, ita etiam in hac doctrina non acquiritur habitus fidei, qui est quasi habitus principiorum, sed acquiritur habitus eorum quae ex eis deducuntur et quae ad eorum defensionem valent" (p. 66, second quotation).

These are seeds that will reach their full maturity several years later in the *Summa*, where Saint Thomas will confront directly the vexing question whether theology is a science. Before that, however, we have to explore an intermediate stage, represented by his short *Commentary of Boetius's treatise De Trinitate*, where Aquinas deals with the issue of the scientific character of theology without explicitly raising the question itself. According to the best scholar-

ship, this Commentary on Boetius is to be dated between 1256 and 1258 (see p. 75, note 1).

Like Bonaventure, Aquinas considers theology as a genuinely scientific endeavor—though of a very special kind, as we shall see—for theology fulfills the essential requirement of science:

“The essential characteristic of science is that it proceeds by an inference through which from what is known something else that was not known becomes known. From this it follows that there can be scientific knowledge of divine things” (p. 70).

Immediately, however, Aquinas proceeds to make a *distinction between philosophical or natural knowledge of things divine and theological knowledge of things divine*, in order to make quite clear the sense in which theology is to be considered as a science.

Philosophical knowledge, he says, reasons its way from the knowledge of the sensible world to the knowledge of the divine. Theological knowledge, by contrast, proceeds directly from revelation. However, this latter knowledge of things divine involves two distinct moments. The first moment—which might be called the moment of pure faith—is not inferential; it has divine revelation as its source and, to the extent that this is possible in our present life, makes us know God as God knows Himself, insofar as through faith we adhere to His Truth. The second moment of this knowledge—which might be identified as the moment of theology—is similar to philosophical knowledge in that it is inferential, that is, reasons its way to conclusions. But in this theological science what is accepted through faith plays the role of principles from which previously unknown conclusions are reached; and, precisely because these principles are accepted through faith and not on the basis of their self-evidence, they can only be called quasi-principles (*quasi prima principia*):

“Sed divinorum notitia dupliciter potest aestimari... et sic de divinis duplex scientia habetur. Una secundum modum nostrum, qua sensibilibus principia accipit ad notificandum divina, et sic de divinis philosophi scientiam tradiderunt... Alia secundum modum

ipsorum divinorum, ut ipsa divina secundum seipsa capiantur, quae quidem perfecte nobis in statu viae est impossibilis, sed fit nobis in statu viae quaedam illius cognitionis participatio et assimilatio ad cognitionem divinam, in quantum, per fidem nobis infusam, inhaeremus ipsi primae veritati propter seipsam. Et sicut Deus ex hoc ipso quod cognoscit se, cognoscit alia modo suo, idest simplici intuitu non discurrendo: ita nos ex his quae fide capimus primae veritati inhaerendo, venimus in cognitionem aliorum secundum modum nostrum, scilicet discurrendo de principiis ad conclusiones. Unde primo ipsa quae fide tenemus sunt nobis quasi prima principia in hac scientia, et alia sunt quasi conclusiones” (p. 70).

From this passage it is clear that Aquinas does not consider as scientific the knowledge of things divine which we acquire through faith, for that knowledge is not acquired through inference but through divine revelation. Only what I called “the moment of theology” follows the inferential procedure of science.

Thus, though Aquinas’s distinction between faith and theology is less sharp than Bonaventure’s, and though Aquinas continues to use indiscriminately “sacra doctrina” and other equivalent expressions to name both the Holy Scripture, which falls on the side of revelation, and the intellectual elaboration by the theologian, which falls on the side of science, the distinction is there nonetheless.

One might, of course, object to Aquinas that a science like theology that borrows its first principles or “quasi prima principia” from faith would hardly be accepted as a science by Aristotle. All that Aquinas has to answer in his *Commentary of De Trinitate* is that the case of theology is far from exceptional, as acknowledged by Aristotle himself in his treatment of the subordination (*subalternatio*) that obtains between certain sciences:

“Etiam in scientiis humanitus traditis sunt quaedam principia in quibusdam earum quae non sunt omnibus nota, sed oportet ea supponere a superioribus scientiis; sicut in scientiis subalternatis supponuntur et creduntur aliqua a superioribus scientiis subalternantibus, et huiusmodi non sunt per se nota nisi superioribus

scientiis. Et hoc modo se habent articuli fidei, qui sunt principia hujus scientiae, ad cognitionem divinam, quia ea quae sunt nota in scientia quam Deus habet de seipso, supponuntur in scientia nostra, et creditur ei nobis hoc indicanti per suos nuntios, sicut medicus credit physico quatuor esse elementa” (p. 72).

Whether this is a satisfactory answer might be disputed.

However, we cannot do justice to Aquinas until, like Bonaventure, he has had the opportunity both to develop fully his views on the *subalternatio* that obtains in theology, and his reply to the foreseeable objections. For this we have to go to his *Summa Theologica*, whose First Part dates from 1267 (see p. 72), that is, in all probability, nine or ten years after the *Commentary on De Trinitate*.

The *Summa Theologica* opens with the issue of the scientific status of theology, under the title of “The nature and Domain of Sacred Doctrine.” (MY TRANSLATIONS ARE TAKEN FROM ANTON C. PEGIS, BASIC WRITINGS OF ST THOMAS, VOLUME ONE). Though, as we already know from the opusculum on Boetius’s *De Trinitate*, Aquinas makes a distinction between Scripture and the intellectual elaboration by theologians, he unfortunately follows again in the *Summa* the then common use of calling both of them by the same name of “sacra doctrina.” It will be part of our task to avoid confusion on this score.

Aquinas starts his treatment of the issue by affirming the insufficiency of reason left to itself, and the consequent necessity of divine revelation. Since the human being is destined to a supernatural end which cannot be known without divine revelation, “Hence it was necessary for the salvation of man that certain truths which exceed human reason should be known to him by divine revelation” (art. 1). Furthermore, “Even as regards those truths about God which human reason can investigate, it was necessary that man be taught by a divine revelation. For the truth about God, such as reason can know it would only be known by a few, and that after a long time, and with the admixture of many errors; whereas man’s whole salvation, which is in God, depends upon the knowledge of this truth” (ibid.).

A distinction is sketched here between two realms: the realm of revelation, and the realm of reason. It seems, at least for the moment, that they coincide in part, for there are certain revealed truths that fall within the realm of reason. *Correspondingly, there is a distinction sketched here between two kinds of knowledge, which amounts to the distinction with which we are already familiar between “philosophical knowledge” of things divine, and “theological knowledge” of things divine.* However, it is to be remarked that the latter has not—at least, not yet—been subdivided into what I previously called the moment of pure faith and the moment of theology. In other words, theology understood as intellectual elaboration by the theologian has not appeared yet. All we know, for the moment, if we refer ourselves to the words used by Aquinas in the title of this article, is that “besides the philosophical disciplines,” in which the purely rational methods have their proper place, there is “a further doctrine required.” This “doctrine” is divine revelation, which Aquinas identifies concretely with the Bible and explicitly distinguishes from philosophical knowledge: “Now Scripture, inspired of God, is not a part of the philosophical disciplines discovered by human reason” (ibid., sed contra).

The second article raises explicitly the central question “whether sacred doctrine is a science.” For this reason, it deserves very special attention and pointed commentary. Two reasons, which open the article under the title of objections, seem to militate against the scientific status of theology. One is that “every science proceeds from self-evident principles. But sacred doctrine proceeds from articles of faith which are not self-evident, since their truth is not admitted by all.” The second reason is that *sacred doctrine deals with particular, contingent, historical facts, whereas “science,” as Aristotle understands it—and that obviously is the meaning discussed in the question whether theology is a “science”—deals with universal and necessary truths.* Such, indeed, seems to be the only possible meaning of the way in which Aquinas formulates the objection: “Further, science is not of individuals. But sacred doctrine treats of

individual facts, such as the deeds of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, and the like. Therefore sacred doctrine is not a science.”

It is worth remarking that, in the first objection, “sacred doctrine” clearly means theology, that is, the intellectual elaboration by theologians, for the Bible does not proceed from principles, self-evident or otherwise. By contrast, in the second objection, the same words seem to refer to the Bible, for it is the Bible that speaks of the deeds of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Or does Aquinas mean to ask whether the Bible itself is a scientific work? Let us leave the question provisorily open. At any rate, we are once again confronted with an important equivocation that we have repeatedly met in all the writings we have so far examined, with the possible exception of Saint Bonaventure’s.

Saint Thomas’s answer to the question raised in the article is categorical: “Sacred doctrine is a science.” His answer is grounded on an implicit appeal to the Aristotelian view of subordination between sciences, much as Bonaventure had done:

“We must bear in mind that there are two kinds of sciences. There are some which proceed from principles known by the natural light of the intellect, such as arithmetic and geometry and the like. There are also some which proceed from principles known by the light of a higher science: thus the science of optics proceeds from principles established by geometry, and music from principles established by arithmetic. So it is that sacred doctrine is a science because it proceeds from principles made known by the light of a higher science, namely the science of God and the blessed. Hence, just as music accepts on authority the principles taught by the arithmetician, so sacred doctrine accepts the principles revealed by God.”

The grave equivocation mentioned above seems to have been dispelled. For here, undoubtedly, Aquinas is referring, not to the Bible, but to the intellectual elaboration by theologians on the data of revelation, since it cannot be said of the Bible that “sacred doctrine accepts the principles revealed by God.” Moreover, that “sacred doctrine is a science because it proceeds from principles

made known by the light of a higher science, namely, the science of God and the blessed” cannot possibly refer to the Bible, either. However, the equivocation *might* only have been displaced rather than dispelled. For now there is question of another science, the “*scientia*” possessed by God and those who already see God face to face—“the blessed,” from which the scientific discipline practiced by theologians borrows its principles.

Waiting for further clarification on the sense in which the word “*scientia*” is to be taken in the case of God and the blessed, Aquinas’s argument is based on an analogy: As certain disciplines accepted as scientific by Aristotle depend on other disciplines where the basic principles borrowed by the former are grasped in their self-evidence, so “*sacra doctrina*,” that is, theology, depends on the immediate vision that God and the blessed have of the truth of the principles to which theologians assent only by faith and from which they infer other truths. Granted, Aquinas does not speak specifically of inference in this passage, but we know from his commentary on Boetius that such was his view. And we know, as well, that, at least since the time he wrote his Commentary on the Lombard’s book, Aquinas maintained that the articles of faith play in theology the role that self-evident principles play in the Aristotelian sciences. That this remains his view in the *Summa* is stated in article 7:

“Hence it follows that God is in very truth the subject-matter of this science. This is made clear also from *the principles of this science, namely, the articles of faith*, for faith is about God. The subject-matter of the principles and of the whole science must be the same, since the whole science is *contained virtually in its principles*.” (Pegis, p. 12. My emphasis).

The whole science of theology is contained virtually in its principles, namely, the articles of faith. What theological inference does is to make known what was virtually contained in the principles and was not known previously. Actually, what Aquinas does here for the most part and in different terms is to repeat the justification of the scientific status of the theological discipline already given

in his *Commentary on Boetius's De Trinitate* (the appeal to the Aristotelian theory of subordination between sciences included). He completes, however, his previous justification, which emphasized the procedure of rational inference as if it were the only characteristic of science, by clarifying the basic role played by principles, for their absolute certainty insures that the conclusions reached by inference from them will share on their certainty and will, therefore, constitute what Aristotle calls "knowledge." The only difference between theology and the other disciplines that deserve the name of "sciences" is that theology works on articles *of faith*, for they are not self-evident to the theologian but only to God and the blessed, whereas in the other dependent disciplines it is possible (though not usually done) to grasp in their self-evidence the principles that they borrow on the authority of the practitioners of the disciplines on which they depend. This difference, though, is relatively minor, in Aquinas's eyes, since after all these other dependent disciplines, which according to Aristotle fully deserve the title of sciences, take their basic principles on the basis of authority, not on the basis of their immediate self-evidence, much as the theologian takes the basic principles of his discipline on the basis of God's authority. Hence, in reply to the first objection, namely, that "sacred doctrine proceeds from articles of faith which are not self-evident" and "therefore sacred doctrine is not a science," Aquinas simply responds that "The principles of any science are either in themselves self-evident, or reducible to the knowledge of a higher science; and such, as we have said, are the principles of sacred doctrine."

One point of this second article is still left undecided. How does Aquinas solve the objection that theology cannot be a science, given that the Aristotelian sciences deal with universal and necessary truths exclusively, while the Bible, from which theology borrows its data, deals with particular, contingent, historical facts?

"Individual facts," responds Saint Thomas, "are not treated in sacred doctrine because it is concerned with them principally; they are rather introduced as examples to be followed in our lives (as in the moral sciences), as well as to establish the authority of those men

through whom the divine revelation, on which the sacred scripture or doctrine is based, has come down to us.”

I must confess that I find this answer extremely puzzling, not to say simply aberrant and unacceptable, at least in what seems to me to be its obvious meaning. For it is equivalent to saying that in the theological discipline whose scientific character Aquinas is establishing, such “individual facts” as the birth, the life, the passion and the death of Jesus-Christ, in whom Aquinas obviously believes, do not occupy a central and essential place, as they certainly do in what Christians take for “revelation.” Do these contingent, historical facts enter into theology only as examples to be followed in our lives? Or only to establish the authority of Jesus through whom divine revelation, on which the Scripture is based, has come to us? Or is it, rather, that if Aquinas grants the central and essential character of these “individual facts,” he would be forced to conclude that the theological discipline cannot possibly be a science in the full-fledged Aristotelian sense, for there is no room for contingent, historical truths in the full-fledged Aristotelian notion of “science”? After all, did not Aristotle declare history even worse off than poetry, from the scientific point of view, in that poetry at least concerns itself with what is possible, that is, with a certain kind of necessity (at least in a diluted sense), whereas history deals with the purely contingent? This, indeed, is the purport of the objection. Has Aquinas really solved it? Has he even taken it seriously? And can theologians who share Aquinas’s Christian faith recognize their discipline in an endeavor where these “individual facts” are relegated to an accidental place? These are important and legitimate questions that will demand explicit consideration when we come to consider in depth Aquinas’s synthesis of faith and reason. For the moment, however, we have to postpone them for the sake of continuity.

What I have presented so far is not, by any means, Aquinas’s entire treatment of “The nature and domain of sacred doctrine.” Other elements will receive our attention in the coming chapters. The only point we have left to explore now is *the relationship*

between Aquinas's and Bonaventure's respective answers to the question whether theology is a scientific endeavor.

The answer given by both of them, as we know, is affirmative. This, indeed, is the sense in which, by contrast to all their predecessors, they can legitimately be called Aristotelians. They also have in common the fact that both of them justify the scientific character of theology on the basis of the Aristotelian theory of subordination between sciences.

There is, however, a very significant difference between Bonaventure and Aquinas on this point. According to Bonaventure, in the passage of the revealed data used by the theologian from the regime of faith to the regime of reason there occurs a “*determinatio distrahens*”—a radical disruption, so to say—by virtue of which the data of faith cease to be treated as object of faith and are considered by the theologian as mere object of science, that is, in their pure intelligibility, not in their credibility. In this view, therefore, theology is really independent from faith. For the fact that the theologian accepts the truth of his basic data through faith does not impinge at all on the way in which he will treat them in his theological endeavor. The theological endeavor is purely scientific, its standards are exactly the same rational standards of any other Aristotelian science, and therefore the fact that its basic data are imported from the paradigm of revelation does not privilege them in any way within the rational paradigm of science. What we want to find out is whether Aquinas shares this view and, consequently, whether he goes as far as Bonaventure in his Aristotelianism.

Aquinas's position on this particularly important point is certainly much more complex than Bonaventure's.

As we had remarked at the time, Bonaventure's posture is inconsistent. If the regimes of revelation-faith, on the one hand, and of reason-knowledge, on the other, are radically different “games” or “paradigms,” one can hardly see how the knowledge rationally reached by theologians can increase the delectation of the faithful, as Bonaventure pretends it can. Furthermore, what possible tension

can there be between truths that belong to totally heterogeneous paradigms, so that the theologian, when confronted with the inability of reason to confirm some of the truths he holds by faith, can always fall back on his faith and dismiss his reason, as Bonaventure suggests? After all, the theologian as theologian is wearing one hat only—the scientific hat. Thus, when unable to reach knowledge, he should say that he does not know, and stick by his guns. Why not, if theology is independent from faith? Of course, the easy way out is to say that he does not know as *a theologian*, but that he knows as *a believer*. This move, however, is grounded on an obvious equivocation, for “knowledge” is knowledge only if it is rationally reached; thus, the theologian cannot say that he knows as a believer.

As for Aquinas, he avoids these problems, though perhaps not others, because, unlike Bonaventure, he does not make theology independent from faith. In the following chapters we will investigate his stand in depth. For the moment, it will suffice to allude to a pertinent passage from his *De Veritate* (q. 14, a. 9, ad 3) where he clearly states his view that there is no *determinatio distrahens* but full continuity between revelation and theology by virtue of the subordination of theology to faith: “Ille qui habet scientiam subalternatam non perfecte attingit ad rationem sciendi, nisi in quantum ejus cognitio *continuetur* quodammodo cum cognitione ejus qui habet scientiam subalternantem” [P. 73].

The point is that theology is not a philosophical discipline that imports its object of rational inquiry from the domain of revelation-faith, as Bonaventure would have it; rather, theology imports reason into the domain of faith to inquire rationally about the intelligibility of the credible, under the light of faith. *The theologian is and remains throughout his theological work a faithful who uses reason, not a purely rational inquirer who has as object of study certain data that happen to come from the domain of faith.* This, by the way, coheres fully with the above quoted text from the *Commentary on De Trinitate*, where Aquinas placed what I called “the moment of theology” under “theological knowledge of things divine,” not under “philosophical knowledge of things divine,” as Bonaventure

would have been constrained to do in full consistency with his views. In short, *for Aquinas, theology is a science subordinated to faith, whereas, for Bonaventure, theology is really independent from faith, subject exclusively to the standards of Aristotelian reason, and only extrinsically related to faith in that its basic data happen to proceed from the domain of faith.*

Of course, if this is indeed Aquinas's view of theology, there is ample room to discuss whether theology can be truly considered a science, as he affirms in the second article of the first question of the *Summa*.

There is ample room, moreover, to discuss whether Aquinas can really be considered an Aristotelian, since when the dice are down he remains, for all practical purposes, on the side of those who, compelled by their understanding of their Christian faith, ended up being non-Aristotelians, in spite of their undeniable eagerness to embrace Aristoteles' views.

We may, then, conclude this chapter by acknowledging that the synthesis between faith and Aristotelian reason, *in the measure that it was achieved*, was a protracted and painful process because of the heterogeneousness sensed by the very people who strove to achieve it between their faith and Aristotelian reason. In other words, it was not obscurantism but deep understanding of their faith and of Aristotelian reason that imposed limitations on their enthusiasm. As for Aquinas in particular, whose work is usually awarded the palm for the successful synthesis between the two, the extent of his success and even the exact character of his synthesis remain, at least at this point, doubtful.

We will have to explore his views more in depth if we want to reach firm conclusions.

Chapter 5: The Notion of Faith

Long before Aquinas and his immediate predecessors and contemporaries, the Fathers of the Church had reflected on their faith, too. The frequency and reverence with which Aquinas cites the Fathers, especially Saint Augustine, shows that he conceives of his own work as a continuation of that reflection. The reflection of the Fathers, however, had no scientific pretensions. It was *Christian* reflection through and through, that is, reflection by committed Christians on the very faith which they lived and of which they had experience as Christians. The reflection conducted by Aquinas in his *Summa Theologica* is, by contrast, avowedly and willingly, a scientific undertaking.

Does this difference affect the continuity between Aquinas's reflection and that of the Fathers? That there is a difference at least in tone and structure between the works of the Fathers and Aquinas's *Summa* is beyond doubt. Already in a previous chapter we considered the distance that separates the two. The question we have to tackle now is whether this difference is merely superficial—simply a question of tone, structure, and scope, just a difference in 'literary genres' or modes of expression—or whether, on the contrary, Aquinas's theological undertaking constitutes such a different kind of reflection that it results in a different notion of faith. The answer to this question involves a number of closely interrelated matters. To proceed in an orderly fashion I will take each of them successively. In the present chapter I will concentrate on the notion of faith exclusively, and, when dealing with Aquinas's views, will

focus for the most part on the subject who believes, leaving the term of the faith-relationship—the God believed in—for a further chapter.

The Patristic Notion of Faith

Many of the Fathers had much to say about faith, that is, the characteristically Christian response to God. What emerges from their works and sermons is that what they understand by “faith” is a relationship that possesses a double characteristic. It is primarily a relationship to and with the tri-Personal God of Christianity, and it is a dynamic relationship that involves the whole person of the believer.

The first aspect or characteristic of the faith-relationship is meant to indicate, not only that *what the Fathers call faith (fides, in Latin, or pístis, in Greek) refers to the tri-Personal God of Christianity to the exclusion of any other God*, but—what is equally important—that *generally the Fathers use the word “faith” in connection with God Himself rather than in connection with propositions about God, the Church, the sacraments, the devil, etc.*

This latter trait deserves particular attention. We are so used to translate “fides” (or pístis) as “belief,” and “credere” (or pistéuein) as “believing,” and we so naturally nowadays attach to the English verb a propositional content as its direct object, that we may have trouble grasping fully what the Fathers mean by the substantive “fides” and the corresponding verb “*credere*.” [ON THE EVOLUTION OF THE MEANING OF THESE WORDS SEE CANTWELL SMITH’S EXTREMELY INSIGHTFUL STUDY]. Actually, the verb “credere” as used most generally by the Fathers to express what Christians primarily do in “believing” has no direct object, much less a propositional direct object. Translating their language in a barbarous way, they do not say, when speaking of what the Christian does in believing, that the Christian “believes *God*,” much less that the Christian “believes *that...*”. The word that in their language typically follows the verb “credere” is indeed God, or the Father, or the Son, or Jesus-Christ, or the Holy Spirit, that is, the tri-Personal God or one of the divine Persons, as already remarked. But these names do not follow

the verb as their direct object. The Christian believes *in* God, *in* the Father, *in* the Holy Spirit, etc.

Now, I do not want to suggest that, in the Fathers' use, the verb "*credere*" is always and only followed by the preposition *in* and the divine name or the name of one of the divine Persons in the accusative. That would be patently false. In fact, they also employ two other constructions: *credere* followed by a personal name or a personal pronoun (as in *credere Deo*, *credere Christo*, *credere ei*), and *credere* followed by a direct object which may be a proposition. The former construction refers to the religious confidence of the Christian in God as Revealer, and the latter to the religious acceptance by the Christian of what God reveals. Most certainly, the Fathers' notion of faith includes these two elements as part and parcel of what they mean by "believing *in* God." Yet, these are neither the only nor even the principal elements of what they have in mind when they speak of "faith," of what the Christian primarily does in "believing."

This is stressed in several of his sermons by Saint Augustine who, while distinguishing certain common uses of the verb "*credere*" in the Christian tradition (a distinction which Aquinas will adopt in the *Summa Theologica*), identifies "faith" with only *one* of them. Thus, for instance, commenting on Joannes 6:29:

"... that you should believe in Him (*in eum*); not that you should believe Him or what He says (*ei*). But if you believe in Him, you believe Him and what He says; whereas whoever believes things that He says does not by that fact believe in Him; for the demons too believe what He says but still do not believe in Him" (p. 141, and note 26).

And again: "*Hoc est etiam credere in Deum, quod utique plus est quam credere Deo*" (This, too, is to believe in God, which is much more than to believe God) (In Ps. 77, no. 8; see p. 142, note 27. My emphasis).

The Fathers' use of the preposition "in" following the substantive *fides* or the verb *credere* and accompanied by a divine name in the accusative, which they directly borrow from Saint John and Saint Paul, is highly idiosyncratic. Both in *classical* Latin and in *classical* Greek the normal complement of the verbs "credere" or "pistéuein," when the point is to express confidence *in a person*, is a dative case (*credo tibi*, *pistéuo soi*), not the preposition "in" followed by the name of the person or by a personal pronoun. Indeed, the early Christians were the ones who, in order to express the unique relationship in which they stood to God in believing, invented and introduced the *barbarous*—and to well trained ears, *abhorrent*—construction of the verbs *pistéuein* or *credere* followed respectively by the preposition "eis" in Greek or "in" in Latin, accompanied by an accusative referring, not to just any person, but *either to the tri-Personal God, or to one of the divine Persons in particular*.

Commenting on this solecistic Christian transformation of the Greek and Latin languages to force them to express the totally new and unique relationship constituted by faith, de Lubac writes:

"The proclamation of the gospel... brought about a spiritual revolution which created a new mental structure deep within man, and, by an imperative logic, this latter, despite some hesitations, had to clear a way to express itself. Erasmus recognized this when he commented on and adopted as his own the traditional explanations: when used in this way, not indiscriminately but as a result of a particular, unique choice, this preposition *in* 'adds a certain force to what is said.' It specifies a privileged use of the verb 'believe.' That is why, Erasmus continued, giving the demands of Christian faith precedence over his literary tastes, '*credo in Deum*' is a well-chosen expression even though those who speak polished Latin can hardly bear it.

"The fact is that neither the Greek words *pistéuo* and *pístis* nor the corresponding Latin words *credere* and *fides* were particularly significant in themselves.... It was Christianity that reintroduced them into the vocabulary of religion, where they played a central

role. However, even if they could serve to express a religious belief..., these words did not suffice in themselves to render... faith itself in the Christian sense of the word..., the notion of which is not merely a generic concept, prior to the specific differences that might produce varying types of belief, but which constitutes an original, irreducible notion [spelled out as follows by Romano Guardini]:

“What the New Testament calls ‘faith’ does not take on a religious attitude that might apply to various contents—something like an abstract category, like knowledge capable of apprehending a multitude of disparate objects while still remaining ‘knowledge.’ Faith, in the Christian sense, has a unique and exclusive character. It is not an all-embracing notion which might be adapted to numerous modalities: Christian faith, Moslem faith, paganism of the ancient Greeks or Buddhism... The word designates a unique thing: the response given by man to God, who has come to him in Christ” (*The Christian Faith*, pp. 277-279).

Let me summarize what I have said concerning the first characteristic of the Patristic notion of faith. The point of it is that the substantives *fides* and *pístis*, that is, “faith” in the Christian sense, and the verbs *credere* and *pistéuein*, that is, “believing,” again in the Christian sense, designate a *unique* relationship. It is unique in two ways. First, it is a relationship to and with the God of Christianity, exclusively. Otherwise said, the only possible term of the faith relationship is the tri-Personal God. Either one believes in *that* God, or one is not doing what the Fathers mean by “believing.” One cannot “believe” *in* the devil, or *in* hell, not even *in* the Church, much less can one “believe” *in* a proposition. Second, the relationship is unique in that only Christians can stand in *that* relationship to God. In other words, “*believing*” or “*having faith*” are convertible with “*being a Christian*.”

He or she who genuinely “believes in God” is a Christian, and he or she who genuinely is a Christian “believes in God.” Christians are “those who believe”; this, in fact, is the way they are identified in the Acts of the Apostles—*oi pistéusantes, oi pistoí*.

[ON THIS POINT, SEE THE VERY ENLIGHTENING CHAPTER BY DE LUBAC, SIGNIFICANTLY ENTITLED “CHRISTIAN SOLE-CISMS,” IN HIS THE CHRISTIAN FAITH, PP. 261-289].

The second characteristic of the Patristic notion of faith is, as I put it above, that it is a dynamic relationship that involves the whole person of the believer. We have to guard, here again, against the danger of understanding the words “faith” and “believing” in the very different meanings they have come to acquire. What the Fathers mean by “faith” is not a collection of “beliefs” in the contemporary sense of this word. The Christian the Fathers have in mind may and does have “beliefs,” but that is not what the Fathers mean primarily by “faith.” Faith is not primarily a matter of believing propositions, much less if by “believing” we mean an arbitrary and unwarranted acceptance, which is what the word tends to connote nowadays.

The word “belief” (much more than the word “faith,” which keeps still some of its early Christian connotation) has come to signify, for us, something akin to what Plato meant by *dóxa*, a sort of unsupported opinion, by contrast to “knowledge.” Now, the very fact that we implicitly contrast “belief” with “knowledge” indicates that we are talking of notions of the epistemic order. The Fathers of the Church, however, did not think in our Greek categories.

For us today—and we will have something to say about this latter in connection with Aquinas’s notion of faith—“faith” tends to evoke something that belongs within the epistemic order, almost irremediably. Not so for the Fathers. Faith is not, for them, an intellectual relationship, nor something that excludes the intellect, either. It is a personal relationship to and with the tri-Personal God of Christianity. And by personal relationship I mean a relationship in which the faithful stand to and with God with their *whole* personality, not only or even primarily with one portion of their being, such as their intellect, or their will. The Fathers do not see “faith” as an act of the intellect or of the will, but rather as a total orientation of the Christian toward God, as a total response to His loving self-rev-

elation. One cannot dissociate in this relationship any of its aspects from the other.

In his INSTITUTION CHRETIENNE Calvin expressed well this characteristic of the traditional notion of faith by contrasting it to the purely intellectualistic notion with which we might be tempted to confuse it and which Calvin personally abominated:

“The first consists merely in holding as true what is affirmed about God and Jesus Christ: ‘Si quis credat Deum esse, historiam quae de Christo narratur veram esse arbitretur.’ In his [AUGUSTINE’S] eyes this faith ‘indigna est fidei appellatione,’ for it does not involve any personal commitment, insofar as it can exist in the most impious of the impious: ‘Eam se habere cum diabolis communem.’ True faith is something quite different. It is a movement of one’s whole being toward God and a trusting and personal abandonment to the One who alone can save: ‘Altera est, quae non modo Deum et Christum esse credimus, sed etiam in Deum credimus et Christum’” (quoted by de Lubac, p. 308).

(For the Augustinian text on which Calvin is probably commenting here, see p. 141).

The tight distinctions among faith, hope, and charity, which are a legacy of Scholasticism and are connected with the Aristotelian view of the soul’s faculties, might tend to obscure rather than illuminate the Fathers’ notion of faith.

For the Fathers, there is no primacy of faith—logical or otherwise—over hope and charity, for the simple reason that the three of them are inseparable aspects of what they mean by “faith.” Saint Augustine, probably more than any other of the Fathers, insists on this point: “Ille enim credit in Christum qui sperat in Christum et diligit Christum”; “Hoc est enim credere in Christum, diligere Christum”; “Credere in Deum... utique plus est quam credere Deo... Hoc est ergo credere in Deum, credendo ahaerere ad bene cooperandum bona operanti Deo” (p. 300, notes).

To make the point clear by applying to it alien categories that come to us from the philosophical language of the Greeks rather than from the Biblical language from which the Fathers take their cue, we would have to say that what the Fathers mean by *faith involves inseparably cognition, volition, and action. All these aspects are equally intrinsic and essential to faith and they qualify each other. In other words, faith is not a matter of a certain cognition or intellectual conviction accompanied by certain volitions and followed by certain actions. Nor can faith be identified more or principally as a cognition rather than as a volition or an action.* In the case of faith, these words do not mean different realities; they are, rather, aspects or ‘moments’ of the same human response to God which is faith. What is cognitional in faith is equally and inseparably volitional and behavioral.

Given this notion of faith, we may understand why, for the Fathers of the Church, the faith of a Moslem would not be what they call faith, for it is not a relationship to and with the tri-Personal God. And why trust in some undefined or impersonal ultimate meaningfulness would not be faith, either. And why a mere intellectual assent to God’s existence (what we might call ‘philosophical faith’) would not be what they call faith, for it does not involve either the loving trust and full commitment or the prayerful confession and adoration that are intrinsic to what the Fathers understand by faith. And why, finally, a merely ritual adoration of the God of Christianity, or a merely ritual recitation of a confession of faith in the Holy Trinity would not be faith, for it does not involve the trusting, loving, cognitional relationship to and with the tri-Personal God without which there is no “faith.”

(ON THIS SECOND CHARACTERISTIC OF FAITH, SEE DE LUBAC, PARTICULARLY CHAPTERS 4 AND 9).

Such is the rich and complex notion of faith that Aquinas received from the Fathers, particularly from Augustine, and in continuity with which he intended to remain in his theological undertaking, not out of blind loyalty to the Christian tradition, or out of uncritical

respect for the Fathers, but because he recognized his own faith in that notion. The question now before us is the extent to which he succeeded in carrying his intention out.

Does Aquinas's notion of faith elaborated under the Aristotelian influence remain fundamentally the same as that of the Christian tradition represented by the Fathers, or does it rather, attracted by the pull of the Aristotelian views, escape its original orbit, gravitate toward a different sun and, as a result, undergo a transformation in its very nature?

Intellect and Will in Aquinas's Notion of Faith

In his elaboration of the notion of faith Aquinas borrows heavily from Aristotle. *He obviously is convinced that what the Fathers expressed in non-Aristotelian terms concerning the faith he shares with them can be articulated more precisely and fruitfully, and without any loss or distortion, by reference to the Aristotelian framework and through the use of Aristotelian categories.* From Aristotle's anthropology he takes his view of the soul in general and, more particularly, of the two main faculties of the soul, namely, the intellect and *the will* [?!]. What he borrows from Aristotle's epistemology has to do, primarily, with the object and the function of the intellect.

The faith-relationship of the Christian to God is, in Aquinas's eyes, analogous to the purely human relationship into which we enter when we believe something because we believe in the person who tells us that. Aquinas himself sketches this analogy:

“Quia vero quicumque credit, alicujus dicto assentit, principale videtur esse, et quasi finis in unaquaque credulitate ille cujus dicto assentitur; quasi autem secundaria sunt ea quae quis tenendo vult alicui assentire. Sic ergo qui recte fidem Christianam habet, sua voluntate assentit Christo in his quae vere ad ejus doctrinam pertinent.” (IIa IIae, 11, 1).

The text stresses the double aspect of the term of any faith-relationship: *it is a relationship to a person who SAYS, as well as*

to what the person SAYS. [A MATTER OF COMMUNICATION OF KNOWLEDGE: NO SAYING, NO FAITH]. Both aspects are involved in faith, inseparably. But not exactly in the same way. The trust in the person who says is primary (*principale*), for it is by virtue of it that what the person says is assented to. Thus, what the person says and is assented to is no less an aspect of faith, but it is secondary (*secundaria sunt*). Furthermore, the assent to what the person says is, in the case of faith, assent of a special kind, for it is prompted or motivated not by the evidence of what one assents to but by the will (*sua voluntate assentit*). Finally, it is worth pointing out that Aquinas, like the Fathers, when he deals with the Christian faith in particular, understands it specifically as a relationship to the God of Christianity, for he explicitly names Christ as the principal term of the relationship (*assentit Christo*).

The second question of II, IIae, is devoted to a detailed analysis of “the interior act of faith.” What, precisely, is the role played by the intellect? To believe, says Aquinas, is “to think with assent,” provided that the assent included in the thinking that is characteristic of faith be firm and unrestricted, as it is when one genuinely knows. That sort of assent is, in fact, what distinguishes the thinking that is characteristic of faith from the thinking involved in such other intellectual acts as suspecting, doubting, or opining, on the one hand, and in the act of knowing, on the other:

“...this act, *to believe*, cleaves firmly to one side, in which respect belief has something in common with science and understanding; yet its knowledge does not attain the perfection of clear vision, wherein it agrees with doubt, suspicion and opinion. Hence it is proper to the believer to think with assent; so that the act of believing is distinguished from all other acts of the intellect which are about the true or the false” (p. 1075, Pegis).

Faith is, therefore, at least in a certain regard, an act of the intellect, much as suspecting, doubting, opining, and knowing are. This is why all of them are modes of “thinking.” But the person who suspects, or doubts, or opines does not *know*, and, thus,

either cannot assent at all, or at least cannot assent firmly and unrestrictedly. The person who believes, by contrast, does assent firmly. And so does the person who knows. In this respect, believing is like knowing. However, the person who knows does not *believe*, for his assent rests on compelling evidence, on “vision.” In this other respect, therefore, believing is unlike knowing.

Another text from the *Summa* renders the similarities and dissimilarities between faith and knowledge still more perspicuous:

“Faith signifies the assent of the intellect to that which is believed. Now the intellect assents to a thing in two ways. First, through being moved to assent by its very object, which is known either by itself (as in the case of principles, which are held by the habit of understanding), or through something else already known (as in the case of conclusions which are held by the habit of science). Secondly, the intellect assents to something, not through being sufficiently moved to this assent by its proper object, but through an act of choice, whereby it turns voluntarily to one side rather than to the other. Now if this be accompanied by doubt and fear of the opposite side, there will be opinion; while, if there be certainty and no fear of the other side, there will be faith.

“Now those things are said to be seen which, of themselves, move the intellect or the senses to knowledge of them. Therefore it is evident that neither faith nor opinion can be of things seen either by the senses or the intellect” (II, IIae, 1, 4; p. 1060).

The sense of this text is so transparent concerning the fundamental role played by evidence in the case of “knowledge” that it demands no explanation. If further corroboration and declaration is needed, we find both in the section of the *Summa* in which Aquinas investigates “How God is known by us.” This is what he has to say in reply to an objection:

“Faith is a kind of knowledge, as much as the intellect is determined by faith to some knowable object. But this determination to one object does not proceed from the vision of the believer, but from

the vision of Him Who is believed. Thus, as far as faith falls short of vision, it falls short of the nature which knowledge has when it is science; for science determines the intellect to one object by the vision and understanding of first principles.” (I, 12, 12, p. 111).

Faith is, therefore, inferior to scientific knowledge (*what Aristotle called “epistemé”*) in that faith lacks “vision,” that is, the rationally compelling evidence that compellingly elicits assent and results in “knowledge.” On the other hand, as Aquinas states in the very first question of the *Summa*, faith is not only comparable but even superior to knowledge because of its superior certitude, which rests on God’s veracity and infallibility:

“... other sciences derive their certitude from the natural light of human reason, which can err, whereas this derives its certitude from the light of the divine science, which cannot err...” (I, 1, 5; p. 9).

That Aquinas sees faith as an intellectual act is, therefore, clear. But this is only one of the two inseparable aspects of the act of faith. Thus, his notion of faith cannot be correctly and fully understood unless one grasps the role played by the will in the act of faith, to which several of the quoted texts have already alluded.

The will’s role is connected with the fact that the assent involved in faith is not prompted by evidence, by “vision.” One reaches “knowledge” when one “sees,” and thus one cannot anymore “doubt,” and does not anymore need to “suspect” or “opinate.” As Aquinas reminded us above, “those things are said to be seen which, of themselves, move the intellect or the senses to knowledge of them.” But this is not what happens in the case of faith. What, then, prompts the intellect to assent, in this case?

“The intellect of the believer is determined to one object, not by the reason, but by the will, and so assent is taken here for an act of the intellect as determined to one object by the will” (II, IIae, 2, 1, ad 3; pp. 1075-6).

This is a restatement of what we had been told above:

“Faith signifies the assent of the intellect to that which is believed. Now the intellect assents to a thing in two ways. First, through being moved to assent by its very object... Secondly, the intellect assents to something, not through being sufficiently moved to this assent by its proper object, *but through an act of choice, whereby it turns voluntarily* to one side rather than to the other” (II, IIae, 1, 4; p. 1060. My emphasis).

An Intellectualistic Notion of Faith?

So far Aquinas’s notion of faith might seem to be not only the same as the Fathers’ but, thanks to the Aristotelian categories he uses, more precise than theirs. For Aquinas’s notion specifies the respective roles played by the intellect and the will, attributes to the will the determinant role in that the will prompts the intellect to assent to the particular truths revealed by God, and at least suggests that the “faith *in*” of which the Fathers spoke and which results in the assent to the truths revealed by God—the latter being an aspect of faith which the Fathers had articulated less clearly—consists in the will’s adhesion to God.

If the case were such, Aquinas’s Aristotelianism would be fully vindicated. There are, however, serious reasons to be less optimistic in this regard. An in-depth examination of Aquinas’s notion of faith will indicate, I think, that, in his eagerness to adopt Aristotelian categories in his interpretation of faith, Aquinas might have ended up, much against his own intentions, with a notion of faith that cannot be reconciled with the one he had received from the Christian tradition.

In what ways that are pertinent to the present investigation is Aristotle an intellectualist? In at least three ways. First, his anthropology attributes an absolute primacy to the intellect. What distinguishes the human being from other animals is its rationality. Now, the rationality of the human being resides primarily in the intellect, in the faculty of understanding. True, the will (or what Aquinas more sharply than Aristotle distinguishes as “the will”) is rational too, but only derivatively, for it can tend rationally to the

good, which is its object, only because the intellect, whose object is the true, makes present to it the truly good rather than the merely attractive. *By itself, the will is a merely appetitive faculty, incapable of discriminating the truly good from the merely attractive, and thus its rationality is derivative.* [OR, TO PUT IT IN ANOTHER WAY, IN THE HUMAN BEING AS RATIONAL THE APPETITIVE FACULTY IS MEANT TO BE RATIONAL BY BEING SUBORDINATED TO THE UNDERSTANDING FACULTY].

The second way in which Aristotle is an intellectualist is closely connected with his interest in genuine knowledge, what he calls *epistémé*. Because that is his main interest and because he identifies the intellect with the knowing faculty, capable of discriminating the true from the false and of assenting rationally to the true on the basis of compelling evidence, the intellectual functions have in Aristotle's works an absolute primacy to which everything else is subordinated.

Finally—and this is the third aspect of Aristotle's intellectualism —, because Aristotle himself was above all an intellectual fascinated by knowledge and truth, he identified the highest good to which people naturally aspire and which brings them the highest possible happiness with the contemplative fruition of the truth, that is, with knowledge.

Now, whether or not Aristotle was right in his intellectualism is, for our purposes, a moot point. The fact is that Aquinas thought that he was and followed closely his traces in his interpretation of faith. (FOR AN IN-DEPTH STUDY OF AQUINAS'S ARISTOTELIAN EPISTEMOLOGY, SEE LONERGAN'S *VERBUM AND IDEA IN AQUINAS*).

But what if this Aristotelian framework happens to be unfit for the Christian faith, with which the Fathers concerned themselves? To the examination of this possibility I now turn.

Is Aquinas's notion of faith overly and improperly intellectualistic to the point of distorting the Christian faith? If so, we should expect it to be such in a rather subtle way, for otherwise Aquinas

himself would have realized it and, given his attachment to the Christian tradition, he would undoubtedly have sacrificed the Aristotelian framework rather than the notion of faith he received from the Fathers and in which he recognized his own faith.

Let us, therefore, pay careful attention to the subtle signs and reserve our final judgment for the time when their accumulation constrains us to pass judgment for or against. Indeed, what at the beginning might appear as a hardly visible fissure that separates Aquinas's notion of faith from that of the Fathers may, in time, turn out to be a clearly visible and truly significant divergence.

I started my presentation of Aquinas's notion of faith by referring to a text in which he distinguishes two aspects: the confidence one has in God, and the assent one gives to what God reveals. The former he considers "the principal" aspect of faith, and the latter "secondary." Faith is, primarily and mainly, a relationship in which one stands to God by believing in, or having confidence in, Him. Because one trusts God, one "wills" (or decides, or chooses) to assent to what God says. Faith, therefore, involves an intellectual act of assent, but this intellectual act is secondary and subordinated to the trustful submission of the will to God.

Aquinas's own emphasis on faith as a relationship to the personal God of Christianity seems to coincide with the Fathers' notion. True, Aquinas uses the Aristotelian idiom, which allows him to understand more precisely than the Fathers the respective contributions of the intellect and of the will in the act of faith. But the notion itself, one would say, remains the same. After all, the Fathers, too, especially the more philosophically alert among them, realized that the "pístis eis" or the "fides in" involved both an element of trust in the God of Christianity and an element of assent to what He revealed. Did not Augustine, following Ambrose, distinguish between "credere Deo" (to have trust in God), and "credere Deum" (to believe something about God)? Granted, Augustine explicitly denied that the latter was "faith," for the demons believe certain true things about God but do not have "faith." But what Augustine denies is,

not that to believe things about God is an aspect of faith, but that this aspect by itself can be equated with faith. In short, the reason why the demons do not have “faith,” according to Augustine, is not that they believe certain true things about God, but that this belief, in their case, is not part and parcel of, and inspired by, the loving, total commitment to God that characterizes “faith.” Now, not only is Aquinas quite aware that he is in continuity with the Fathers when he includes the assent to what God says as an aspect of faith, but he explicitly refers himself to the Patristic origin of his view. He raises the question “whether the act of faith is suitably distinguished as believing God, believing in a God, and believing in God” (II, IIae, 2, 2). After, as is his custom, presenting the possible objections to the answer he will give, he triumphantly states that Augustine is on his side: “On the contrary is the authority of Augustine who makes this distinction” (Serm. CXLIV, 2—PL 38, 788); Tract. XXIX, super Ioann, VII, 17 (PL 35, 1631). [SEE ALSO IN SENTENTIAS, D. 23, 2, 2, 2; AND 3 D. 23, 2, 2, 2, AD 1; AND VER. 14, 7, AD 7). CF. JOSEPH PIEPER, *BELIEF AND FAITH; A PHILOSOPHICAL TRACT*, PANTHEON BOOKS, NEW YORK 1963, PP. 53-54, NOTES 7, 8, AND 90).

On second thoughts, however, one wonders whether we are not confronted here with a first sign of a real and important divergence between Aquinas’s notion of faith and that of the Fathers. Let us forget, for the moment, the “secondary” aspect of faith to concentrate on “the principal”—faith *in* God, rather than believing what God says.

The very analogy that Aquinas considers paradigmatic of the faith situation is already heavily intellectualistic. Indeed, the trust in the person, given the situation chosen by Aquinas as his model for faith, is trust of a particular kind, trust in the person’s veracity, trust that whatever the person SAYS is true. Both of these terms refer exclusively to the intellect.

Now, there is another kind of trust, of faith in a person, which does not exclude the trust of which Aquinas is speaking—the trust

in the person's reliability concerning truth—but which goes far beyond that. One can trust a physician as a diagnostician—he is reliable and, let us assume, even infallible in his diagnostics—without necessarily trusting him in other no less important matters, such as his care and concern for his patients or his sexual morality. Certainly, the Fathers' notion of faith included trust in God's veracity, but this was only one among the many aspects of the total commitment of the Christian to God involved in their notion of faith. By contrast, the very model from which Aquinas draws his notion of faith is a relationship that includes and demands no other form of trust than trust in the veracity and knowledge of the person trusted.

If we are to take seriously this model, “to believe in God” is, for Aquinas, to adhere to a God who is totally reliable in what He reveals. Consequently, what he means by the “principal” aspect of *faith is an adhesion to God that consists in the willingness to assent* to Him, nothing else or more; in accordance with this, the “secondary” aspect of faith consists in actual *assent* to the truths revealed by God. For the Fathers, however, faith is not primarily—much less exclusively—an intellectual relationship to God; it is an adhesion to God which involves much more, and cannot possibly be reduced without loss and distortion, to a mere willingness to assent, even if that willingness is manifested in actual assent to each of the truths revealed by God.

My distinction between two kinds of trust or forms of “faith in” may sound like mere hair-splitting—too thin a basis to ground the less than trivial claim that Aquinas's notion of faith is different from that of the Christian tradition. Though I personally think that the model of faith on which Aquinas works is defective and is the source of his different notion of faith, I willingly admit that, at this point, my thesis needs much more support to become persuasive. After all, I may be illegitimately projecting Aquinas into an intellectualistic corner where he does not belong at all, given his insistence on the role played by the will in faith. However, at this point the hypothesis is not excluded, on the other hand, that Aquinas's own Aristotelian

categories are the gravitational pull that projects him into that corner, much against his intentions and certainly without his realizing it. To decide which is actually the case we have to investigate further.

For the purpose of this investigation, it will be useful to keep in mind the conception of the intellect and of the will that Aquinas shares with Aristotle. According to a fundamental Aristotelian principle of which Aquinas himself reminds us in his treatise on faith, “habits are known by their acts, and acts by their objects” (II, IIae, 4, 1; p. 1095). Thus, if the intellect and the will differ both in their respective objects and in their respective acts, they have to be different faculties, as in fact they are for Aquinas, and less explicitly for Aristotle. For the object of the intellect is the true, whereas the object of the will is the good; and the acts of the intellect are such as knowing, doubting, suspecting, opining, etc., whereas desiring, loving, choosing, rejecting, abhorring, etc., are the very different acts of the will. Hence, the faculties themselves are different, the intellect being a cognitive faculty, and the will an appetitive one.

As to the way in which those faculties are coordinated in the act of faith, we already know that the will plays the more important role, for it is the will that trusts in God—and this is “the principal” in the case of faith—and it is the will that, on the basis of that trust, prompts the intellect to assent to what God reveals, which is “secondary.” Now, according to this hierarchy of primacy or importance, one would expect Aquinas, when he considers faith as an act, to define faith as being primarily an act of the will and to concentrate his attention on faith as trust *in* God. Oddly enough, he does exactly the opposite. Indeed, from the previously quoted texts we know in great detail how the assent of the intellect obtains, how faith is a mode of “thinking,” and how it differs from such other intellectual acts as doubting, opining, suspecting, and knowing—all of which has primarily to do with the intellect. But what has he told us about the will’s trust in God? Hardly anything, except that it is an aspect of the act of faith and that it is fundamental. If it is so fundamental, however, why does Aquinas show so little interest in exploring it in at least the same depth in which he explores the intellectual aspect?

Might this not be another subtle indicator of the gravitational pull under which Aquinas has fallen?

At any rate, if in fact Aquinas attributes the primacy to the will in the act of faith, his definition of the act of faith will have to take approximately the following shape: Believing in God is the act by which the will, in the absence of evidence that would compel the intellect to assent, but on the basis of its trust in God, prompts the intellect to assent to what God reveals. Is this the shape that Aquinas's definition takes? Does Aquinas characterize the act of faith as being primarily an act of the will? Let us listen to him.

Aquinas raises the question "whether faith resides in the intellect [or in the will]." His answer is that

"to believe is immediately an act of the intellect, because the object of that act is *the true*, which pertains properly to the intellect. Consequently faith, which is the proper principle of that act, must needs reside in the intellect" (II, IIae, 4, 3).

One cannot fail to observe the important shift that has taken place. We had been led by Aquinas himself to think, on the basis of his model of faith, that to believe is primarily and principally an adhesion of the will to God. Now it turns out that, for Aquinas, it is really a matter of the intellect, because what one believes is the true, and the true is the object of the intellect, not of the will. This, of course, corresponds perfectly to the secondary aspect of faith, which consists in assenting to what God reveals, because assenting is an act of the intellect, but, unless I am badly mistaken, does not correspond to the primary act of faith, which is a deed of the will. Faith, therefore, properly speaking, has become an act of the intellect, not a volitional act, and that is why it 'resides in the intellect,' immediately.

Of course, the implication is that, though not *immediately*, faith is *also* an act of the will, for otherwise Aquinas would be denying what he had so forcefully affirmed, to wit: that the intellect assents not because of the evidence of what God reveals but because it is

prompted to do so by the will. Moreover, although the text I quoted comes in a section that deals with faith as a virtue rather than as an act, Aquinas makes clear in it that he considers the habit of the will as much an integral part of the virtue of faith as the habit of the intellect, and explicitly states that “this act [of faith] proceeds from the will and the intellect, both of which have a natural aptitude to be perfected by a habit...” (ibid.). However, it is difficult, at least for me, to escape the feeling that Aquinas is progressively reducing the notion of faith to its secondary aspect and, by the same token, relegating the will to a secondary role.

Vague feelings, of course, will not carry us very far in these matters. We need to find out where Aquinas actually stands. We gain a more precise idea in his treatment of “formless faith,” that is, mere faith not informed by charity. Does such formless faith really qualify as “faith”? Yes, answers Aquinas unequivocally. But what interests us in particular is the reason for his answer:

“... since faith is a perfection of the intellect, that pertains *essentially* to faith which pertains to the intellect. Now *what pertains to the will does not pertain directly to faith...*” (II, IIae, 4, 4; my emphasis).

Aquinas is not known for his imprecision. When he writes “essentially” he means what he writes. Thus, what pertains to the will is not part and parcel of the essence of faith. The will’s prompting of the intellect is, of course, required for the intellect’s assent to obtain, but it is not itself a constitutive of faith. [THIS IS WHY DE LUBAC CONCLUDES THAT IN AQUINAS’S NOTION OF FAITH THE WILL PLAYS AN EXTRINSIC ROLE AND, THEREFORE, OCCUPIES A SORT OF SECONDARY PLACE, WHICH PLACES HIM OUT OF THE PATRISTIC TRADITION]. Now, if Aquinas really means that charity, that is, the love of God, is not part and parcel of what he understands by faith, then clearly his notion of faith is different from that of the Fathers. But what else is he saying here?

Lest we think that this constitutes a mere slip of the pen on his part, in the previous article Aquinas explicitly clarifies that the par-

ticipation of the will in faith is purely extrinsic. Responding to the objection that charity cannot be the form of faith, as he holds it to be, because “faith is in the intellect and charity is in the will,” he replies that “This objection is true of an *intrinsic* form. *But it is not thus that charity is the form of faith*, but in the sense that it quickens the act of faith, as explained above” (II, IIae, 4, 3, ad 2; my emphasis). This, of course, is consistent with such other points already made by Aquinas as that “faith resides in the intellect,” not in the will, and that believing is a form of “thinking,” not a volitional act. Indeed, this is why the will can participate only extrinsically in the act of faith by prompting or “quickenning” the intellect to assent to what God says, *without being itself the faculty that believes*. But, though consistent with other points made by Aquinas, it is not consistent with the Fathers’ notion of faith. It reveals, in fact, a different notion of faith from theirs, for the total response to God in which faith consists according to the Fathers has become merely an assent of the intellect to what God reveals.

Is this difference simply due to the fact that the Fathers did not think their faith in terms of the intellect and the will? Or is it, rather, that thinking in those Aristotelian terms constrains Aquinas to change the notion of faith he inherited from the Fathers and breaks his continuity with them? We will be in a better position to settle the question when we have taken all the data into account. What for the moment seems unmistakable is that, in Aquinas’s analysis of the act of faith, what he declared principal becomes secondary; that Aquinas’s attention is focussed on the assent to what is revealed, and that, consequently, the participation of the will becomes avowedly extrinsic. Faith resides in the intellect. The will does not believe; it makes the intellect believe.

Is it true, however, that Aquinas ends up forgetting the primacy he originally accorded to the adhesion of the will to God to grant it finally to the assent to what God reveals? That is, at any rate, what I gather from his answer to the question “whether faith is the first of the virtues”:

“... the last end must of necessity be present in the intellect before it is present in the will, since the will has no inclination for anything except in so far as it is apprehended by the intellect.

Hence, since the last end is present in the will by hope and charity, and in the intellect, by faith, the first of all the virtues must, of necessity, be faith, because natural knowledge cannot reach God as the object of heavenly beatitude, which is the aspect under which hope and charity tend towards Him“ (II, IIae, 4, 7).

This, it seems to me, amounts to saying that the intellect has *first* to assent to, that is, know, God as being the last end capable of fulfilling our aspirations, so that, *then*, the will may adhere to God through hope and charity, “since the will has no inclination for anything except in so far as it is apprehended by the intellect.” This, indeed, is why Aquinas concludes that “the *first* of all the virtues must, *of necessity*, be faith.” But is this not tantamount to granting to the intellect the priority that he had previously accorded to the will in the act of faith, so that whatever does not “reside in the intellect” becomes more and more extrinsic to faith? And does this not constitute a very different notion of faith from that of the Fathers, for whom what they called “faith” was inconceivable and inseparable from hope and charity, without any possible primacy of one of its aspects over the others precisely because they saw them as *aspects of the same* relationship of the Christian to God?

What is worse, it seems that in his increasing intellectualization of faith under the pressure of the Aristotelian view of the faculties of the soul he has made his, Aquinas reaches a point at which he cannot remain fully coherent with the role he had initially attributed to the will. For how can the will, which apprehends nothing but what is presented to it by the intellect, fulfill the function of quickening the intellect’s assent in the case of faith? If the will needs the assent of the intellect to God being man’s end to start aspiring to God as its end, which is what Aquinas just said, it becomes unintelligible how the will can prompt that assent. How, indeed, can Aquinas, at the same time, maintain that the intellect has first to assent to God as

being our ultimate end in order for the will to aspire to that end, *and* that the will is the one that prompts the intellect to assent? Aquinas senses the problem in which he finds himself and presents it under the form of an objection:

“The order of habits is taken from the order of acts. Now in the act of faith, the act of the will, which is perfected by charity, precedes the act of the intellect, which is perfected by faith, as the cause which precedes its effect. Therefore charity precedes faith. Therefore faith is not the first of the virtues.” (II, IIae, 4, 3. obj. 5)

This is the way in which Aquinas answers:

“Some act of the will is required before faith, but not an act of the will quickened by charity. This latter act presupposes faith, because the will cannot tend to God with perfect love unless the intellect possesses a right faith about Him” (*ibid.*, ad 5).

May I honestly say that I find this solution totally unsatisfactory? What, indeed, is this “some act” of the will required before faith? If it is required before faith, then it is not itself part and parcel of the act of faith. Now, this squares with Aquinas’s idea that the role of the will is extrinsic to faith. But it does not square at all with the role Aquinas had previously assigned to the will. For this “some act” cannot be but the trust *in* God by which the will is motivated to quicken the intellect to assent to what God reveals. It turns out now, however, that the will cannot trust God unless and until the intellect assents to God as being the good to which the will is destined to tend. How, then, can the will prompt the assent of the intellect, lacking all motivation to do so before the intellect enlightens it as to God being the good to which it is supposed to tend? In other words, the problem is not whether the will is or is not “quickened by charity”—which is what Aquinas’s answer attempts to deal with—but the impossibility of the will prompting the intellect to assent and, at the same time, not being able to do anything before the intellect assents.

Thus, until I am enlightened by someone who proposes an understanding of this passage that completely escapes me, I am

constrained to state that Aquinas's attempt to interpret the act of faith by means of Aristotelian categories not only leads him to an intellectualistic notion of faith that I have much trouble identifying with the Fathers' notion, but to a notion of faith in which neither the function he assigns to the will nor the function he assigns to the intellect are really intelligible. In fact, I strongly suspect that, given his views on *knowledge* (*epistémé*), which is what concerned him, Aristotle would have unhesitatingly rejected Aquinas's notion of faith as a bad mixture of Aristotelian and other extraneous (Christian) elements; and, given their views, the Fathers would have found Aquinas's notion of faith significantly and strangely at odds with theirs and with the Christian tradition on faith.

It may be too early, however, even to *suspect* such things. After all, so far we have been focusing on the act of faith, that is, on faith on the side of the subject who believes. Perhaps the exploration of the term of the relationship, that is, of the God believed in, will bring new elements that will allay all possible suspicions.

Chapter 6: The Object of Faith

One of the ways in which Aquinas divides his study on faith is by considering the “act” of faith and the “object” of faith.

In the former case he concentrates on the subject of the faith-relationship, that is, on the believer; in the latter case, he focuses on the term of the faith-relationship, that is, on what is believed. Having already explored the first, we move now to the second, after a short recapitulation.

Where are we, at this point? What the Fathers call “faith” is by its very nature a relationship whose term or “object” can only be the God they recognize as God, the God of Christianity. In taking as his model for faith the relationship of trust between two persons—the one who trusts and the one trusted—and in specifying that in the act of faith the trust in the God who reveals is the “principal,” whereas the assent to the particular truths revealed is “secondary,” Aquinas seemed to have not only made his the Fathers’ notion of faith, but even added some welcome precision concerning the acceptance by the believer of particular truths that is involved in faith. Nonetheless, at the time we came across Aquinas’s model of faith I expressed certain misgivings. It seemed to me, indeed, that Aquinas saw faith as a relationship to God as reliable concerning the matters He revealed, either exclusively or at least principally, whereas the faith of which the Fathers spoke was not particularly, much less exclusively, a relationship to God as veracious. Initially, however, it appeared conceivable that the difference between Aquinas’s notion of faith and the traditional one was fundamentally a matter of emphasis rather than of substance. I must confess, however, that the detailed

examination of Aquinas's analysis of the act of faith I undertook in the preceding chapter did nothing to convince me that the difference was merely superficial. Quite the contrary. For not only did Aquinas practically bypass in his analysis what he himself had announced as "the principal" in the act of faith, namely, God himself rather than the truths revealed, but his heavy concentration on faith as assent to particular truths and his relegation of the will to a merely extrinsic role indicated that, caught within the gravitational pull of Aristotle's intellectualistic epistemology, Aquinas really conceived faith as a fundamentally intellectual relationship to the "doctrines" revealed rather than as a relationship of the whole person Himself. At any rate, a close examination of Aquinas's views on the "object" of faith will surely help us to find out whether or not his notion of faith is the same as that of the tradition, for it will clarify the way in which he sees God in the faith-relationship.

The Object of Faith

What is the object of faith? This is the question with which Aquinas opens his treatise on the object of faith. "The First Truth," he answers (II, IIae, 1, 1). Of course, the First Truth is God. Thus, the object of faith is God. One might, thus, feel inclined to conclude that for Aquinas as well as for the Fathers "faith" is faith in God. But would the preposition "in" as used by Aquinas express the same relationship to God as the same preposition as used by the Fathers and in the Nicæan Symbol?

It is noteworthy that in defining the object of the faith-relationship Aquinas pointedly gives precedence to one particular aspect of God. For he does not refer simply to God, as the Fathers would have done if asked what the term of the faith-relationship is, but to God as the First Truth, that is, to God as incapable of erring and of lying. This seems to indicate that, for Aquinas, "faith" is trusting God as omniscient, infinitely veracious, and absolutely infallible, and, consequently, believing, that is, assenting to each of the truths revealed by God on the basis of His authority.

How, concretely, does Aquinas construe divine revelation? From God seen as the First Truth what one naturally expects is true statements. And that, precisely, is what divine revelation consists in, according to Aquinas: what God reveals is a special kind of knowledge that complements the knowledge reached by reason left to its own forces.

“It was necessary for man’s salvation that there should be a doctrine revealed by God, besides the philosophical disciplines investigated by human reason. First, because man is directed to God as an end that surpasses the grasp of his reason... But the end must first be known by men who are to direct their intentions and actions to the end. Hence it was necessary that certain truths which exceed human reason should be made known to him by divine revelation. Even as regards those truths about God which human reason can investigate, it was necessary that man be taught by a divine revelation. For the truth about God, such as man can know it, would only be known by a few, and that after a long time, and with the admixture of many errors; whereas man’s whole salvation, which is in God, depends on the knowledge of this truth” (I, 1, 1).

I underlined a number of words and expressions in the above passage to make clear the heavy epistemic character of Aquinas’s notion of revelation. It all is a matter of knowledge and truth to which everything else is subordinated. What God shares with us through revelation is the knowledge He possesses. And, lest we miss his point, Aquinas himself underscores the parallelism between that which is obtained through the natural use of reason, which of course is knowledge, and what is revealed by God. Consequently, what one gains through faith is knowledge, too, the knowledge revealed by God. That is why the act of faith, for Aquinas, is—indeed, has to be—an intellectual act, an act of assent, for only through such an act can a person acquire knowledge. “Faith,” as Aquinas asserts categorically, “is a kind of knowledge, inasmuch as the intellect is determined by faith to some knowable object” (I, 12, 13, ad 3; p. 111).

True, Aquinas does not simply equate with knowledge what the faithful gain through faith, for he is keenly aware that knowledge is based on “vision,” whereas faith for all its superior certitude does not involve an assent compelled by evidence. This difference, however, does not, in Aquinas’s eyes, invalidate the analogy between what is gained through the natural use of reason and what is gained through faith, for the difference is only temporary and obtains only in this life, as he takes care to point out repeatedly: “the chief object of faith consists in those things which we hope to see in heaven” (II, IIae, 1, 6). “The object of the heavenly vision will be the First Truth seen in itself” (II, IIae, 1, 2, ad 3).

For Aquinas, as for Aristotle, the ultimate happiness of the human being consists in the contemplative fruition of truth. The difference between them is only that what Aristotle attributes to the natural strength of reason and limits to this earth, Aquinas sees fulfilled—partially and inchoatively in this world, fully in the world to come—thanks to a supernatural elevation of the intellect by God:

“... the perfection of the rational creature consists not only in what belongs to it according to its nature, but also in that which it acquires through a supernatural participation of the divine goodness. Hence it was said above that man’s ultimate happiness consists in a supernatural vision of God. To this vision man cannot attain unless he be taught by God... Now man acquires a share of this learning, not all at once, but a little at a time, according to the mode of his nature; and everyone who learns thus must needs believe, in order that he may acquire science in a perfect degree” (II, IIae, 2, 3).

The analogy between faith and reason and between their respective “objects”—supernatural or revealed truths and truths naturally accessible to us—literally underpins Aquinas’s notion of faith. [Unsurprisingly, since the *symbola fidei* were mistakenly taken for catalogs of truths to be assented to in faith, for factual statements rather than for what they are: confessions of faith. Hence, persuaded of the truth of the Christian faith, and convinced that truth and falsity apply only to statements, Aquinas could easily fall within

the gravitational pull of the Aristotelian epistemology, which sees judgments and the statements in which judgments are expressed as the only acts susceptible of truth and falsity. See Aquinas's own commentary on *De interpretatione*]. This is why—to give a couple of examples—he sees a perfect continuity and complementarity between the “doctrine revealed by God” and “the philosophical disciplines investigated by human reason.” This is why, too, his main concern, when he deals with the act of faith, is to situate faith in relation to such other cognitional acts as opining, doubting, suspecting, and knowing, all of which belong within the epistemic order, rather than to other acts which are not purely cognitional, such as loving, or entrusting oneself into somebody's hands, as Christ did on the cross.

God as the Formal Object of Faith

Let us return to our quarry—the object of faith as understood by Aquinas. Aquinas's Christian tradition makes him clearly aware that the term of the faith-relationship is God himself. Faith is faith in God, whatever else the relationship may involve. That awareness was in fact what, concerning the act of faith, led him to declare, as we saw in the last chapter, that the assent to what God reveals is only secondary, while the trust in God is the principal. Correlatively, then, concerning the object of faith, he also has to introduce some sort of distinction between what is principal and what is secondary. And so he does. However, there has to be correspondence between the way in which he conceives the act of faith and the way in which he conceives the object of the act of faith. Now, given that his analysis of the act of faith practically bypassed what he nevertheless called “the principal,” that is, the trust in the God who reveals, and placed all the emphasis on the assent to the truths revealed by God, unsurprisingly the correlative distinction concerning the object of faith will displace the focus from God Himself to the truths revealed by God. Indeed, the “principal” in the “object” of faith, as we will see, is not God Himself, as it was for the Fathers, but rather certain of the truths revealed by God.

Saying that the object of faith is the First Truth, however correct that may be, is insufficient. For the fact is, as Aquinas well realizes, that Christians believe—that is, adhere or assent through faith to—many things. In fact, they adhere through faith, at least implicitly, to as many things as are contained in the Holy Scripture, for “Holy Scripture is the rule of faith, to which no addition or subtraction can lawfully be made” (II, IIae, 1, 9, obj. 1; 1070). Accordingly, the Christian “is prepared to believe whatever is contained in the Holy Scripture” (II, IIae, 2, 5; 1081). Now, all these are truths of faith. How can this multiplicity of truths cohere with the fact that faith is faith in God? Aquinas answers by distinguishing between the material and the formal object of faith:

“The object of every cognitive habit includes two things: first, that which is known materially, and is the material object, so to speak; and, secondly, that whereby it is known, which is the formal aspect of the object...

“Accordingly, if in faith we consider the formal aspect of the object, it is nothing else than the First Truth. For the faith of which we are speaking does not assent to anything, except because it is revealed by God. If, however, we consider the things to which faith assents, they include not only God, but also many other things, which, nevertheless, do not come under the assent of faith except as bearing some relation to God...” (II, IIae, 1, 1; 1056).

It might seem that under the names of the “formal” and the “material” object of faith Aquinas is just distinguishing “the principal,” which is God, and “the secondary,” which are the truths revealed by God. For the distinction is between the truths revealed by God and assented to by the believer, on the one hand, and the motive for the assent given to them, on the other, which is God’s veracity. The truths believed are multiple, but the motive is one and the same, namely, the fact that they are revealed, that is, supported by the infallible authority of the First Truth.

Had Aquinas stopped at this point, the way in which he conceives the object of faith could, perhaps, still be identified with the tradi-

tional understanding of the term of the faith-relationship. Unfortunately, the gravitational pull of the Aristotelian epistemology by which he has been captured forces Aquinas to alter significantly the idea of the formal object of faith he just presented.

A Different Idea of the Formal Object of Faith: The Unseen Truths

In reply to an objection Aquinas introduces a further distinction regarding the formal object of faith:

“The formal aspect of the object of faith can be taken in two ways: first, on the part of the thing believed, and thus there is one formal aspect of all matters of faith, viz. the First Truth; and from this point of view there is no distinction of articles. Secondly, the formal aspect of a matter of faith can be considered from our point of view, and thus the formal aspect of a matter of faith is that it is something unseen; and from this point of view there are various distinct articles of faith...” (II, IIae, 1, 6, ad 2).

The distinction between the formal object of faith “on the part of the thing believed,” on the one hand, and “from our point of view,” on the other, seems innocent enough. And it would, indeed, be innocent if the truths that are assented to by the believer because they are revealed by the First Truth were coextensive with the truths that are “unseen,” for in that case there would be one and the same formal object considered from two points of view. But if that is not the case, then what Aquinas has done by means of this distinction is to shift to a different idea of the formal object of faith from the one he had previously presented. And this, I think, is what has happened here. For in the first view presented by Aquinas the formal object covers all the truths that are object of faith, since each and all of them are revealed by the First Truth and are to be assented to by the believer for that very reason, while in the second view the formal object covers only those revealed truths which are “unseen,” that is, which are not themselves evident and cannot be rationally demonstrated. Thus Aquinas’s distinction between the formal object of faith “on the part of the thing believed” and “from our point of view” does

not refer to one and the same formal object; it introduces a different formal object of faith. And it is by means of this second conception of the object of faith as that which is unseen that Aquinas will clearly identify God-the-object-of-faith with truths to be assented to. Indeed, from now on, as we will presently see, the First Truth as the object of faith, which Aquinas had designated as the principal, will disappear; what will remain is a distinction within the “the secondary,” that is, among the truths revealed, some of which will now become the principal, while some will be the secondary object of faith.

The Essential and the Secondary Object of Faith

There is a hierarchy among the truths revealed by God. Let us have Aquinas speak for himself on this important point:

“Some things proposed to our belief are in themselves of faith, while others are of faith, not in themselves, but only in relation to others... Now, since the chief object of faith consists in those things which we hope to see in heaven..., it follows that those things are in themselves of faith which order us directly to eternal life. Such are the Trinity of Persons in Almighty God, the mystery of Christ’s Incarnation, and the like; and these are distinct articles of faith. On the other hand, certain things in Holy Scripture are proposed to our belief, not chiefly on their own account, but for the manifestation of those mentioned above, e. g., that Abraham had two sons, that a dead man rose again at the touch of Eliseus’ bones, and the like, which are related in Holy Scripture for the purpose of manifesting the divine majesty or the Incarnation of Christ; and such things should not form distinct articles” (II, IIae, 1, 6, ad 1; 1064). (My emphasis).

The same is repeated in slightly different words two articles later:

“As was stated above, to faith those things belong essentially, the sight of which we shall enjoy in eternal life, and by which we are brought to eternal life. Now two things are proposed to us to be seen in eternal life, viz., the secret of the Godhead, to see which is

to possess happiness, and the mystery of Christ's Incarnation..." (II, IIae, 1, 8; 1068).

And again:

"We must, therefore, say that the direct object of faith is that whereby man is made one of the Blessed, as was stated above, while the indirect and secondary object comprises all things delivered by God to us in Holy Scripture, for instance, that Abraham had two sons, that David was the son of Jesse, and so forth. Therefore, as regards the primary points or articles of faith, man must believe them explicitly, just as he must have faith; but as to other points of faith, man is not bound to believe them explicitly, but only implicitly, or to be ready to believe them, in so far as he is prepared to believe whatever is contained in the divine Scriptures. Then alone is he bound to believe such things explicitly, when it is clear to him that they are contained in the doctrine of faith" (II, IIae, 2, 5; 1081). (My emphasis).

Finally, a text in which Aquinas explicitly connects his second, more restrained conception of the formal object of faith, with the truths that are of faith absolutely:

"Nevertheless, that which is proposed to be believed equally by all is equally unknown by all as an object of science. Such are the things which are of faith absolutely. Consequently, faith and science are not about the same things" (II, IIae, 1, 5; 1062).

It is only natural to ask what prompts Aquinas to introduce this hierarchy among the truths revealed by God, given that, as he himself repeatedly points out, all the truths revealed by the First Truth, from the greatest to the smallest, from the secret of the Godhead to the fact that David was Jesse's son, commit God's veracity equally and are, therefore, to be believed equally by the faithful. The basic reason for this, I surmise, is the weight of the Christian tradition as reflected in the Symbola, the tradition on which Aquinas depends and to which he has the firm intention of remaining loyal. As remarked in the previous chapter, the traditional notion of faith does

not primarily concentrate on the truths revealed by God but on God Himself as the term of the faith-relationship. However, forced by his intellectualistic, epistemic conception of faith, Aquinas's focus has shifted from God to the (FACTUAL) truths revealed by God. It is, therefore, among these truths that he has to find a privileged place for God as the central object of faith, in order to satisfy himself as to the continuity of his views with the tradition. That is what he does by designating certain revealed truths "concerning God" (II, IIae, 1, 6; 1063) as the direct or essential object of faith and relegating the others to a secondary place.

That this is the main reason for the hierarchy Aquinas establishes among the truths of faith is suggested by the fact that he repeatedly identifies the truths that constitute "what is of faith absolutely" with the articles of the Creed that deal with God. This identification is not casual, for the Fathers themselves had insisted that the Christian faith finds its natural and sanctioned expression in the official confessions of faith, in which God clearly appears as the term of faith-relationship and which typically reserve to God the solecistic construction that expresses the faith-relationship: "Credo in unum Deum, Patrem omnipotentem... et in unum Dominum Iesum Christum... et in Spiritum Sanctum Dominum et vivificantem..." In fact, Aquinas is so keen in maintaining his continuity with the tradition that, precisely in connection with the symbols of faith, he specifically excludes even the Church from being part of the direct object of faith, as the Fathers had also done:

"If we say 'In' the holy Catholic Church, this must be taken as verified in so far as our faith is directed to the Holy Ghost, Who sanctifies the Church; so that the sense is: I believe in the Holy Ghost sanctifying the Church. But it is better and more in keeping with the common use to omit the in, and say simply, the holy Catholic Church, as Pope Leo observes" (II, IIae, 1, 10, ad 5; 1071-1072).

What Aquinas fails to notice is that his distinction between the direct and the secondary object of faith does not coincide at all with the traditional understanding of the object of faith, which is God

Himself. For his distinction concerning the object of faith is not between God Himself and the truths revealed by Him, but rather between certain of “the things proposed to our belief,” which are “essential, namely, the truths about God contained in the Creed,” and certain other revealed truths which are “secondary,” “like the fact that somebody resuscitated at the touch of Eliseus’s bones or that Abraham had two sons.” This difference, I maintain, corresponds to two entirely different views of the faith-relationship, as it will now be explained.

Belief in God Almighty, or Belief That God Is Almighty?

The displacement of the principal in the object of faith from God Himself to certain of the truths revealed that are directly about God does not go without problems. For if faith is reduced to assenting to certain truths, even if the truths are about God rather than about other matters only indirectly related to God, one can hardly see how God can be “the principal” in faith.

No doubt, Aquinas sensed that his idea of the object of faith involved this danger, for he himself raises the question “whether the object of faith is a proposition?” (II, IIae, 1, 2) and objects to himself that believing in God is very different from believing statements about God. The objection, as voiced by Aquinas, is the following:

“The exposition of faith is contained in the symbol. Now the symbol does not contain propositions, but things; for it is not stated therein that God is almighty, but: I believe in God... almighty. Therefore the object of faith is not a proposition but a thing” (II, IIae, 1, 2, obj. 2).

Aquinas’s answer is two-pronged. One of the spikes of his fork deals with the propositional form, the other with the substance of what is believed. In regard to the propositional form, he argues that the nature of the intellect is such that we know whatever we know by “composition and division,” that is, by affirmative or negative judgments through which we attribute (“composition”) or refuse to attribute (“division”) a certain property to a subject, which is what

propositions express. Thus, yes, the expression of the judgment by which the intellect assents to a truth of faith has to take the grammatical form of an affirmative proposition, for such is the nature of the human intellect. [HE SHOULD HAVE DISTINGUISHED BETWEEN THE SITUATED AGENT'S PRACTICAL JUDGMENTS INVOLVED IN DECISIONS, WHICH REFER TO OBJECT FOR RESPONSE AND ARE MEANT APPLICATIVELY, AND THE REFLECTIVE JUDGMENTS THAT ARE NOT DIRECTLY CONNECTED WITH DECISION]. However, in regard to the substance, that is, to what is actually believed or assented to, Aquinas remarks that the assent of faith does not terminate in the proposition itself but in "the thing," that is, the reality meant by the proposition. Now, though "the thing" believed—is in itself simple, our mode of knowing it is complex, for it predicates or refuses to predicate something of a subject. (II, IIae, 1, 2). [THIS DOESN'T ANSWER THE QUESTION, FOR THE QUESTION IS WHETHER THE REALITY KNOWN IS "FACTUAL", THAT IS, PURELY OBJECTIVE FACT TO BE ASSENTED TO, OR RATHER "OBJECT FOR RESPONSE," TERM OF AN ON-GOING, LIVING, PERSONAL RELATIONSHIP].

Has Aquinas solved the problem? Only apparently, I think, and only because he himself raises the objection in a form that suggests that what creates the problem is the wrongheaded idea nobody has that the assent involved in a judgment and expressed in a proposition is assent to the proposition itself rather than to the reality judged by the judgment and meant by the proposition. Given this, Aquinas has a very easy way out of the problem by explaining that, although the 'knowledge' of faith is propositional, it really is assent to God, to whom the propositions of the Symbol refer, not to the propositions themselves. But this answer misses completely the substance of the objection, which is that the term of the faith-relationship is of an entirely different kind from that of the objects of knowledge as Aristotle conceived them and of which Aquinas is speaking.

Actually, the objection expresses one of the most serious misgivings of all those anti-Aristotelians and non-Aristotelians who

doubted that the Aristotelian intellectualist conception of knowledge could accommodate the faith-relationship without denaturing it. For the Aristotelian epistemic framework within which Aquinas has placed the act of faith, is apt, by the very nature of the purely epistemic interests by which Aristotle was guided, only to fit objects of knowledge-assent, but God, who is the term of the faith-relationship, is not, and cannot be reduced to, an object of knowledge, to a “knowable object,” to a reality or an existent being in the Aristotelian sense, to an *epistatōn*. [THE FEUERBACHIAN DISTINCTION BETWEEN “OBJEKT” AND “GEGESTAND,” WHICH NEATLY SEPARATES OBJECT OF AFFECTION FROM OBJECT OF KNOWLEDGE AND ATTRIBUTES OBJECTIVITY ONLY TO THE LATTER, MAY HELP TO EXPLAIN THIS POINT. (Cf. Delhougne, pp. 536-537, and see my “99-nov-1” on Barth et la connaissance de Dieu, pp. 1 and 2)]. This is why in the Nicæan Creed, which genuinely expresses the Christian faith, God doesn’t figure, even grammatically, as direct object of its “articles of faith,” for the direct object is constituted by “facts.” Indeed, the Christian confession of faith, the Christian “I believe,” has not as its term or correlate a series of propositions about God—that God exists, that God is almighty, etc. Calvin was not wrong when he reminded us in his *Institutiones*, that the Christian faith does not consist primarily in believing that God is almighty, but in believing in God almighty. [This is what Aquinas tried to capture, but failed, in his distinction between believing in propositions and in the things to which the propositions refer]. And, correlatively, the act of faith does not consist in assenting to the fact that God is almighty, but in a practical, personal rather than purely intellectual commitment of the Christian to God almighty. Consequently, even if we grant Aquinas that the proposition “God is Almighty” refers to a reality (to a “thing”), and that what is assented to is “the thing” rather than the proposition, the fact remains that his answer does not meet the objection, much less does it solve it. And since the objection is that his intellectualistic, epistemic notion of faith does not do justice to the Christian faith, it seems to put in the right all those “anti-Aristotelians” and

reluctant “non-Aristotelians” who considered impossible the marriage between their Christian faith and Aristotelian reason.

In any case, the issue of “believing that God ...” and “believing in God” will reappear in the next chapter. Then we will have a further opportunity to reconsider whether what I just said distorts or misinterprets Aquinas’s views. For the moment, let us explore other serious problems that attend his treatment of the object of faith, due to the tension between the demands of his Aristotelian epistemology and the demands of his faith.

Between Faith with Vision and Faith without Vision

The tension I am referring to is located on the line at which reason and faith touch each other, and the tremors are felt by Aquinas precisely in connection with those truths of faith which are also accessible to reason or, what is the same, in connection with those truths which are both object of faith because they are revealed and object of knowledge because they are rationally demonstrable. The tension, as we shall presently see, is such that it constrains Aquinas to waver between two incompatible positions, which is in itself significant.

Position #1: No truth which is object of faith can be rationally demonstrated

Inquiring “whether the object of faith can be something seen,” Aquinas replies by distinguishing the assent involved in faith, which rests on God’s authority, from the assent involved in knowledge on the basis that only the latter is prompted by evidence. From this he draws the following conclusion:

“Now those things are said to be seen which, of themselves, move the intellect or the senses to knowledge of them. Therefore it is evident that neither faith nor opinion can be of things seen either by the senses or by the intellect” (II, IIae, 1, 4; 1060).

The denial that what is object of faith can be rationally demonstrated is categorical, unconditional, because it necessarily follows from the very way in which Aquinas conceives and defines the act

of faith. Indeed, if what essentially distinguishes believing from knowing is the absence of compelling evidence in the case of believing, then necessarily, by definition, that is, without any possible exception, what is object of faith cannot be object of knowledge, and what is object of knowledge cannot be object of faith. In other words, if a truth can be rationally demonstrated, it cannot be a truth of faith, for it is impossible to “believe” and “know” the same object, since knowledge includes vision and faith excludes it. One can believe something because one does not know that it is true. But if one knows that it is true, one cannot believe it. This is what I call position #1.

By the way, this is the position that authorizes those who think that Aquinas reached a perfectly harmonious synthesis between faith and reason that in a previous chapter I presented as possibly being Aquinas’s view. Indeed, what we have in this case is a relationship between reason and faith in which they complete each other without in any way interfering with each other, so that there is no possibility at all of conflict between them—not even apparent conflict, since they have different objects. According to this view, faith and reason touch each other in matters related to religion, but they do not interfere with each other, because in these matters there are two different kinds of truths: on the one hand, truths which exceed the possibilities of reason left to itself, which are revealed by God, and which are object of faith; on the other hand, truths which are accessible to reason left to itself, which are not revealed by God, and which are object of knowledge. In this case, the synthesis between faith and reason is perfectly harmonious, for each of them has its proper, self-contained, and well-defined sphere within which each is autonomous. However, as we will see in a moment, Aquinas also holds a very different view concerning the demonstrability of the truths which are object of faith, which of course implies a different view of the relationship between faith and reason. That is what prevented me from claiming that Aquinas achieved a real synthesis between faith and reason, as his sanguine admirers claim he did.

The advantage of position #1 is that it is fully consistent with THE ARISTOTELIAN EPISTEMIC FRAMEWORK WITHIN WHICH AQUINAS HAS PLACED THE ACT OF FAITH AS DISTINCT FROM OTHER ACTS OF THE INTELLECT. Unfortunately, it has the enormous disadvantage of failing to square with the data of the Christian faith. For it reduces the object of faith to those truths which are inaccessible to human reason left to its own strength, thereby excluding from the Christian faith such basic truths as, for instance, God's existence, which Aquinas deems to be rationally demonstrable. That, precisely, is the problem that constrained Aquinas to shift to what I call position #2.

Before considering this second position, let us reflect on Aquinas's quandary. If he sticks by solution #1, he saves his Aristotelian notion of faith AS AN INTELLECTUAL ACT OF ASSENT, but he detracts from the object of his faith. However, if in order to save the integrity of the object of his faith he grants that certain truths which are object of faith can be demonstrated, as he will actually do by adopting position #2, he is bound to give up his notion of the act of faith, for according to it what is believed cannot possibly be known, and what is known cannot possibly be believed. Yet, Aquinas will adopt solution #2 without renouncing his notion of the act of faith as assent. Is that feasible? If so, at what price?

Position #2: Certain truths which are object of faith can be rationally demonstrated

In the second question of the Summa Aquinas maintains that God's existence can be demonstrated. Actually, he proposes no less than "five ways" of demonstrating it (I, 2, 3; 21-22). This, however, forces him to confront the following objection:

"It seems that the existence of God cannot be demonstrated. For it is an article of faith that God exists. But what is of faith cannot be demonstrated, because a demonstration produces scientific knowledge, whereas faith is of the unseen..." (I, 2, 2, obj. 1; p. 20).

Aquinas replies:

“The existence of God and other like truths about God, which can be known by natural reason, are not articles of faith, but are preambles to the articles; for faith presupposes natural knowledge, even as grace presupposes nature and perfection the perfectible. Nevertheless, there is nothing to prevent a man, who cannot grasp a proof, from accepting, as a matter of faith, something which in itself is capable of being scientifically known and demonstrated” (Ibid., ad 1).

We should remark that what Aquinas denies is that the existence of God and other like truths about God are articles of faith, not that they are object of faith. This corresponds, of course, to the way the objection is raised by Aquinas himself, where it is argued that those truths are “articles of faith.” Now, what Aquinas means by “articles of faith” are the truths concerning God that are contained in the “*symbola fidei*.” However, as repeatedly acknowledged by Aquinas himself, the *symbola fidei* do not contain all the truths that are object of faith, for Holy Scripture contains many truths that are of faith which are not to be found in the *Symbola fidei* and are nonetheless part of the material object of faith, such as that Abraham had two sons and that David was the son of Jesse.

If Aquinas were denying that the existence of God and other like truths—“the preambles to the articles”—are object of faith, he would still be sticking to position #1. But he is not. For he is implicitly conceding that “the preambles” can—and, indeed, need to—be “accepted as a matter of faith” by a person “who cannot grasp a proof,” though they are “something which in itself is susceptible of being scientifically known and demonstrated.” Thus, Aquinas has already abandoned his previous stand which reduced the object of faith to those revealed truths that cannot be known. For he had previously asserted, as a necessary and unconditional conclusion based on the nature of the act of faith, that what is object of knowledge cannot be object of faith, whereas now he is asserting that it can, provided that the person who believes be not the same as the person who knows.

In any case, even if the text I have been commenting upon were ambiguous enough to authorize the view that Aquinas does not think that “the preambles” are object of faith (as all those who sing the praises of Aquinas’s perfectly harmonious synthesis between faith and reason would have to argue), the texts we will consider now clearly show the contrary.

Precisely in answer to the question “whether it is necessary to believe those things which can be proved by natural reason?” Aquinas writes:

“I answer that, It is necessary for man to receive by faith not only things which are above reason, but also those known by reason; and this for three motives. First, in order that man may arrive more quickly at the knowledge of divine truth. For the science to whose province it belongs to prove the existence of God and many other such truths is the last of all to offer itself to human inquiry, since it presupposes many other sciences; so that it would be far along in life that man would arrive at the knowledge of God. The second reason is, in order that the knowledge of God may be more widespread. For many are unable to make progress in the study of science...; and all these persons would be altogether deprived of the knowledge of God, unless divine things were brought to their knowledge by way of faith. The third reason is for the sake of certitude. For human reason is very deficient in things concerning God. A sign of this is that philosophers, in their inquiry of human affairs by human investigation, have fallen into many errors, and have disagreed among themselves. [THIS INVOLVES AN IMPLICIT RECOGNITION THAT THE TRUTHS OF FAITH ARE OBJECTS OF KNOWLEDGE, EPISTATA, THOUGH NOT ALL OF THEM ARE ACCESSIBLE TO REASON LEFT TO ITS OWN DEVICES, FOR THAT IS WHAT PHILOSOPHERS ARE ABOUT]. And consequently, in order that men might have knowledge of God, free of doubt and uncertainty, it was necessary for divine truths to be delivered to them by way of faith, being told by God Himself, Who cannot lie” (II, IIae, 2, 4; 1079). (My translation)

This text, I think, is unambiguous. Now, if the ambiguous passages in an author's work are to be understood in the light of the unambiguous ones, then the text on which I commented immediately before this one has to be understood in the same sense as this one. And what this one affirms is that "it is necessary for man to receive by faith not only things which are above reason, but also those known by reason," among which the "preambles" are obviously to be counted.

In this way, Aquinas has restored its full extension to the object of faith, which position #1 necessarily reduced to those revealed truths which exceed human reason left to its own strength. Indeed, position #2 extends the quality of object of faith to all the truths revealed by God, whether or not they are rationally demonstrable. In addition, position #2 seems to satisfy the requirements of his Aristotelian notion of the act of faith, which—this is new, too—only demands that the same truth be not object of faith and of belief for the same person:

"... it is impossible that one and the same thing should be believed and seen by the same person. Hence it is equally impossible for one and the same thing to be an object of science and of belief for the same person" (II, IIae, 1, 5).

It was, therefore, in accordance with this new position that, concerning "the preambles," Aquinas pointed out in the previous text that the same truth can be object of faith for the Christian capable of grasping a proof for God's existence and object of belief for the Christian incapable of such grasp. The former knows that God exists; for the latter it is a matter of faith.

But is this second position more satisfactory than the first? Hardly so. For it implies that the object of faith is not constituted as such by the fact that it is revealed by God—which is the way in which Aquinas himself defined the material object of faith—but by the comparative intellectual ability of people. For there are truths revealed by God that are not object of faith for the more intelligent Christians because they know them. By the same token, it also

implies that the object of faith is not the same for all Christians, depending on their intelligence, so that what is part of the faith of the less intelligent Christians is not part of the faith of the more intelligent ones.

The only semblance of a solution furnished by Aquinas is that “that which is proposed to be believed equally by all is equally unknown by all as an object of science. Such are the things which are of faith absolutely. Consequently, faith and science are not about the same things” (II, IIae, 1, 5; 1062).

However, it is clear that this passage corresponds to position #1, where “faith and science are not about the same things” and only those “things which are of faith absolutely” and constitute the formal object of faith “from our point of view” are really object of faith rather than of knowledge. But position #2 affirms that “it is necessary... to receive by faith not only things which are above reason, but also those known by reason” (II, IIae, 2, 4; 1079). And it is precisely about the latter that the problem arises, for they are object of faith only for the less intelligent, with the unavoidable result that the object of the Christian faith is different for different Christians depending on their intelligence. Thus, the proposed solution is no solution.

The above problems regard the object of faith. Even on the subject’s side, however, that is, even on the believer’s side, position #2 has a corresponding serious drawback. Indeed, as realized by Aquinas, if the more intelligent Christians cannot accept by faith what they know, then the merit of their faith is less than that of the less intelligent. For evidence compels assent and leaves no room for the prompting of the intellect by the will moved by God’s grace to accept what is revealed, in which the merit resides. Considering this obvious objection, Aquinas replies:

“Now human reasons in support of what we believe may stand in a twofold relation to the will of the believer. First, as preceding the act of the will, as, for instance, when a man either has not the will, or not a prompt will, to believe, unless he be moved by human

reasons; and in this way human reasoning diminishes the merit of faith... Secondly, human reasons may be consequent to the will of the believer. For when a man has a will ready to believe, he loves the truth he believes, he thinks out and takes to heart whatsoever reasons he can find in support thereof; and in this way, human reasoning does not exclude the merit of faith..." (II, IIae, 2, 10).

This reply comes in answer to the question "whether reasons in support of what we believe lessen the merit of faith?" Evidently, Aquinas denies that such is necessarily the case. But as to the reason for that answer, the passage strikes me as highly ambiguous.

One way in which the passage can be understood is that it is possible for a Christian to believe and to know the same truth, provided that the Christian believe it before knowing it by way of evidence, for this manifests the person's will to believe it even if it were undemonstrable. However, this interpretation in terms of temporal priority seems unpromising, for then the person who converted to the Christian faith after having known God's existence through one of Aquinas's five ways would be at a disadvantage in terms of merit of faith, which is what Aquinas is trying to protect here. Perhaps, then, the passage is to be understood, not in terms of temporal priority, but of the ultimately determinant reason for the person's assent. If the person assented because the particular truth is demonstrated, and would not be willing to believe it if it were not demonstrated, then there is no room for the merit of faith. But if the person would be willing to believe that truth because it is revealed, even if it were undemonstrable, then the merit is preserved.

Both of these interpretations would extricate Aquinas from the problem he is facing. But in both cases he would be forced to sacrifice his Aristotelian, epistemic notion of faith, which makes it absolutely impossible for the same person to believe and know the same object, as would have to be the case in either of the previous interpretations. However, since Aquinas did not feel constrained to give up his view of the act of faith as intellectual assent, the only acceptable interpretation of the passage seems to be the following:

When a Christian knows something, then that Christian cannot anymore accept it by faith, for faith and knowledge are mutually exclusive in the same person. Nonetheless, the merit of faith is not diminished if the determinant reason for the assent is not the evidence of the truth, so that the person would believe it even if it were undemonstrable.

That this is what Aquinas actually meant is confirmed by the way in which he answers an objection raised in the same article:

“... though demonstrative reasons in support of the preambles of faith, but not of the articles of faith, diminish the measure of faith, since they make the thing believed to be seen; yet they do not diminish the measure of charity, which makes the will ready to believe them even if they were unseen. And so the merit is not diminished” (II, IIae, 2, 10, ad 2; 1090).

Now, if this solution renders back to the more intelligent Christians the merit that they seemed to have lost, it sends Aquinas right back onto the other horn of the dilemma that concerns the object of faith, for now the object of faith for the less intelligent is different and more reduced in extension from the object of faith of the more intelligent, given that the more intelligent do not have to accept by faith certain of the truths revealed by God. To use Aquinas’s own expression, the measure of faith of the more intelligent is diminished by comparison to that of the less intelligent.

In this way, Aquinas may have saved his Aristotelian conception of the act of faith, but at the price of a very dubious continuity with the way in which faith has been understood in the Christian tradition. For not only has he displaced the term or correlate of faith from God to truths about God, but he has ended up affirming, by implication, that certain of the truths revealed by God are not object of faith, at least not for the more intelligent of the faithful.

Needless to say, unless I have misunderstood Aquinas completely, this chapter shows that the idea that he achieved a real synthesis between faith and reason is highly problematic. For, if we

identify Aquinas with position #1, then there is no possible conflict at all between reason and faith, but in that case the object of faith is reduced to those revealed truths which exceed human reason. And if we identify Aquinas with position #2, then what determines what is to be accepted by faith is not that it is revealed by God but the measure of intelligence of different Christians.

It is too early, however, to hazard firm conclusions as to whether Aquinas's conception of faith coheres with the Christian experience and with the traditional understanding and, consequently, whether his synthesis of faith and reason is or is not valid. Let us reserve such conclusions for the time when all the data are in. For we still have to explore Aquinas's position concerning the nature of theology, which may throw additional light on this subject.

Chapter 7: Revelation, Theology, and the Bible

Of all the people actively involved in the process of placing theology on the map of the sciences, only Bonaventure and Aquinas could positively entertain the idea that they had achieved the elusive synthesis between the demands of reason as conceived by Aristotle and the demands of their faith. To achieve that synthesis both of them had recourse to the Aristotelian theory of the subordination between sciences to insure the scientific autonomy of theology while preserving its ties to faith. Theology, they reasoned, is a science subordinated to faith much as medicine, according to Aristotle, is subordinated to mathematics without thereby losing either its autonomy or its scientific character. However, Bonaventure and Aquinas differed as to the character and the actual measure of the independence of theology from faith.

Bonaventure and Aquinas: Two syntheses

For all practical purposes, if not clearly in theory, Bonaventure made theology into a science genuinely independent from faith, having with the latter only the extrinsic connection of partially sharing with it the same material object, but differing radically from it because of their *different* respective formal objects—the “*credibile ut credibile*,” for faith, and the “*credibile ut intelligibile*,” for theology.

Aquinas tried a different route. Theology, according to him, is only a “*quasi-scientia*,” for it not only takes its principles from faith to examine them by the light of reason and to draw conclusions from

them by combining them with other truths of faith or of reason, but *accepts its principles by faith*. In other words, theology is not genuinely independent as a scientific discipline, for the theologian not only works on and with principles that come from the domain of faith, but continues to assent to them by faith while working rationally on them and with them. There is, therefore, no bracketing of faith, either real or even purely methodical, in theology. Theology is not a special branch of philosophy, as it would have to be the case in Bonaventure's view; it is radically different from philosophy, in particular from the special branch of philosophy that deals with matters pertaining to God, for the basic principles of theology on which all its conclusions depend are revealed truths assented to as such by the theologian. On this point Aquinas is unequivocal:

"Sciences are diversified according to the diverse nature of their knowable objects... Hence there is no reason why those things which are treated by the philosophical disciplines, so far as they can be known by the light of natural reason, may not also be treated by another science so far as they are known by the light of the divine revelation. Hence the theology included in sacred doctrine differs in genus from that theology which is part of philosophy" (I, 1, 1, ad 2).

These are, of course, two very different conceptions of theology which correspond to very different syntheses—or very different attempts at a synthesis—between faith and reason. Bonaventure's, in fact, Aquinas would rightly claim, is not a synthesis at all, but a veiled sacrifice of faith to reason. For it actually establishes two realms—the realm of faith and the realm of reason, and simply transfers the intelligibility of the object of faith to the domain of reason. The dangers of the Averroistic view of the 'two truths,' that is, two different and unrelated orders of truth—reason and faith—, of pure fideism and, as an unavoidable consequence in the long run, of the dismissal by reason of all those elements of the object of faith that do not live up to its standards loom very large. As for Aquinas, who without being more attached to his faith than Bonaventure was certainly more perceptive than him as to the conditions required for preserving its integrity, he constructed a very different and, in his

eyes, successful synthesis by keeping theology strictly subordinated to faith.

Not that Aquinas's way is unproblematic, as we have seen in the last two chapters. Hard as he tries to keep in balance the demands of his Aristotelian epistemology applied to faith with the demands of his faith, not only is the conflictive tension between the two detectable in his works, but the Aristotelian gravitational pull seems to be the ultimately determinant one, with consequences for the integrity of the faith he so much loved that render his success doubtful.

We move now to the exploration of the way in which Aquinas conceives the relationship between revelation, Scripture, and theology. Since all of the issues we have so far encountered have to converge at the point at which *Aristotelian reason, represented by theology* [OR, RATHER, BY PHILOSOPHY?], and faith, represented by the Bible, concretely touch each other, we are not likely to find a more appropriate field to gauge the success of Aquinas's synthesis.

The issue of literary genres

For Bonaventure, as we saw in chapter four, there is no problem in the shift in literary genres from the Bible to theology, for their respective objects are different. The Bible deals with the revealed as object of faith (*credibile ut credibile*); theology deals with the revealed as object of reason (*credibile ut intelligibile*). Avowedly, there is in the passage from the one to the other a *determinatio distrahens*, a shift of 'paradigms,' a radical change of epistemological regimes that involves a genuine change of "objects," to which corresponds the clear difference between the literary genres of the Bible and of theological works. The Scripture's fundamental literary genre is "*revelativus*," whereas the literary genre of the work by a theologian, say, the Lombard's *Book of Sentences*, is "*inquisitivus*" or "*argumentativus*," in a word, scientific.

Things stand very differently for Aquinas. For he denies that a *determinatio distrahens* occurs at all in the passage from faith to theology, since the object of faith is the same as the object of

theology. The revealed enters into theology as revealed, not merely as object of rational inquiry, as Bonaventure holds. Consequently, unlike Bonaventure, Aquinas is faced with the problem of explaining the rather striking difference between the literary genre or genres of the Holy Scripture and, say, his own *Summa Theologica*.

Most unfortunately, Aquinas does not confront the problem squarely, as Bonaventure certainly does. As a consequence, his position lacks the sharpness of Bonaventure's. *From the way he treats the relationship between Scripture and theology one senses that he is obscurely dealing with the same issue as Bonaventure, but he never comes to formulate it as definitely as Bonaventure does nor, one gathers, to realize its urgency and importance.* As a result, Aquinas's reader has to glean tentatively here and there and infer the solution that the data seem to imply and support.

To avoid getting lost in this complex issue it might be useful to *formulate clearly Aquinas's options*. It would seem that, since he holds that the object of theology is the same as the object of faith, the only solution open to him is to deny that there is a radical difference between the literary genre of the Bible and the literary genre of a theological work. In this case, however, he has either to assert that the fundamental literary genre of theology is "*revelativus*," as is the literary genre of the Bible, or that the literary genre of the Bible is "*inquisitivus*" or "*argumentativus*," as is the literary genre of a theological work. Now, it suffices to realize what is implied by either of these alternatives in order to understand how thorny, indeed, is the problem Aquinas has in his hands. For, in the first place, in both cases he has to go against the rather clear intuition that there is a profound difference between the literary genres of the Bible and of a theological work like the *Summa*. What is more serious still, if he reduces the "*modus inquisitivus*" of theology to the "*modus revelativus*" of the Bible, this seems to imply that all theological conclusions are object of faith; and if he does the inverse, he seems to imply that the content of the Bible is only as good as the evidence by which it is or may be supported. Obviously, both implications

are equally unacceptable, for in the first case reason is absorbed by faith, and in the second case faith is absorbed by reason.

Now, as I just said, Aquinas did not see the problem in these sharp terms. *My opinion, however, based on the data we will presently examine, is that he maintains that there is no shift in literary genres between the Bible and theology because revelation itself is analogous to knowledge. This amounts to saying that the Bible is itself a scientific work.*

Aquinas's basic equation

The material that concerns us now is to be found in the very first question of the *Summa*, where, under the title of “The nature and domain of sacred doctrine,” Aquinas attacks the closely related issues of the scientific character of theology and the relationship of theology to the Bible.

Already in the preceding chapter we came across Aquinas's idea of revelation, which appears in the first article of the *Summa*. *What God shares with us through revelation is knowledge, His own knowledge, a knowledge that is for Him intuitive and is assented to by us not because of its evidence for us but because of God's authority. In this life, therefore, what is revealed by God is object of faith for us, but will in the future life become object of vision.* Though not in all its details, this is the idea of revelation that emerges from Aquinas's sketch, in the first article of this section, of the complementarity between the “doctrine revealed by God” and “the philosophical disciplines investigated by reason.” There is reciprocal complementarity because in both cases it is a matter of *knowledge*, though the knowledge gained through reason is based on compelling evidence, whereas the knowledge imparted by God and gained through faith rests, for the time being, on God's authority.

How does the Bible relate to revelation, according to Aquinas? The Bible *is* revelation, concretely. In fact, the article on which I am commenting clearly refers to the Bible—“Scripture, inspired by God” (I, 1, *sed contra*). This is to say that Aquinas identifies mate-

rially the “doctrine revealed by God” with the text of the Scripture. That Aquinas makes and means to make such an identification of revelation with the text of the Scripture is indisputable, not only because of this article but because of the way in which he speaks about the Scripture throughout the *Summa*. Indeed, this is why, as we saw in the preceding chapter, the Christian is—must be—“prepared to believe whatever is contained in the divine Scriptures” (II, IIae, 2, 5; 1081).

We have here in a nutshell the basis on which Aquinas will approach the issue of the possibility of theology as a science, on the one hand, and of the respective literary genres of the Bible and theology, on the other hand. This basis is constituted by the equation ‘revelation = knowledge = Holy Scripture.’ Indeed, if what is revealed by God is a sort of knowledge, a knowable (“a doctrine revealed by God”) in complementary continuity with the scientific knowledge of which Aristotle speaks (“the philosophical disciplines investigated by reason”), then there is no reason why theology couldn’t be quasi-scientific, since the revealed is itself quasi-scientific. The revealed is quasi-scientific, not scientific, because if, on the one hand, it possesses an infallibility superior to all purely rational knowledge, on the other hand (from our side, not from God’s side), it lacks the evidence that characterizes rational knowledge. Furthermore, since the revealed is itself quasi-scientific by its very nature, there is no *determinatio distrahens*, that is, no change in the nature of the revealed in the passage from the realm of faith to the realm of theology.

As to the issue concerning literary genres, the solution has to be parallel. Since the revealed is knowledge of a certain kind, and since the text of the Bible is identical with the revealed, the text of the Bible conveys knowledge. Consequently, the literary genre of the Holy Scripture is—indeed, it *has to be*—fundamentally the same as the genre of a theological work, namely, quasi-scientific. Therefore, whatever differences may be found between a theological work and the Bible are merely stylistic, superficial, and susceptible of being

explained by reference to the different ‘publics’ addressed by the Bible and by theological works.

Such is, to the best of my understanding, Aquinas’s position concerning the issue of literary genres of the Bible and of theological works. Let us now see whether the way in which the rest of this question is developed by Aquinas confirms my interpretation.

The literary genre of the Scripture

One of the most vexing features of Aquinas’s treatment of the issues related to the scientific status of theology is that, following the traces of all those who had participated in that controversy, he continues to use the same name—“sacred doctrine”—for both Scripture and theology. Needless to say, not only does this render difficult the reader’s task, but it creates for Aquinas himself a constant danger of gliding unwittingly from one meaning of the expression to the other and predicating of the Bible what belongs to theology. This, I think, is what happens in the particular case of the literary genre of the Bible.

After presenting his idea of revelation in the first article of the *Summa*, Aquinas moves to the issues that regard the scientific status of theology. Since we are already familiar with them, a quick glance will suffice to bring us to the articles concerning the literary genre of the Bible.

His central points are the following. First, theology is a science because its fundamental principles are “revealed by God” (Art. 2). Second, the unity of theology derives from its object, “because Sacred Scripture... considers things under the formality of being divinely revealed” (art. 3). Third, theology is both a speculative and a practical science, though “it is more speculative than practical, because it is more concerned with divine things than with human acts” (art. 4). Fourth, theology is nobler than other sciences “by reason of its greater certitude,” and “by reason of the higher dignity of its subject-matter.” Also because, “the purpose of this science in so far as it is practical, is eternal beatitude, to which as to an ultimate end the ends of all the practical sciences are directed” (art. 5). Fifth,

theology is “a wisdom,” that is a supreme science comparable to Aristotle’s metaphysics, because “sacred doctrine essentially treats of God viewed as the highest cause, for it treats of Him not only so far as He can be known through creatures just as philosophers knew Him... but also as far as *He is known to Himself alone and revealed to others*” (art. 6). Finally, the subject-matter of theology is God, and that is why this discipline is called theology (art. 7).

The vexing equivocation to which I referred above becomes positively harmful at the point where the relationship between theology and the Scripture comes to the fore and, therefore, when the issue of the respective literary genres of theology and the Scripture is to be decided. The question raised by Aquinas in article 8 is “whether sacred doctrine is argumentative?”

Since under the name of “sacred doctrine” he has been speaking of theology one presumes him to be asking whether theology is argumentative, that is, whether theology is a discipline whose procedures are at least analogical to those of the disciplines that Aristotle would classify as scientific. Surprisingly, Aquinas’s answer, which is affirmative, refers explicitly to the Bible too, not only to theology. Indeed, after establishing an analogy between theology and Aristotle’s metaphysics as to their use of principles, he concludes:

“Hence *Sacred Scripture*, since it has no science above itself, disputes argumentatively with one who denies its principles only if the opponent admits some at least of the truths obtained through divine revelation. Thus, we can argue with heretics from texts in Holy Scripture, and against those who deny one article of faith we can argue from another. If our opponent believes nothing of divine revelation, there is no longer any means of proving the articles of faith by argument, but only of answering his objections—if he has any—against faith. Since faith rests upon infallible truth, and since the contrary of a truth can never be demonstrated, it is clear that the proofs brought against faith are not demonstrations, but arguments that can be answered” (I, 1, 8; 13-14. My emphasis).

Obviously, whether or not he noticed it, Aquinas has here glided from theology to Sacred Scripture. For the matter he was dealing with was “sacred doctrine” as theology, not as Scripture. In the process, however, he has ended up attributing to Scripture what belongs to theology. For, obviously, it is theology, not Scripture, that uses certain texts of Scripture as principles. It is theologians, not Scripture, who dispute argumentatively with someone who denies what functions as a principle in their discipline. In short, it is theology, not Scripture, that is “argumentative,” and the fact that theology is argumentative does not imply that Scripture is argumentative, too.

Should we make of this a big point? I think so. For what is at stake is nothing else than the fundamental issue of the literary genre of Scripture. The issue is fundamental for what hinges on it is the very possibility of the quasi-scientific, Aristotelian theology Aquinas has in mind. Indeed, if the literary genre of theological works, which is quasi-scientific, is different from the literary genre of the Bible, then there is a *determinatio distrahens*—an epistemological rupture, a radical shift of paradigms—between the Bible and theology. In that case, Aquinas’s quasi-scientific theology would not be theology at all, for it would not deal with the revealed as revealed, as he maintains it does and claims it has to. Now, the only argument given by Aquinas to support his view that the literary genre of the Bible is “argumentative,” that is, quasi-scientific, is obviously defective. Favored by the equivocation between “Sacred doctrine” *as theology* and “Sacred doctrine” *as Scripture*, Aquinas has illegitimately attributed to Scripture the characteristics of his brand of theology.

Moreover, it should be remarked that so far Aquinas has not undertaken even the most cursory examination of the Scriptural text itself. Yet, he has already put the literary genre of Scripture in the same bag as that of theology, that is, he has classified the Scripture as “argumentative,” as a scientific work. Is Aquinas disingenuous? I do not think so. What happens, in my opinion, is that *his Aristotelianism has made him the victim of badly distorted vision*. From the very first page of the *Summa* he has already seen what God

reveals as a kind of *knowledge* comparable in certain respects, and complementary to, Aristotle's scientific knowledge. It follows from this that, if the Bible's text is what God has revealed, it *has to* be a work whose purpose is to convey knowledge. Therefore, the literary genre of the Bible *has to* be scientific, that is, of the same kind as the genre of theological works, which are themselves analogous to the Aristotelian scientific works.

The problem of metaphorical language

In the remaining two articles of this section of the *Summa* Aquinas asks "whether Holy Scripture should use metaphors?" (art. 9), and "whether in Holy Scripture a word may have several senses?" (art. 10).

These questions might seem to appear out of the blue. Why should Aquinas bother to ask these particular questions, and to ask them precisely at this point of his inquiry? After all, why should—or, for that matter, should not—the Scripture use metaphors or charge words with several senses? The answer is not difficult. These are very real problems for someone who, as is Aquinas's case, has predetermined that the Bible is a work of the scientific genre. Indeed, from a scientific work one does not expect metaphors and double or triple meanings; one expects unequivocal propositions combined into arguments, proceeding systematically to cover as exhaustively as possible the subject-matter at hand. In short, one expects something very much like a *Summa Theologica*, especially if, like Aquinas, one is convinced that "the author of Holy Scripture is God" (I, 1, 10; 16). However, from his long and deep familiarity with the Scripture as a devout Christian, Aquinas knows that the Bible does not read at all like a *Summa Theologica*. How come, then, that Holy Scripture, being a scientific work dictated by God, uses literary devices that do not correspond to the Aristotelian views on science? Should the Scripture use such proceedings at all? That is the context within which Aquinas's questions are truly pertinent. It is obvious, however, that, God being the author of Scripture, Scripture is written as it should be. Aquinas's problem, then, concerning

the literary genre of the Scripture, is to explain why the Bible's text is what it in fact is, if it is meant to be a scientific work, and how in spite of the fact that the Bible uses literary devices that do not belong in a scientific work the Bible is, nonetheless, a scientific work. This is the rather difficult, not to say impossible, task Aquinas has created for himself by predetermining the literary genre of the Bible.

Now, as we will later see in more detail, *the nature of the biblical text constituted one of the main obstacles that prevented other people no less eager than Aquinas to adopt the Aristotelian framework from actually doing that.* They found the biblical text, in which their faith was concretely reflected, so obviously and utterly alien by its very literary genre to the Aristotelian schemata, that they feared that any attempt to transfer it to forms that fitted the Aristotelian molds would necessarily involve a radical transformation of their faith. This is what Bonaventure called a *determinatio distrahens* and, without realizing the consequences involved, was willing to accept as the unavoidable fee to be paid for the transfer of the object of faith from the domain of faith to the domain of Aristotelian reason. As for Aquinas, he thinks that the problem is a pseudo-problem because what God has revealed is itself quasi-scientific, so that there is no substantive change in the passage of the revealed from the regime of revelation to the quasi-scientific regime of theology. This is why he has now to show that, contrary to all appearances, the Bible itself is "argumentative," that is, belongs within the quasi-scientific literary genre.

Now, from the quick and, I must say, speaking at least for myself, rather shallow way in which Aquinas deals with this complex and truly fundamental issue in just two short articles, one gathers that either he presupposes what he has already said in other of his works concerning the issue, or that his Aristotelian spectacles prevent him from even suspecting the seriousness of the problem with which he is dealing. I think there is much of both involved here. To alleviate the former and be fair to Aquinas I will supplement these two articles of the *Summa* with related material from his previous works. Concerning the latter, all I will be able to do, once we have examined

these two articles of the *Summa*, is to make the reader aware of the seriousness of the problem by re-examining the reservations voiced by other people less sanguine than Aquinas as to the compatibility between their faith and Aristotelian reason. After all, a real test of the validity of Aquinas's position will be the extent to which it is capable of genuinely allaying those reservations.

The question, then, to be answered in article nine is "whether Holy Scripture should use metaphors?" The very first objection alerts us as to the wave-length at which the question is raised:

"It seems that Holy Scripture should not use metaphors. For that which is proper to the lowest science seems not to befit this science, which holds the highest place of all. *But to proceed by the aid of various similitudes and figures is proper to poetic, the least of all the sciences. Therefore it is not fitting that this science should make use of such similitudes*" (I, 1, 9).

Besides, as the second objection adds, "this doctrine [Holy Scripture] seems to be intended to manifest truth... But by such similitudes truth is hidden" (ibid.).

There is, therefore, no possible mistake: what the objections dispute is precisely the scientific genre Aquinas has attributed to Scripture, the reason being that the use of similitudes and figures can hardly be expected from a supposedly scientific work. Such things belong in poetic works, which in the Aristotelian taxonomy of the sciences figure in the lowest place and only by a highly tenuous extension of the meaning of the word "scientific." How, then, can Aquinas maintain that the Scripture is a scientific work?

This is Aquinas's direct reply to the objection:

"Poetry makes use of metaphors to produce a representation, for it is natural to man to be pleased with representations. But sacred doctrine makes use of metaphors as both necessary and useful" (Ibid.).

The last part of the reply rests on the answer given in the corpus of the article, where Aquinas argues that the reason Holy Scripture

uses comparisons with material things “to put forward divine and spiritual truths” is that “it is natural to man to attain to intellectual truths through sensible things, because all our knowledge originates from sense.” And, in any case, as Aquinas points out in his reply to objection 2, “those things that are taught metaphorically in one part of the Scripture, in other parts are taught more openly” (ibid.).

As is clear, *Aquinas sees the Scripture as a book that teaches, a doctrinal work whose purpose is to convey revealed knowledge.* This defines the literary genre of Scripture, to which everything else—and in particular the use of metaphors, images, similitudes, and comparisons—is subordinated. *Unlike poetry, however, which uses such devices to give pleasure, Scripture uses them to convey divine truths. Consequently, the use of metaphorical language does not detract from the scientific character of the Scripture.*

From this basic view Aquinas does not budge. There are, however, in other of his works, certain additional details to be taken into account for the sake of completion and of fairness to Aquinas.

In his commentary on the Lombard’s *Book of Sentences* (1254) Aquinas also deals with the issue of the literary genre of Scripture. There again he meets the, for him, bothersome issue of the biblical use of the “method” that he identifies variously as “*symbolica*,” “*parabolica*” and “*metaphorica*.” The reason, however, on the basis of which he justifies the use of this “method” differs somewhat from the one given in the *Summa*. In the latter, as we just saw, such use is justified in terms of God’s accommodation to our human ways, for, as acknowledged by Aristotle, we cannot know the intelligible but through the sensible. The same reason is given in the commentary to the Lombard’s work, but with one addition. Certain of the truths revealed are above the reach of reason and cannot be communicated directly, but only through the use of metaphors. And this distinguishes the metaphorical language of poetry from the metaphorical language of Scripture. Poetic works have no truth to communicate, for they are meant only to please, and images or metaphors are pleasant; the Bible, by contrast, has to communicate certain truths,

some of which at least are in themselves beyond human understanding and can be communicated only through images:

“Poetica scientia est de his quae, propter defectum veritatis, non possunt a ratione capi; unde oportet quod quasi quibusdam similitudinibus ratio seducatur. Theologia autem est de his quae sunt supra rationem; et ideo modus symbolicus utrique communis est, cum neutra rationi proportionetur” (In Sent., prol., a. 5, ad 3; Chenu p. 44, not 3).

At least this latter justification of metaphorical language has the advantage of some verisimilitude, which obviously is not the case with the only justification presented in the *Summa*. Indeed, if the reason for the biblical use of metaphorical language were that we cannot understand the intelligible but through the sensible, we should find the same use of *poetic* metaphorical language in scientific works like Aristotle’s *Metaphysics* or Aquinas’s own *Summa Theologica*. But we do not. And the problem Aquinas is expected to solve is, precisely, why not, given that the Bible is supposed to be a scientific work like the ones just mentioned.

The problem of the multiplicity of meanings

In the next and last article of this section of the *Summa* Aquinas tackles the question “whether in Holy Scripture a word may have several senses.”

We need not go into the issue of the senses of Scripture in any more depth than Aquinas himself goes here. It is sufficient to know that he is fully aware that Christians have traditionally detected in the Bible several layers of meaning, which in his reply to objection 2 Aquinas will reduce to two classes: “the literal sense,” and the spiritual or allegorical senses—“allegory alone stands for the three spiritual senses.” To give an illustration of both of these kinds of sense, in the sacrifice of Isaac by Abraham Christians have traditionally seen a symbolic prefiguration of the sacrifice of Christ. In this case, the narration concerning the sacrifice of Isaac constitutes the literal sense; the prefiguration of the sacrifice of Christ constitutes the spiritual sense.

The first objection presented in the article gives us a clear idea of the problem that concerns Aquinas:

“It seems that in Holy Scripture a word cannot have several senses... For many different senses in one text produce confusion and deception and destroy all force of argument. Hence no argument, but only fallacies, can be deduced from a multiplicity of *propositions*. But *Holy Scripture ought to be able to state the truth* without any fallacy” (I, 1, 10; p. 16).

In order to grasp the full strength of the objection, we may reformulate its point as follows. The Bible, according to Aquinas, is a scientific work. What one expects from a work of such a kind is clear, unequivocal statements—“propositions” that “state the truth”—, for only such statements can convey knowledge, which is what scientific works are about. However, what we find in the Bible is “a multiplicity of propositions,” that is, statements that belong in different and heterogeneous layers of meaning, and which are therefore inept to convey scientific knowledge. Thus, by virtue of its very literary genre, the Bible can in no way be considered as a scientific work.

The gist of Aquinas’s answer to the question is to grant the existence of different senses or layers of meaning in the Bible while maintaining that this does not create a problem as to the quasi-scientific or “argumentative” character of the Bible, because

“...in Holy Scripture no confusion results, for all the senses are founded on one—the literal—from which alone can any argument be drawn, and not from those intended allegorically, as Augustine says. Nevertheless, nothing of Holy Scripture perishes because of this, since nothing necessary to faith is contained under the spiritual sense which is not elsewhere put forward clearly by the Scripture in its literal sense” (I, 1, 10, ad 1; 17).

The knowledge of which Aristotle spoke and which the Bible, as a work of the scientific genre, is supposed to convey can only be expressed propositionally, and only through propositions that mean literally rather than allegorically or spiritually. Now, Aquinas’s point

is that such precisely is the case with the Bible, because its fundamental sense—the “literal” sense—is constituted by propositions of *that* kind. This sense is fundamental because the spiritual senses are based on the literal, that is, they are possible only on the basis of the literal sense and by reference to it. *And lest anyone argue that something of what is conveyed by the spiritual senses may be lost by attending exclusively to the only sense that would have interested Aristotle—“the sense from which alone any argument can be drawn”—, one has only to realize that whatever of real importance to faith is conveyed by the spiritual senses is elsewhere in the Scripture formulated in propositions that mean literally. Hence, in spite of all appearances, the Bible is itself a scientific work and, consequently, no denaturation of the revealed can occur in the transposition of the literal statements of the Bible to the homogeneous milieu of a scientific theology.*

Does Aquinas really mean to say that the literal sense of the Scripture is of the same kind as the sense of scientific statements? Yes, he does. To realize this one has only to read the corpus of the article, where, after stating that “The author of the Scripture is God,” he explicitly compares the Bible—“this science”—to the “other sciences,” in which only the literal sense is employed.

Before leaving this article, I want to mention a point whose importance will be appreciated only later, when we come to speak of narratives. *In this article, Aquinas explicitly identifies the literal sense of the Bible with the historical sense: “Therefore that first signification whereby words signify things belongs to the first sense, the historical or literal”* (p. 16). That he means to make such identification is beyond doubt, for in his reply to objection 2 *he clarifies that the historical sense is just a particular variety of the literal sense: “For it is called history, whenever anything is simply related”* (p. 17). Now, since Aquinas has identified the literal sense with the sense of propositions or statements which can constitute premises in an argument, it follows that Aquinas reduces the sense of biblical narratives to the sense of the kind of statements that alone interested Aristotle.

The problem of contingent, historical truths

There is only one other important issue related to the literary genre of the Scripture as understood by Aquinas that we need still to consider in order to complete his views. The issue concerns the fact that Scripture, for the most part, speaks of particular characters and particular events. Now, this is something for which there should be absolutely no room in a work of the scientific genre. After all, is not a genuinely scientific work supposed to be constituted by universal and necessarily true propositions that refer to “natures” or “essences” and yield “knowledge *propter quod*”? And did not Aristotle himself, for this very reason, expel history—that is, particular, contingent truths—from the scientific realm? Was this not, indeed, the reason why he placed history even below poetry, which at least has the merit of dealing with possible rather than with temporal, contingent beings?

Aquinas does not confront this issue in either of the articles that have directly to do with the literary genre of the Bible because he has already dealt with it in a previous article of the same section. Considering “whether sacred doctrine is a science?” in article 2, he faced the following objection:

“Further, science is not of individuals. But sacred doctrine treats of individual facts, such as the deeds of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, and the like. Therefore sacred doctrine is not a science” (I, 2, obj. 2; 7).

To this Aquinas answers that

“Individual facts are not treated in sacred doctrine because it is concerned with them principally; they are rather introduced as examples to be followed in our lives (as in the moral sciences), as well as to establish *the authority of those men through whom the divine revelation, on which this sacred scripture or doctrine is based, has come down to us*” (Ibid.).

This, unless I am very badly mistaken, amounts to saying that whatever in the Bible refers to particular characters and particular

events is secondary. They appear merely as examples that illustrate a doctrine, or at best as historical points of reference that establish the actual authority which certain of the characters enjoy in regard to the reader of the Bible. Now, it is rather difficult, at least for me, to see in such a casual comment anything that even remotely resembles a satisfactory answer.

Can Aquinas possibly mean what he says? Does he see Jesus—the particular character involved in particular events, who constitutes the obvious core of the four Gospels—as not being the principal concern of the Gospels? Does he see Jesus as just an exemplification of certain doctrines? Does he think that Jesus appears in the Gospels just for the purpose of establishing the authority of his own sayings, which are themselves the important, revealed doctrine? I honestly doubt that Aquinas would have answered these questions affirmatively. This leads me to think that, *unlike those of his predecessors and contemporaries whose views we studied above, Aquinas has been so totally absorbed by the Aristotelian gravitational pull as to have lost all sense of a possible tension between his faith and his Aristotelianism.*

At any rate, such is, to the best of my understanding, the way in which Aquinas disposes of the problems that the character itself of the Bible seems to create to his attempt to understand it as a scientific work. *Rather than considering the variety of literary genres involved in the Bible, and certainly without preserving the autonomy of the narrative genre (which he reduces to literal statements), and without any sense of the temporality of history, Aquinas seems to read the Bible and every portion thereof as preceded by an implicit “God stated that...”*

The unheard voice of the opposition

Aquinas’s position concerning the matters that interest us in this book is now known to us in its entirety. I would like to finish this chapter with an at least general impression as to the solidity of Aquinas’s position by considering it side by side with the reservations expressed by other Christians who found the marriage

between their faith and Aristotelian reason impossible. After all, Aquinas's synthesis, if successful, must be capable of allaying those reservations.

A quick glance at the material presented in chapters three and four will do for our present purpose.

What were de Halès's reservations? That scientific works address the intellect exclusively, whereas the Bible talks to the heart and moves to love and fear God; that the Bible does not demonstrate anything, the Bible reveals; that because of this the literary genre of the Bible is radically different from the "*modus scientialis*" (4, 2-9). What were Kilwardby's reservations? That "the truth of the Scripture is not the result of rational inquiry but of divine inspiration, exclusively" (4, 17); that the Bible—"dico de canone Bibliae"—does not and cannot proceed by way of universal truths, as scientific works must (4, 19-20). What were Stephen of Tournai's reservations? That the scientific reading of the Bible leads to a theology where one does not recognize the Bible, where God's mystery is voided and the Holy Trinity vivisected (4, 21-22). That, in Jean de Saint-Gilles's eyes, such a theology substitutes philosophical questions and private opinions for revelation (4, 22). That, in Roger Bacon's opinion, the scientific reading of the Bible ignores the narrative character of the Bible and the singularity of the stories—"sicut liber historiarum solebat legi"—and structures the biblical text after questions that are alien to its character—"nam quaestiones... sunt iam separatae a textu" (3, X, and 4, 23).

These reservations, whose authors themselves found powerful enough as to be prevented by them from consummating the marriage between their faith and Aristotelian reason, emphasize closely inter-related characteristics of the Christian faith and of the Bible that contrast very sharply with fundamental traits of Aristotelian reason and the works inspired by it.

Certain of these reservations appeal to *the non-demonstrative character of the Bible*. The Bible is not a scientific work because it does not support with evidence. It does not prove or argue; it

reveals. Its genre is “*revelativus*,” not “*argumentativus*” or “*inquisitivus*.” Other reservations appeal to *the historical structure of the Bible*. Insofar as the Bible can be deemed to make statements, its statements cannot be equated with those that fit within the scientific structure. For the Bible does not employ universal and necessary judgments of the kind that alone interested Aristotle. The Bible deals with contingent, particular people and particular events which cannot be subsumed under, or reduced to, or expressed by means of, scientific statements. It is not only that particular people and particular events are to be found almost everywhere in the Bible, but that *the fundamental structure of the Bible is constituted by, and inseparable from, the temporal sequence of particular events in which particular persons participate in particular and different roles, out of which a particular and unique sense emerges*. This sense, as well as the Christian faith, would be totally different if the events or the participants had been different. And for this sense there is no room at all within the Aristotelian framework. Now, not only does this render highly problematic, not to say simply wrong-headed, the attempt to read the Bible as a scientific or even a quasi-scientific work, but it suggests that a deductive theology after the Aristotelian scientific model would be equally wrongheaded, for it would be radically at odds with the nature itself of revelation and of faith. Finally, other of the reservations of the Non-Aristotelians and Anti-Aristotelians, while reinforcing the preceding two, implicitly appeal to *the narrative form of the Bible*. The Bible’s fundamental literary genre is narrative, not doctrinal. Scientific works address the intellect exclusively, for they aim at eliciting assent, which is a purely intellectual operation. But the Bible, as is of the nature of narratives, moves the heart, provokes love and fear. And it is the purport of the objection that *this narrative form is not a dispensable characteristic of the Scripture, but a constitutive of its revealed message*, which cannot be conveyed otherwise than through a fundamentally narrative work. Thus, the reading of the Bible as a scientific work denatures God’s revelation, and the theology that results from such a reading would actually involve the sort

of *determinatio distrahens* that Bonaventure was willing to accept without weighing its consequences, and that Aquinas thought he had avoided by understanding the Bible as a quasi-scientific work.

Such is the real and, at least in my opinion, all but trivial, purport of the objections raised by those who, willingly or regretfully, refused to let themselves be carried by the Aristotelian wave that would end up engulfing the Western world after Aquinas. Was their voice really heard? Did Aquinas himself hear it at all? Does his position constitute a genuine answer to their concerns?

I do not think so. Aquinas's treatment of the related biblical issues trivializes and counterfeits these objections rather than really responding to them. For what is at issue is not merely the use of imagery in certain passages of the Bible, but the whole narrative structure of the Bible, which Aquinas completely ignores. What is at issue is not whether the spiritual senses of the Bible are dependent on the literal sense, but the nature itself of its literal sense, which Aquinas identifies with the sense of the kind of predicative statements that alone interested Aristotle, and which at least some of the objectors identify as narrative. What is at issue, consequently, is the nature itself of revelation and of faith, which Aquinas identifies respectively with the transmission of divine knowledge and the assent to it, and which the objectors obscurely strive to identify with something very different and closely connected with the narrative character of the Bible and its historical sense.

These are the problems with which we will have to struggle if we are to reach a satisfactory outcome in our inquiry.

Chapter 8: Biblical Categories and Aristotelian Categories

Propositional Sense and Narrative Sense

Over the Anti-Aristotelians and the Non-Aristotelians Aquinas has, in respect of us, the great advantage of possessing a fully developed theoretical framework. Indeed, his position is supported by a theoretical infrastructure which he owes to Aristotle, thanks to whose views he was able to give shape to his comprehension of revelation, of faith, of the Bible, and of theology. By contrast, the position of the Anti-Aristotelians and the Non-Aristotelians has no comparable theoretical infrastructure. It is simply informed by the intuitive comprehension that accrued to them from the practice of their faith and their familiarity with the canonical books and the para-canonical documents of the Christian tradition. As a result, their position is likely to appear to us as weak, if not simply parochial.

Now, some of the non-Aristotelians may well have been what today we would call ‘obscurantists,’ insecure people for whom any innovation represented a threat. But that, most certainly, was not the case with the Non-Aristotelians. They were as eager as Aquinas to find room for their faith within the Aristotelian epistemological framework which appeared to them to be indisputable, thereby insuring to their faith a harmonious continuity with the field of reason. Yet, they failed in their undertaking. What prevented them from achieving their project? On the basis of their own expressed reservations, I think that the answer is: an obscure sense of the incompatibility between the structure of their faith and the Aristotelian framework.

As to where my sympathies lie, the reader of this book has probably little doubt. For I have repeatedly suggested that Aquinas's undertaking failed, not because of lack of ability on Aquinas's part, but because it was bound to fail by virtue of a radical incompatibility between the Christian faith and the Aristotelian framework. And that Aquinas's failure resulted, not in a deformation of Aristotelianism under the pressure of the radically alien strictures of the Christian faith, but in a denaturation of the Christian faith—perhaps I should rather say, *a denaturation of our understanding of the Christian faith, in contradistinction with the practice of the Christian faith*—under the pressure of the alien strictures of the Aristotelian epistemology. Now that we are in possession of all the necessary pieces, the time has come to find out whether or not such an incompatibility actually exists.

An Aristotelian model of faith

It is evident that Aquinas himself had no sense at all of the incompatibility of which I am talking. The reason is that he approached the analysis of the Christian faith with a mind already colonized by Aristotle. For him, more so than for any other of his contemporaries with the possible exception of Saint Albert, “the Philosopher’s” voice represented the voice of reason at its best. Now, given Aquinas’s absolute confidence in the truth of his faith and in the impossibility that reason and faith would contradict each other, for both proceeded from the same provident God, he had every reason to expect a fundamental harmony between his Christian faith and Aristotle’s views.

Nothing in Aristotle seems to have impressed Aquinas more than the former’s views on the intellect as the faculty capable of reaching the truth or, what amounts to the same, of knowing with certainty. To this intense epistemological interest Aquinas may have been predisposed by his interest, as a Christian intellectual, in the issues related to the truth of the Christian faith. Now, once Aquinas had appropriated Aristotle’s views on the intellect, he was ineluctably bound to see what God reveals as analogous and complementary to

the knowledge reached by the Aristotelian knower, and the act of faith as analogous to the intellectual act of judging through which the Aristotelian knower comes to know. As a consequence, he had to see the Bible, which conveys what God has revealed, as analogous to a scientific work whose purpose is conveying knowledge.

A particular aspect of the Aristotelian views appropriated by Aquinas demands special attention because of its bearing on Aquinas's understanding of the Christian faith in general and of the Bible in particular. Truth and falsity, for Aristotle, are exclusive predicates of judgements and, by extension, of the statements in which judgements find their natural expression. The reason is that, of all human acts, only judgements involve a truth-claim. Other expressions—such as commands, supplications, words of endearment, expressions of desire or aversion—as well as acts of other types, such as emotions or actions, neither are nor can be true or false, for they involve no truth-claim. Not even perceptual acts, at least according to the Aristotelian view borrowed by Aquinas, involve a truth-claim. If, for instance, I see a prestidigitator cut a human body in two halves, my act of seeing is neither true nor false, for I do not judge that the prestidigitator actually cut the body.

Lonergan has aptly characterized assent, as understood by both Aristotle and Aquinas, as follows:

“It is an act of the possible intellect. It is, accordingly, contrasted with consent which is an act of the will. The good is in things, but the true is in the mind; consent is a motion of the will with respect to the thing, but assent is a motion of the intellect with respect to a conception. Again, the object of an assent is on either side of a contradiction... We assent to first principles, to demonstrable conclusions, to the affirmations of reliable authority. *Assent occurs when we judge a conception of the thing to be true.* It must be motivated... In a word, *assent appears to be identical with judgment but to emphasize its subjective and reflective aspects; it is the judgment as a personal act, committing the person, and a responsibility of the person; it is the judgment as based upon an apprehension of*

evidence, as including an awareness of its own validity, as a truth in the subject rather than as a truth absolutely and as a medium in quo reality is apprehended” (Verbum, p. 61).

Assent is, therefore, a commitment to the truth of a judgement by the judging person. A categorical judgment is a grasp of what is the case as being the case and, simultaneously, as an unrestricted intellectual commitment on the part of the judging person to the case being such as judged. This unconditional commitment to the truth of what is judged, this “assent,” is identical with the unrestricted truth-claim that categorical judgments possess and by which they differ from all other human acts in general and, in particular, from such other intellectual acts as opining or doubting.

It follows from the preceding that, if the Christian faith is true, as it is for Aquinas, it has to involve judgements and to be expressed in categorical statements. Hence Aquinas’s model for faith: assenting to what a person states, not on the basis of evidence, but of the authority of the person who makes the statements. In the *Summa* and concerning the Christian faith in particular, this model takes concrete form in the all-pervasive analogy between God, “the author of the Bible,” and a teacher. What a teacher does is what Aristotle does in his *Metaphysics*: to express his judgments by means of statements, and to support them with the evidence that has compelled him or her to judge that the case is such as stated. Insofar as the evidence presented by the teacher is capable of eliciting the same judgments from the students, the students will come to share the teacher’s knowledge. Analogously—but only analogously, because of the highly significant difference that makes possible the assent characteristic of faith—what God does in revealing is to state His own intuitive knowledge,* but without supporting His statements with any evidence whatsoever. Insofar as people come to assent to God’s statements on God’s authority, they come to share God’s infallible knowledge without however, in this life, sharing in God’s intuitive vision of the objects of His knowledge, much as a child who believes what his father says without for the time being sharing the evidence his father possesses for what he says.

* “Faith is a kind of knowledge, inasmuch as the intellect is determined by faith to some kind of knowledge” (Ia, 12, 13, ad 3). “It was necessary for man’s salvation that there should be a doctrine revealed by God, besides the philosophical disciplines investigated by human reason” (Ia, 1, 1).

This allows us to grasp *the absolutely central role that Aquinas attributes in the Bible to statements, with which he identifies its literal sense*. Indeed, if the Bible is God’s word, and if God’s word is true, the Bible’s literal sense *has to* consist essentially of statements. In the process, however, Aquinas identifies the historical sense of the Bible with the literal sense, as we saw in the preceding chapter. The “signification by which words signify things belongs to the first sense, the historical or literal” (p. 16). The literal sense is “the first sense” because it is the sense on which “all the senses are founded” and “from which alone can any argument be drawn” (I, 1, 10; ad 1; p. 17). This sense “is called history, whenever anything is simply related” (p. 17).

Clearly, *this amounts to reducing the historical sense of the Bible to the sense of statements, that is, to the only sense that interested Aristotle in his scientific works*, for it is the only sense from which arguments leading to scientific—that is, universal and necessary—conclusions can be drawn. That this and no other is the kind of arguments Aquinas had in mind is obvious from the rather expeditious way in which he disposes of the biblical statements that refer to particular characters and contingent events. Indeed, from such statements no scientific conclusion can be drawn because they are neither universal nor necessary.

An alternative model of faith

From Saint Paul on, in the Christian tradition, Abraham, “the Father of the faithful,” has been taken as the paradigmatic example of faith, following of course the Jewish tradition. Surely, then, *if Aquinas’s model of faith is basically the same as that of the tradition, as he must have assumed it was, his model should be glowingly verified by Abraham’s case. If faith, then, is the intellectual act of assent to*

what God states, we should see Abraham assenting to what God states.

We could refer ourselves to the whole biblical story concerning Abraham, but a portion of it will suffice for our present purpose. Nowhere is Abraham's faith more powerfully portrayed than in the scene of the sacrifice of his own son. It is to be remarked that we are dealing with a scene, that is, with a narrative passage, with an episode of the developing history or story of Abraham. However, if one approaches the Bible with the preconceived idea that God's revelation consists of statements, and conceives God as the Author of the Bible, the temptation to understand the Bible as implicitly prefaced by the words "God stated that..." is irresistible. In which case the passage that concerns us, where God orders Abraham to go to the mountain and sacrifice his son will be composed of a series of statements to which the faithful have to assent: *that* God ordered Abraham to go to the mountain, etc. *Given his epistemological model* and his corresponding notions of revelation and of faith, Aquinas cannot help assuming that the Scripture *states that* God ordered Abraham to go to the mountain and sacrifice his son. And, since this is a statement or a series of statements whose author is God, we are supposed to assent to it or to them on God's authority. Most certainly, however, that is not what Abraham did or was supposed to do in this case. For God had stated nothing; God had given him an order to be obeyed or disobeyed, not made a statement to be assented to or dissented from. God had communicated to Abraham no piece of knowledge susceptible of being expressed in propositional form and of being true or false. In other words, Aquinas's model does not fit the case of the Father of the faithful.

The faith by which Abraham became the Father of the faithful did not consist in assenting to the fact that God had given him an order, which in any case was not a fact stated by God, but in obediently going to the mountain to sacrifice his son out of his total reverence for Yaweh. And such, clearly, is the sort of faith which the rest of the scriptural passage shows, for it contains no divine statements to which Abraham could possibly have assented.

Aquinas's model of faith simply does not fit at all a passage to which it would have to fit if it were the right model. In fact, this passage itself furnishes the concrete model which Aquinas should have made his, but did not because it did not square at all with his Aristotelian preconceptions. Now, it seems to me, on the basis of the analysis conducted in chapter 5, that the faith of which the Fathers were talking, that is, the traditional understanding of faith, is informed by the concrete model furnished by the story of Abraham, which, needless to say, differs abysmally from Aquinas's own.

It is at this point that we may start appreciating the profound difference between Aquinas, on the one hand, and the Non-Aristotelians and Anti-Aristotelians, on the other. For one of the latter's fundamental reservations concerning the possibility of a scientific or even quasi-scientific theology had to do, precisely, with the narrative structure of the Bible which, as is the nature of narratives, deals with particular characters and events and is meant to produce perlocutionary effects in its readers—such as love and fear—which are very different from the assent meant to be produced by statements. Now, this objection cannot be taken lightly. After all, there are good reasons to think that the Bible may well not be a work of the genre Aquinas, constrained by the Aristotelian frame of mind he had thoroughly appropriated, assumed it was. What if the fundamental, literal sense of the Bible is narrative rather than assertive? And what if the narrative sense is irreducible to the assertive or propositional sense that alone interested Aquinas and with which he identified the literal sense of the Bible?

A narrative model of faith

Whether or not the Bible is a sacred text that contains God's revelation, it is sure that it contains certain passages that are narrative, of which the one referring to Abraham is an example. Again, whether or not this passage is historical in the modern sense of the word, that is, refers to real persons and real events of the past and is at least to an extent verifiable by the "trace" it left (cf. Ricoeur), it is sure that the passage has the shape of a story. Now, stories are

narratives. The word “story,” however, in our modern parlance, connotes a narrative that is not historical but purely fictional. Since I do not want in any way to prejudge the question of the historical or fictional character of the Bible, rather than using the words “story” or “history” in reference to the narrative passages of the Bible I will use the neutral word “narrative.”

My thesis is the following: (a) The fundamental literary genre of the Bible is narrative. (b) Narratives—whether Biblical or not—possess or convey a sense of their own which cannot be conveyed but by a narrative. This sense is irreducible to any other sense, and in particular to the propositional sense. I will designate the sense to which I am referring by the expression “narrative sense.”

Needless to say, the core of my thesis is not new at all. I am indebted for it mainly to Hans Frei’s enormously influential book *The Eclipse of Biblical Narrative*. However, since this thesis constitutes an essential piece in the present work, I will try to make it persuasive to the reader in my own terms, independently of whether Frei would or would not recognize his own position in the one I will present as mine.

What is a narrative? The biblical scene of the sacrifice of Isaac is a concrete example. Speaking in a very general way, a narrative is a presentification of the events in which a person or a number of persons participated by shaping the events and being shaped by them. These participants are usually called “characters,” and I will follow this usage. In the passage I am referring to, the characters are Yaweh and Abraham. The events are obvious, starting with God’s order to Abraham, through Abraham’s conduct in response to it, to the final outcome.

Narratives possess certain characteristics. The sequence of events is temporal, that is, not only are the events narrated interconnected in an irreversible order of before and after but, if this order were altered, either the events narrated would become unintelligible, or if they kept any intelligibility the significance of the narrative would be changed. This is to say that the sequence of events is not

purely temporal, in that the events are connected in their sequence by a certain 'narrative or dramatic logic.' Of course, this 'logic' is not the logic of demonstrative arguments; it is, rather, the 'logic of life' as lived by human beings. What do I mean by this? Roughly, that the characters in a narrative find themselves in the initial situation as all of us find ourselves in life in any dramatic situation: with a certain comprehension of the present situation and the challenges it poses to us and to others, with certain desires and fears as to the possible outcome, and with no absolute certainty as to the final outcome, since the future is always contingent and partly dependent on the actions of the involved people. Of course, each of the characters will, to the best of his or her abilities, promote the realization of the outcome he or she ultimately prefers under the circumstances, and will have to face the new circumstances created either by nature or by the other characters until the final outcome that terminates the narrative or the episode of a narrative takes place. I call it a 'logic' in that it confers to the narrative the structure by which it is intelligible. And, to distinguish it from the logic of life, for our life may be the basis for narratives but is not itself a narrative, I will call it 'dramatic logic.' I call it this way because the intelligibility of a narrative is structured around, or obtains thanks to, the outcomes desired or feared by the characters, which may or may not coincide with the final outcome that takes place actually at the end of the narrative. Indeed, if human beings were totally indifferent to what may happen to themselves or to others under whichever circumstances, narratives would become mere *factual* descriptions of a sequence of events passively and indifferently undergone by humans, instead of being what they actually are: *dramatic* narratives. This is to say that narratives are dramatic by definition, which is what distinguishes them from descriptions in particular and, in general, from all literary pieces structured according to a non-dramatic logic.

It is important to keep in mind the distinction between the time-space of the author and the reader, on the one hand, and the time-space of the characters, on the other. For the author and the reader, the time of a narrative is past (if what is narrated actually occurred,

if the stuff of the narrative is “historical”), or it is imaginary time. In both cases, the author may know the final outcome before writing or telling the narrative. The reader may also know the final outcome if the events are “historical,” and even if they are imaginary, if the reader has already read the narrative at least once. But, for the characters themselves, their time is like ours in life, their future is as unknown and contingent as ours is. And it is into the time of the characters, imagined or reproduced by the author, that the reader of a narrative enters as a spectator.

All the above applies, of course, to the biblical narratives, leaving aside the fine and complex distinctions that would be pertinent concerning God as a character, given His prescience and omnipotence, and which make of Him such a special “character” in biblical narratives.

I come now to part (b) of my thesis, starting with the point that *narratives convey a sense of their own, which cannot be conveyed otherwise than by a narrative*. This is what I call the “narrative sense.”

The narrative sense is the sense that a competent reader of a narrative is meant to get *as a reader of a narrative* rather than of a piece of any other literary genre. Of course, the knowledge of the particular language in which the narrative is written is required to qualify as a competent reader. In addition, however, to this kind of understanding, the ability to understand a narrative *as a narrative* is required. To distinguish the “language” (English, French, Spanish, etc.) in which a narrative is written from what I am talking about I will call the latter the “idiom” of narratives. “Idioms” are parasitic on but not identical with “languages.” A narrative has to be written in a certain “language”—Chinese, Aramean, English, French, etc. But a demonstrative argument, or a lyrical poem, which also have to be written in a certain “language,” are not thereby narratives. In fact, a demonstrative argument and a lyrical poem exemplify “idioms” or “genres” which are different from each other and from the narrative idiom. Being a competent reader of demonstrative arguments is

being capable of following them as demonstrative arguments, so as to be able to understand the conclusion as a conclusion to which one will assent or with which one will dissent. Similarly, being a competent reader of lyrical poems is being capable of following them as lyrical poems, so that the characteristic linguistic effects that lyrical poems are capable of producing in their readers may obtain. In a similar way, then, *being a competent reader of narratives is being capable of following them as narratives, so that the linguistic effects characteristic of this particular "idiom" or "genre" may obtain in the reader.*

Locutionary effects: illocutionary and perlocutionary

I have spoken of "characteristic effects" in reference to the "idioms" I used as examples, because "idioms" differ among themselves by the effects they are capable of producing according to their respective natures. If, for instance, assent is the characteristic effect that a demonstrative argument is meant to produce, for such an argument is nothing else than a statement with its supporting evidence as required by the people to whom the argument is addressed, assent can hardly be considered the characteristic effect of a lyrical poem where, as the saying goes, "the poet affirmeth nothing."

In this connection, it is important that we avoid a common misunderstanding that would be fatal in our context. The misunderstanding consists in believing that grammatical sentences—be they oral or written—can be understood independently of their particular 'literary genre.' The grammatical sentence "Go to hell" is not understood at all if it is understood as an order, because it does not express a command. If I respond to this sentence or utterance by refusing to go to hell, I misunderstood the utterance, I am an incompetent hearer of English, though I may have the illusion that I know the English language because I understand the meaning of each of the words.

In *Speech Acts* Searle distinguished between illocutionary and perlocutionary effects. Language is not a thing there, that exists complete in itself, like a brick ready to be used for purposes of

construction. The French language, for instance, does not exist apart from speakers and hearers of French. It is constituted by “speech acts,” that is, acts of speaking and hearing, which are correlative and complementary to each other. You speak so that I hear, and I hear because you speak. Now, we tend to think that speaking is picking up chunks of an already constituted, pre-existing language to build a sentence, much as one picks pre-existing bricks to build a house. The speaker builds the house, and the hearer retrieves it by understanding it. The speaker *says* something, and the hearer retrieves this *something* by *hearing* it, where hearing stands for understanding.

Though Searle thinks in terms of speech acts rather than of bricks, his idea of speaker and hearer ends up corresponding to the one I just presented. Language is constituted by speech acts, which are speaking and hearing. Speaking is saying something intelligible, something to be understood. Hearing is retrieving what was said by understanding it. What the speaker intends is the said by him or her to be understood. This is the *illocutionary* effect of language, that is, the effect that any genuine piece of language is capable of producing, given the nature of language, the effect that any person capable of speech acts intends as a speaker and receives as a hearer. Competent speakers are people who say something, and competent hearers are people who understand it. Apart from this, the speaker may intend other locutionary effects, that is, other linguistic effects, other effects apart from understanding which that language, given its nature, is capable of producing or at least of meaning to produce. Thus, as a speaker, I can give you an order by using a sentence in the imperative: “Fetch me that spoon.” As in every case in which language is used, I as a speaker intend an illocutionary effect, that is, that the said by me be understood by you, the addressee. But, in this case, I also intend a perlocutionary effect: that you pass me the spoon. In Searle’s view, the perlocutionary effects of speech acts are parasitic on the illocutionary effect, in that they can neither be intended nor obtain but on the basis of the illocutionary effect. The illocutionary effect, therefore, is common to all speech acts; the

perlocutionary effects are characteristic of particular acts, such as commanding, threatening, praising, insulting, etc.

This view is, in my opinion, mistaken. It arises from taking the declarative sentence—the case of “*saying* something” in the sense of stating, of predicating something of something—as the paradigmatic example of speech acts. This kind of sentence has, or at least appears to have, a particular property. What is said can be detached from the perlocutionary effects while keeping its meaning or intelligibility in its integrity. “*Humans are rational animals*” is a declarative sentence by which no other than the illocutionary effect is intended or even normally intendable. This is Searle’s model of the speech act: saying something that can be understood. The illocutionary effect, that is, the “*meaning*,” the “*content*,” is detachable from all perlocutionary effects and, therefore, clearly different from them. *This amounts to identifying meaning with a piece of information given by the speaker and received by the hearer (or the witness), and the perlocutionary effects as parasitic on a piece of information from which they are separable while remaining intelligible.* The sense or meaning of language is self-contained and independent from perlocutionary effects.

I think this is wrong.

If I tell you “Your mother is on the phone,” I intend linguistically the perlocutionary effect of your going to the phone to talk to your mother. It seems as though I intend two things: informing you and making you take the phone. Indeed, without saying anything, I could take you to the phone and thus obtain the perlocutionary effect in a non-locutionary way. Thus, it would seem that the perlocutionary effect is different, even separable, from the illocutionary effect that characterizes all linguistic pieces. But such is not the case. *What I intend locutionarily is to bring you to the phone.* I do not intend to give you a piece of information at all, if by “piece of information” we understand something to be simply understood, that is, decoded and stored in your mind, to be retrieved at will later. Of course, I could bring you to the phone by other non-locutionary means, but

that would not be the same at all, for neither my action nor yours would be locutionary, that is, linguistic.

Other people interested in speech acts have spoken of *performative* speech acts. The umpire who shouts “out” is *performing locutionarily*, putting the player out. He is not declaring, that is, giving a piece of information and, *in addition*, putting the player out. He is simply putting the player out, linguistically or locutionarily, much as the judge who condemns is not informing and condemning but simply condemning somebody who is by the same token locutionarily condemned. My point is that *all speech acts of the “involved mode,” are performatives in intention*, and that *being a competent user of language is being capable of meaning and grasping all and each speech acts of this mode as performatives*.

What about declarative sentences? Language is a communicative relationship, which is primarily spoken and only derivatively written, between two or more persons. This is to say that *we might make a bad mistake if we try to theorize about language as if it were primarily written and only derivatively spoken*. We all were introduced to the linguistic universe through talking, not through writing. And, historically, humankind talked long before writing. Now, speaking of talking involves at least two people. *The original linguistic act is not talking to oneself, but talking to others and with others*. Furthermore, *the original communicative situation is not aesthetic but practical, in the “involved” or “exposed” mode*. By this I mean that the fundamental, though not unique, function of language is coping with the surrounding world, not enjoyment or anything else that would presuppose a bracketing of action. It is fundamental for the same reason that survival is fundamental, for without survival all the other functions of language could not obtain or be of any use.

Assuming that the above notations are correct, certain implications follow. We talk in a given situation, in the situation with whose immediate challenges we have to cope to the best of our abilities and according to the outcome each of the participants ultimately prefers,

given the circumstances. If, in a movie house, I shout "Fire!," I am using a "performative." I am not communicating a piece of information to be understood and stored in memory; I am *urging* other people to live, much as I am *blackmailing* when I tell somebody "I will kill you now if you do not give me the money you have in your pocket." The other is *thereby blackmailed*, much as the player is *outed* by the "out" of the umpire. If the 'other' continues to seat placidly in the moviehouse, or does not start taking his money out of his pocket, or tries to go to bat at the next turn, this person did not 'understand,' that is, is an *incompetent linguistic agent* at least in this singular case. Suppose the blackmailed answered: "I understand what you say," or even "I believe what you say," that is, I assent to what you say, and proceeded to continue walking as if nothing had happened. Obviously, the blackmailed had not understood what the blackmailer said, for he understood it as a piece of information to be stored, not as a particular performative to be responded to appropriately.

Thus language in the involved or exposed mode is primarily performative. At least at this point, 'understanding' = 'performing', and 'meaning' = intending something to be linguistically performed. Moreover, this meaning is directly related to the immediate situation constituted in part by the mutual presence of the speaker and the hearer or spoken-to, and in part by the immediately surrounding circumstances, such as the movie-house, the stadium, the place where the poor guy is blackmailed.

I return to Searle. Can language be rightly understood as constituted essentially by its "illocutionary" effect, which is common to all pieces of language? I don't think so. I believe that language is characterized by its being capable of producing perlocutionary effects, and that there is no such a thing as the illocutionary effect of language, much less that the latter is separable or even different at all from the perlocutionary. Of course the perlocutionary effect is a locutionary effect, for otherwise it would not be linguistic; but it is perlocutionary, not illocutionary.

Having made my position clear, I want to spell it in more detail as to certain of its implications. The first is that *there is nothing to understand in a linguistic piece, if by understanding we mean simply getting the sense of what is said and of what the speaker thereby intends*. The reason is that no linguistic piece, not even declarative sentences, say anything, if by saying something we mean something purely intelligible; linguistic pieces are not saying or predicative pieces, they are performative pieces. Being a competent linguistic agent is being capable of grasping appropriately the *performative force* of pieces of language—not, as Searle claims, the “illocutionary force”—, according to the particular role one plays in the situation. The meaning of language is identical with its perlocutionary force, but the *perlocutionary force varies according to the roles occupied by the participants within the linguistic situation*. There is the role of the addresser, the role of the addressee, the role of the witness, all of whom are present to the situation. And there is the role of the linguistic contemplator.

The speaker and the hearer are participants. Suppose, however, that I am watching the scene of the blackmail from a window above, but without any chance to interfere with the action. I am not a participant. I am a witness. This fact, however, does not disqualify me from being a competent linguistic agent, though I am not a participant in the actual linguistic situation. If I understand the scene as anything else than as a case of blackmailing, I am an incompetent linguistic agent, at least in this case. Now, I, as a witness, am ‘informed’ of the blackmailing that is taking place. But neither the speaker is informing nor the blackmailed is informed or being informed. Moreover, it is not quite true that I am just being informed, as a witness. The scene ‘moves’ me. To simplify things, I am shattered, I am revulsed by the wantonness of the blackmailer, I am scared for the blackmailed’s life, I am sorry for him, etc. And, no less important, if I were in the position to prevent what is going on—that is, in the position of a participant in the situation, though not in the role of the blackmailer or the blackmailed—I would feel

called to do something and would feel bad about myself, guilty, if I did not do something.

Suppose, now, that I read in the paper: "Yesterday evening, on Main Street, a man was blackmailed into giving all he had in his pocket." Here we are in written language, one of whose characteristics is that it is removed in space (and usually in time) from the situation in which action is possible. Here I am 'informed'. Even here, however, insofar as I belong to the same town, this information may make me fear and worry and take certain precautions in the future.

Searle and Predicative sentences

Searle grants that linguistic utterances do not mean. Speakers mean, and hearers understand. They are thereby constituted as "competent." But he also makes the meaning dependent on (identical with?) the uttered in a particular language. Can he have it both ways?

His paradigmatic case of communication demands sincerity on the speaker's part. This applies to predicative sentences. The speaker believes what he says. But I can say something without believing it. Therefore, even in the speaker's case, believing and understanding are different.

This seems to imply that understanding is the same on the speaker's part as it is on the hearers, and that the hearer is the model. But then, a language is a ready made meaningful tool: The pieces of language mean by themselves. Their *intrinsic* meaning is what *they* say. The speaker uses them to communicate his primary intention (being understood, which coincides with understanding what the sentence says), and *to produce perlocutionary effects, which themselves are connected with what the sentence says: giving for begging, assenting for predications, etc.* Now, Searle denies that utterances mean by themselves and in themselves.

Searle has an apparent scoop in the fact that I can understand something without believing it, understand a command without

obeying, understand an act of begging without giving. But his scoop is only apparent. As insincerity is a second order intention parasitic in the first order intention constitutive of linguistic communication, so is the illocutionary force or sense which Searle identifies with meaning.

The speaker's understanding of commanding, at least initially—that by which the speaker is constituted as competent, native speaker—is identical with his command. The speaker does not first understand as commanding the sentence he will use, and then attaches to it his intention of commanding such and such. If such were the case, then language would mean by itself, which Searle denies. In a parallel way, the speaker does not first understand the declarative sentence he is going to use, and then believes it. Assenting, like sincere speech, is the paradigmatic case. Why?

“There is fire in the theater.” Would a child who understood the words but did not register that he should live understand the sentence? I don't think so. Would Searle say that a speaker who utters a declarative sentence but who has no hint of what uttering it sincerely, that is, believingly, understands it? I don't think so. In other words, being a competent speaker involves being capable of grasping as a linguistic agent, not reflectively, not only the sense (what Searle calls “meaning”) but also the perlocutionary force of what one says, without which one could not possibly have the perlocutionary intentions Searle grants speakers have. But are these two different and separable things? In that case, in the example of fire, the child I mentioned would have to be declared by Searle a competent hearer and speaker. Yes, one can predicate something believingly and unbelievably or doubtfully, but one cannot just predicate as a parrot would predicate, for that is the nature of the predicative speech act. Conversely, one can hear something believingly or unbelievably or doubtfully or even suspending judgment, but one cannot hear a predicative sentence without taking a stand as to its truth, for that is the nature of hearing. Suspending judgment is a stand in respect of the predicated and of the speaker. As one cannot disbelieve a speaker's statement without disbelieving the speaker,

and one does not make two acts. Much as Searle acknowledges that one cannot refer without speaking. Believingly, disbelievingly... are modalities of speech acts, but all speech acts are modal and cannot but be modal for they are speech acts.

A further point. All speech acts are performative in relation to the speaker, and intentionally performative in relation to the hearer. The speaker who commands constitutes himself as commander by commanding, by conveying his intention linguistically through a commanding sentence, much as the umpire constitutes the player as outed by shouting "out." Now, language is a communicative practice that cannot subsist at all without the cooperation of the participants. The fundamental sanction of the lack of cooperative communication is the rupture of communication, which can be sustained without the total dissipation of communication only as long as it is not systematic and is only incidental. He who makes systematically disbelieving predications defeats the communicative purpose of predicating, and will pay the price of not being believed. He who systematically commands without constituting himself as commander will not be obeyed. He who begs without intending to receive will be given nothing when he begs sincerely. In fact, all that Searle says about "sincerity" can be extended to all the other speech acts; they should be "sincere," that is, express the real intentions of the speaker. Now, though there is no corresponding word to "sincerity" on the hearer's side, the same rupture of communication (resulting in ostracism) and ultimate dissolution of the communicative community would obtain if commands were systematically disobeyed ('unheard'), demands unheard, salutations unacknowledged, etc. Commands, by the very nature of the intention they express are to be obeyed, demands satisfied, salutations acknowledged...

Where does this leave us concerning the question of "understanding"? If I do not realize that by commanding I constitute myself as commander and expecting obedience, by predicating (to the addressee) I constitute myself as believer of what I say and expecting to be believed, I am not a competent speaker of language. Now, predicative sentences seem to be special in that they involve not only the

question of sincerity but also the question of truth. And this question involves its proper rules. Assenting is not primarily a matter of free decision, as obeying an order or consenting to a demand may be; it is a matter of judging, which does not obtain without sufficient reason as judged by the hearer. While I admit this difference, I will deal with it later. Moreover, the fact that there is a personal element on the hearer's part does not make this case exceptional. Obeying an order and consenting to a demand involve that too. Were that not the case, obedience *to* an order and disobedience would not exist, nor consenting or refusing to consent *to* a demand. But on all this, more later.

To return to "understanding." My difference with Searle is that he makes "meaning" the correlate of "understanding," and he equates meaning with "something to be understood." I already showed that no speech act demands such kind of understanding.

But "understanding" is a particularly dangerous word, for we tend to reserve that word particularly for statements, that is, for predicative speech acts which do not seem to demand from the hearer any particular external conduct but only, at best, mental assent.

The result, if we take Searle's view on meaning, is that we might tend to separate cleanly, as Searle does, the illocutionary force and effects of speech acts from their perlocutionary force and effects, and then to confuse the illocutionary force and effects of all other speech acts with the illocutionary force and effects of predicative statements.

Searle writes:

"When I say 'Hello', I intend to produce in the hearer the *knowledge* that he is being greeted. If he recognizes it as my intention to produce in him that knowledge, then he thereby acquires that knowledge" (p. 43). [He attributes this to Grice, whom he criticizes: "This account of meaning does not show the connection between one's meaning something by what one says, and what that which

one says actually means in language. Secondly, by defining meaning in terms of intended effects, it confuses illocutionary with perlocutionary acts... *but* saying something and meaning it is a matter of intending to perform an illocutionary, not necessarily a perlocutionary act" (43-44).]

"... saying something and meaning it is a matter of intending to perform an illocutionary act... many kinds of sentences used to perform an illocutionary act... many kinds of sentences used to perform illocutionary acts have no perlocutionary effect associated with their meaning. For example, there is no associated perlocutionary effect of greeting. When I say 'Hello' and mean it, I do not necessarily intend to produce or elicit any state or action in my hearer other than the knowledge that he is being greeted. But that knowledge is simply his understanding what I said, it is not an additional response or effect... Secondly, even when there generally is a correlated perlocutionary effect, I may say something and mean it without in fact intending to produce that effect. Thus, f. e., I may make a statement without caring whether my audience believes it or not but simply because I feel it my duty to make it." (46).

Meaning, therefore, equals knowledge, equals illocutionary force or intended effects. I disagree.

If I salute, a witness knows that I saluted X, but the witness is not himself saluted. X not only knows that he is saluted; he is saluted, whereas the witness is not. Does being saluted amount to knowing that one is saluted in the same way that knowing that somebody else is saluted? If saluting is meaning to convey the knowledge of saluting someone, it is. And, in this case, we have a reduction of meaning and of illocutionary force to knowledge, which is what predicative speech acts addressed to someone intend to produce. That is, as I suggested above, the illocutionary is clearly distinguished from the perlocutionary and the illocutionary force of all other speech acts is reduced to, and confused with, that of statements, of predicative speech acts. Why do I reject this?

When I state I intend to convey knowledge which will be acquired by the other in the measure the other assents to what I said. But surely I do not intend the same when I salute, or I command, or I demand. An appropriate response to my statement is "I agree" or "I disagree." But I would consider such response inappropriate in the latter three cases. In fact, if that is the response I received from X when I salute her, I would surely know that she misunderstood. And, if I received such response consistently from her to my salutations, I would consider her an incompetent user of language, an incompetent linguistic agent, for she takes salutations for statements.

Searle is likely to reply that he equates the illocutionary force and effect with knowledge, not with assent or dissent, which he considers perlocutionary effects. Even in that case, I think he is wrong. When I make a predicative speech act, I intend to convey knowledge to my interlocutor. But do I intend to convey knowledge when I salute her? Sounds queer, at least to me.

When I make a predicative speech act (a statement) I mean both to express my belief in the truth of the statement and to share that knowledge with the addressee. But when I salute her I do not intend to convey any knowledge I possess; I intend to salute her. Since I have said nothing susceptible of being assented to or dissented from, I would find any response of that kind utterly inappropriate—a case of misunderstanding. What is this kind of knowledge Searle has in mind? It cannot be shared knowledge, for I do not mean to share any knowledge with the person saluted. It is, furthermore, nothing susceptible of being assented to or dissented from, which is typical of linguistically shared knowledge. In what way, then, is it knowledge?

Let us, however, charitably consider the possibility that what is typical of speech acts is to produce knowledge, but not of sharing knowledge, and that the latter is only the distinctive perlocutionary intention of statements, whereas the former is the illocutionary effect of all speech acts. Perhaps this is what Searle has in mind.

Having saluted X, I know that I saluted X; X knows that I saluted him; and a witness knows that I saluted X.

Have we not here a piece of knowledge that is shared but not stated by anybody, in particular not by the speaker?

This kind of “knowledge” would be about a linguistic fact, but is not itself a linguistic fact anymore than seeing a tree is a linguistic act, for it is not meant by the speaker. When a speaker wants to convey knowledge, a speaker states; a speaker does not salute, or demand, or command. It seems strange that speech acts, that is, linguistic acts, would be characterized and defined by a non-linguistic effect.

It seems to me that Searle’s mistake consists in trying to find a quality that is common to all speech acts independently of the respective particular effects that they are meant to produce. Well, what is common to all linguistic acts is that they are communicative acts. And communication obtains in the measure that the speech act is meant and heard as, according to its particular nature it ought to be meant and heard. An insincere statement is not a statement at all, though it sounds as a statement and can be heard as a statement, for a statement by its very nature demands assent of the speaker to the stated as much as it demands assent by the hearer. As a speech act, a statement that is not believed by the speaker or by the hearer is not a speech act, for it does not communicate, though perhaps it was meant to communicate by the speaker, or taken as meant to communicate by the hearer. The same can be said of a command that is not meant to be obeyed or that is not obeyed.

Yet, Searle’s position seems plausible. After all, I can ‘understand’ or ‘know’ that you meant “I love you” as a declaration of love for me, without loving you in return, or ‘understand’ or ‘know’ “Please, give me a piece of your bread” as your begging me, without giving you a piece of my bread. True. But we have to go more deeply into the nature of language. It is the nature of language to communicate. A linguistic agent is an agent who is capable of participating in linguistic communication in the roles of speaker or hearer, that is,

of intending linguistic effects as a speaker and of cooperating in the achievement of those effects as a hearer, and reciprocally. What the speaker minimally and essentially intends is to achieve linguistically the effects signified by what the speaker says. If he states something, he intends that to be believed. If he begs for something, he intends beggily to be given what he begs for. If he salutes, he intends the other to take himself as saluted by the speaker. A speaker who does not intend that is not using language; he is *ab-using* language, he is giving the impression that he is using language. A speaker does not intend to be purely 'understood.' Imagine a language in which Searle's illocutionary effects always obtained, but what he calls the perlocutionary effects never obtained. Statements would be understood as statements, but never believed; commands would be understood as orders, but never obeyed, etc. Would such a language function as language? Would its speakers function as speakers and its hearers function as linguistic hearers? Could a hearer who thinks that statements are not to be believed, that commands are not to be obeyed, that demands are not to be consented to, function as a speaker in his turn and make statements, give orders, make demands? Yet, if Searle were right, that would be a language!

Nonetheless, there is the illusion that language is 'understood' in the way Searle thinks. From where does it arise? From objectifying language, from thinking *about* language, from contemplating the linguistic situation rather than living it as a participant. When one reflects on language, one neither speaks as a speaker nor hears as a hearer participating in the linguistic situation. One contemplates them. One 'understands' what the speaker says and what the hearer hears, but one is not speaking or hearing. Obviously, the speaker does not 'understand' what he says by hearing what he says. And, since hearing is correlative and reciprocal to speaking, the hearer does not 'understand' what the speaker says, for it is not meant to be understood. Searle's understanding is an abstraction. There is no mental operation called 'understanding' that precedes, and is different from, the speaking conduct and the hearing conduct. The speaker intends linguistic effects by intending them linguistically

and the hearer responds linguistically by responding. The hearer of “out” responds linguistically by ‘acting out.’

Now, why am I so interested in debunking Searle’s views on the illocutionary?

Why do I deem them to be, not only wrong, but dangerously wrong? Because I think they perpetuate the very intellectualistic mistake that the notion of speech acts should help us to overcome. *The intellectualistic mistake consists in separating the intellect from the will, the emotions, and the conduct. In making of knowledge an autonomous thing, complete in itself, and the necessary foundation for emoting the emoted, willing the willed, and acting the acted.* This is what Plantinga does by separating believing that God exists from believing in God. *This is what Aquinas does by reducing faith to intellectual assent, thereby making faith independent from “feelings” and “behavior”. This is what Aristotle did by identifying truth with the truth of reflective judgments, of the judgments of a pure contemplator and by making of knowledge (the judged) the foundation of all other human acts.*

Suppose I am right. What follows for my purposes?

- (1) I can pass to the question of literary genres as speech acts given and received as such, and apply this to the narrative (dramatic) genre. Establish the parallelism, or at least the analogy between speech acts and literary genres.
- (2) *I can disqualify Aquinas’s understanding of the Bible as constituted by predicative sentences asking for assent, and of faith in God as assent to what God says.* For narratives neither state anything nor can be assented to or dissented with. The same with God’s revelation.

Narratives as comprehensive speech acts, as “idioms” or “genres”

A narrative is a speech act whose speaker is its author and whose hearer is its readers or its public. It is *one* complex speech act. It is characterized by the intrinsic effects of the genre. The author

may narrate for his or her own ulterior purposes, but he cannot attain those purposes without obtaining and intending the linguistic effects characteristic of the genre. Thus, the author may narrate to entertain, or to earn his living, or to convey a message he wants to teach. But he *narrates* to realize his particular purposes. Thus, his purposes are parasitic on the intrinsic purposes of the narrative and will not obtain without the intrinsic effects of narratives being intended and obtaining. What are these effects?

A narrative is a presentification of dramatic events in which a character or characters participate, by means of which a competent reader or hearer of narratives is made present as an ideal witness as if he were there.

By *dramatic events* I mean events that terminate in an outcome that accords or discords with the desires of the characters, but which in any case is not neutral, that is, neither in accord nor in discord with their desires.

The dramatic tension of a narrative, which is what gives the narrative its unity, consists in the tension between the outcome desired by each of the characters and the uncertainty of its accomplishment, with the correlative consequences for the central characters. Of course, the outcome desired by one of the characters may be different and in conflict with the outcome desired by another or others.

The distinctive characteristic of the temporality of narratives is that it replicates the temporality of human life, where the future is always contingent and, therefore, unknown until it becomes present. Unknown does not necessarily mean unforeseen by the characters, but with the fallibility characteristic of human foreseeance, where the unforeseen is always absolutely possible.

The reader is made present to the action and the characters, which are inseparable from each other in a narrative, as an *ideal witness*. By this I mean that the reader or hearer is there as if he witnessed the action, but without being able to intervene in the action. As is the case with an actual witness, this does not prevent

the reader from preferring a certain outcome to other outcomes and, thus, from identifying himself with one character by preferring the outcome preferred by that character and by suffering and rejoicing with the character. *In fact, it is the very intrinsic effect of narratives that the reader be present in this way, as an ideal witness.* Being a competent reader of narratives is being capable of this mode of presence. Being a competent teller of narratives is being capable of creating the conditions for such presence of the reader to the action. A narrative is as good, as a narrative, as it is capable of producing this form of presence of the reader to the action.

Narratives, therefore, are intrinsically dramatic. In this they differ from descriptions, which are a-dramatic.

The *author's voice*, whether heard or unheard, is always there. A narrative may replicate the structure of life, but it is not life itself. It is a speech act that obtains by replicating the structure of human life and making the reader present to a chunk of life as an ideal witness.

Needless to say, there are infinite possible variations of the features of narratives, depending on the author's particular purposes.

The Bible as a narrative

The Bible is a collection of heteroclite books of very different genres. Yet, there is a sense in which, as a whole, it can be considered as a narrative work. Indeed, the reading of the Bible *as a sacred book* has always 'followed' it as a narrative. Why?

There are in the Bible books of very different genres: sapiential, legislative, prayerful (Psalms), etc. These books, however, make sense within the whole on the basis of the narrative books. The prayers are addressed to Yaweh, one of the central characters in the narrative books. The legislative books present the laws by which the people of Israel, another of the central characters, lives its relationship to Yaweh. In short, the narrative passages are "selbständig," intelligible by themselves, but the non-narrative passages or books get their proper intelligibility only by their relationship to the narrative passages or books, which are connected with each other as a

sequence of episodes moving toward a desired outcome which, by the end of the Bible, is still to come and desired by the participants in the action.

The biblical whole, then, possesses a narrative unity in spite of the variety of its authors. Correlatively, there is also a certain unity to the authorial voice, in spite of the variety of its individual authors. What characterizes this voice is the fervent allegiance to Yaweh on each of the author's part. Yaweh is not only the main character, but such a character as to demand and command—and, in the authorial voice—deserve the total allegiance of the readers. A particular reader may come to despise and hate Yaweh for his arbitrary ways and his cruel demands. In fact, it is very much the right of the reader of the Bible, as it is the right of the reader of any narrative not to sympathize with the authorial voice. But a reader of the Bible as a narrative who would not realize that in doing this he is at odds with the authorial voice and with the main characters in the successive episodes, would not 'follow' the Bible as the particular narrative it actually is, for that reader would not be an ideal witness to the action actually narrated.

Now, as a fundamentally narrative work the Bible is meant to produce the intrinsic effect by which the narrative genre is characterized. This effect consists in the reader's presence to the action as an ideal witness who reacts to the action and to the characters and, accordingly, suffers and enjoys with the "action," depending on the partial and the final outcomes the reader desires and his reaction to the characters and the authorial voice, which in this particular case *ideally* should consist in the reader's sympathetic identification with the allegiance of the main characters and of the authorial voice to Yaweh.

Let us provisorily identify this unique "allegiance to Yaweh" as a sort of "faith." Let us now compare the Bible to a love story: Romeo and Juliet. No reader of Romeo and Juliet can help sympathizing with the two young lovers and desiring the outcome they desire and they finally do not achieve. The authorial voice is such as to practically insure this "linguistic" effect, without which the story

would hardly make any sense. Thus, although the authorial voice is nowhere explicitly heard, it is all over by the kind of story the author tells and the way he tells it.

Romeo and Juliet is a love story. A story of love because the love between Romeo and Juliet is its central subject. A story because the reader ideally witnesses it as being present to its development, with the dramatic temporality—uncertain, contingent future outcome desired and striven for, whether actually achieved or not. Love, as Saint Thomas said, is “*velle bonum alicui*.” This is a definition, it abstracts the common structure of all loves, whoever the lover and the loved, whatever the circumstances. But what is *velle bonum*, and *velle bonum alicui* in particular? When asked “Who is my neighbor” Christ responded with an example, with a little narrative; not with a definition. Why? Because a definition of a human relationship, even the most apt definition, is an abstraction of the intelligible in singular cases and can mean only by reference to singular cases. And this is so because only what is intelligible can be understood and defined. *Velle bonum alicui*? Christ would have answered with the parable of the good samaritan.

Two points to remark. The parable is not told in a dramatic form. And it is not told in a dramatic form because the purpose of telling this story was not to presentify it narratively but to teach a point, to answer a question. What the interlocutor wanted was to understand, to come to know what he did not know. Now, a narrative may be used to answer a question, but it is not of the nature of narratives to answer questions, while it is of the nature of narratives as such to make the reader present to the action as an ideal witness, as if he had been there.

The point I am after is why the Scripture had to be a narrative, why it could not produce the effects it is meant to produce but by being a narrative and, consequently, why an understanding of the Scripture that presupposes that the Scripture conveys knowledge and demands assent is wrongheaded.

As all stories, the Scriptural narrative is told to hearers-readers. If what it wanted to produce was assent, it would have been a collection of statements. But it is not; it is a story. And a story is a genre that does not demand assent and to which assent and dissent are inept responses to it. If God's revelation consisted in something that demands assent, the Scripture, whose point is revelation and faith, would be made of statements and examples of assent to the statements. Thus what I am after is: *of what sort have to be God's revelation and its correlative, faith, so that they have to be narratively expressed.*

One can approach the Bible with the questions "What is God's revelation?", "What is faith?". In that case one is looking for knowledge, which will take the form of predicative statements. On this level I disagree with Aquinas. We differ in our respective reflective understandings of revelation and faith. However, we share the same faith. Let us call our point of disagreement "cognitive interpretation." And let us call our point of sharing "*practical comprehension.*" What I hold is that this practical comprehension has to be formulated in a mediating story, not in statements.

The implicit term of all perceptual experience is the subject who experiences. Experience is always organized around the named or unnamed subject who experiences: in front or behind me, to my right or to my left, above or below me. Distances unfold from me or, what is the same, toward me.

In the act of experiencing I am given to myself (experience myself experiencing) as much as I experience the objects of my experience. But when I remember and formulate my past experience (of having seen a tree to my right) I do not experience myself as seeing the tree, for I am not seeing the tree anymore. So I have to formulate my particular experience by formulating explicitly both the object experienced and the subject experiencing. This is not experiencing anymore, but formulating the experience, which cannot be adequately formulated without the object (tree) the subject (I) and

their relationship (I saw a tree). In *other words*, the subject of the experience becomes explicit.

Our perceptual experience, however, is experience in a context, in a given spatio-temporal situation. I do not just see a car. I see a car in the street, moving away from me or toward me.

Perception is of the order of interaction, of need-desire and vulnerability. It is structured toward the future desired, toward the realization of the desired outcome. Carthago est delenda Romanis, defendenda Carthaginensibus.

We perceive as witnesses or as involved participants. We do not notice this when ‘everything is under control.’ That is, when we do not desire or fear anything intensely, or when what we desire is not prevented by obstacles that make its achievement uncertain. It is the inverse case that shows the dramatic character of experience and that distributes it into episodes. That is why we spontaneously narrate our experience, though we tend to remember and narrate only significant events.

Actual experience is lived dramatically, toward a desired outcome that is contingent, for which we strive or which we at least desire, but without ever having the absolute certainty of achieving. We know the end of the episode at the end, when the outcome obtains, be it the desired one or a different one. It is always success or failure. And only a narrative preserves the dramatic structure of our experience and its flavor. Because of this, it is, apart from the actual witnessing of the events or the comprehension that accrues to actual participation in them as one of the agents, the only adequate means of communicating an experience to somebody. And because narratives recreate imaginarily the events while preserving their spatio-temporal-dramatic structure of lived experience.

A narrative, however, is not the lived experience itself; it is, even in the case of autobiography, an interpretive formulation of the experience of somebody as deemed to have been lived by the subject.

Our interactions, and therefore our experiences, do not only involve us as subjects, but also other subjects who are sometimes involved as participants in the same events, who may or may not desire and pursue the same outcomes I do, and who will accordingly enter into my story with a positive or negative coefficient of adversity in relation to my desired outcome.

Perceived objects, as we saw above, move us to action, depending on the situation, because we are present and exposed. The world immediately perceived is our immediate field of action and passion in relation to the objects perceived. We do not first perceive and then are moved to act. Perceiving is being moved to act; we perceive instrumentally, hodologically. We have the illusion that perceiving and being moved to act are two different things because we reflect on perception as pure contemplators, precisely when we are not exposed, when we are not involved as agents, when therefore the moving ability of the object is neutralized. But this is not perceived object, it is reflected object. Then, of course, we have the unsolvable problem of the passage from “is” to “ought,” which rests on the wrong assumption that perceiving amounts to seeing, and that being moved is not a constitutive of perceiving. As Sartre says, perceiving and acting are two moments of the same.

Images, whether perceived as images or only imagined, keep their moving power. Being moved is being moved to act, to respond. But in respect of images we are not in a position to respond. Narratives are images of persons involved in action, as we all are in our lives, but understood as images, without any possibility to interfere with the action. Thus, they keep the moving power of perceived objects, but without calling the perceiver, or the imaginer, or the hearer, or the reader to action. *Carthago est delenda* for me, but not delenda by me, if the outcome I desire is Rome’s prosperity. This is the kind of effect characteristic of narratives, which is, on the author’s part, underpinned and intended by the authorial voice, and on the reader’s side by the ‘social personality’ of the individual reader. The reader of *Lolita* usually identifies with Lolita, but a sadist may identify with the protagonist.

A competent writer or teller of stories is capable of producing such identification on the reader's part, with important variations that depend on the particular purposes of the author: to entertain, to explain, to convey knowledge of people and events, etc. A competent follower of narratives is capable of following the characters and events as being moved by them in the particular way defined by his/her identification, which ideally is the one intended and pursued by the authorial voice. People who are totally incapable of being so moved are incompetent linguistic agents, as shown by the fact that this is one of the genres preferred by children because it is connatural to us from the fact that we live our life and the lives of others dramatically. Of course, one may continue to love the narrative genre, in which case one will be an avid reader of dramatic works (plays, novels, history...), as one may become an avid watcher of football games, which are dramatic games and demand, as such, to be followed as dramatic games, identification and being moved on the spectator's side.

Is there a following of narratives as narratives that does not involve this kind of ideal participation (identification and being moved)? I can tape a tennis match and then watch it to study the technique of one of the players. But then I am not following it as a tennis match, as the spectacle was meant to be watched by the spectators. And I would be badly mistaken if I claimed that that is the way tennis matches, as tennis matches, are to be followed. The same with narratives. They are to be followed and understood as narratives. And, for that, the typical participation of the reader of narratives is essential. The same with the author of a narrative. Life is dramatic in that persons in situations desire outcomes that are uncertain and contingent partly on their actions or lack thereof. There is no possibility of understanding a scene of life as we people live it without some idea of the possible outcomes, of the outcome or outcomes desired by the respective participants, and—since it is a scene that has consequences in the world in which one participates by being alive—of not preferring one outcome over others. If I witness a fight in the street between two people unknown to me, I may

be neutral as to the outcome preferred by each of the fighters, but I am not neutral as to the outcome I prefer: the fight to be stopped by somebody, the fight to last because I get enjoyably excited by that kind of spectacle, etc. If I have no idea of the possible outcomes of such a scene and of the outcome preferred by each of the contenders, I do not follow the scene, I am an incompetent witness of real-life scenes. Now, I may not identify myself with either of the contenders. But I identify myself with myself; I am myself, who does not desire the outcomes desired and pursued by the contenders, but I situate myself in regard to the scene as preferring a certain outcome: that the fight lasts long and end with a lot of blood (without which I will be disappointed), or that the fight be immediately stopped. In short, I cannot see a dramatic scene, as a dramatic scene, without desiring an outcome and being moved accordingly, much as I cannot follow an argument as an argument without grasping that the outcome pursued is persuading, and without being persuaded or not persuaded, or considering the argument silly because the issue itself is based on presuppositions which I do not share. (This, for instance, is my case in relation to arguments for or against the passage from is to ought).

But suppose I follow a fight understanding the outcomes desired by each of the fighters but without identifying with either of them and without myself desiring any outcome in particular. Is such understanding possible?

This seems to be Searle's 'understanding' of the 'illocutionary force' of language.

Such understanding of a scene of fighting is not possible. Why not?

One cannot be a competent hearer if one is a totally incompetent speaker, for one cannot understand what is intended *of him* without having any experiential idea that a speaker necessarily intends something linguistically when a speaker speaks. I can understand what a speaker says to a hearer by saying "Come here" without myself saying it, and even without identifying with the speaker as a

commander of this command. But I cannot understand his “Come here” without understanding that he linguistically intends the other to go to where the speaker is, because, let us say, for whatever reason the going there of the hearer appears to me undesirable—because it is dangerous, or because the speaker has no right to command the hearer, etc. But I cannot understand that X is commanded if I do not understand that the speaker has the intention to command. Similarly in the case of a fight. I cannot understand a fight as a fight without understanding that the fighters have the intention to hurt and avoid being hurt, and without some experience of what pain and humiliation are. And I can have no idea of what a fight is if, for me, pain—or at least my pain—is painful and my humiliation humiliating, for inflicting that to the other while avoiding receiving it is the intention without which the fighting behavior is not a fight. In short, I cannot be indifferent to my pain and humiliation if I am to function as a human being who understands a fight, and without understanding that for the fighters their own pain and humiliation are painful and humiliating (undesirable) and the other’s pain and humiliation desirable. Now, as a witness of a fight, I cannot possibly take a *neutral* stand to their inflicting and receiving pain and humiliation, for I am a perceiver confronted with it; it happens in my world, in the world I share with them. I have to take a stand toward these two people who intend to inflict pain and humiliation while avoiding it. My stand may be that I do not care for these two people while I care for the pleasure that their fighting gives me. But this itself is not neutral, it is a way of being moved by identifying with myself. Thus, if our question is whether it is possible to witness a fight as a fight without being moved to prefer an outcome, the answer is no. The same with Searle’s understanding of an order. Commanding is preferring the outcome of being obeyed by the person commanded, as fighting is preferring to inflict pain and humiliation and to avoid receiving it. The person commanded is put in the linguistic situation of being commanded, as the outed player of Searle’s. But the hearer is *a subject who prefers, and constitutes himself as preferrer of, an outcome*, too. His disobedience or his verbal refusal constitute *his*

linguistic self in the given situation, as much as the commanding of the commander constitute his own linguistic self in the situation. Speaking is creating a linguistic situation by constituting himself as preferrer of a linguistic outcome expected from the hearer or hearers who is or are thereby constituted as part of the situation in a determined role to which they cannot be neutral, since it is an end to be pursued by them, and an end is determined by its being preferred by the pursuant.

I-Thou communication is intrinsically dramatic.

But what about the hearer-witness, which seems to be Searle's model for the illocutionary? He is also a subject, creator of situations (linguistic and others), preferrer of outcomes which may be by "identification" those of the participants, or his own in respect of the given situation.

But he cannot be neutral. If he interferes with the action, enters the situation as an agent, obviously he prefers an outcome. If he chooses not to interfere, he prefers the outcome of not being involved and the fight to continue or to be stopped by somebody else. It is from this standpoint of preferring-being moved that he understands the fight as a fight. But he cannot see a fight as a fight from a neutral (unpreferential-unmoved) standpoint.

Going to a match of tennis or to the theater is going as a watcher of tennis or of plays. Reading a narrative is following as a reader-watcher of the narrated, which is intrinsically dramatic and to be understood as such. One can interrupt reading or watching. But one cannot read a narrative without reading it as a narrative, as dramatic. And this amounts to identifying oneself with the outcome of the participants or identifying with oneself as preferrer of a different outcome to the situation, or at least being indifferent as to the actual outcome by being indifferent to the people involved in the action, which is a preferential attitude toward them and their preferred outcomes. In a situation of salutation, refusing to salute because one does not care is preferring an outcome humiliating for the person. In witnessing a non-salutation, one can only be indifferent by pre-

ferring not to care for either person and their preferred outcomes, which is the preferring-being moved from which one understands a denial of salutation. But one cannot understand a dramatic situation neutrally, that is, by being neutral, by not understanding the dramatic situation as a situation that imposes preferred outcomes, for this would amount to understanding it as a-dramatic.

What I want to say is that narratives are to be followed by preferring outcomes and being accordingly moved, and that otherwise they are not followed as narratives, as presentifications of dramatic situations. One may know that it is a narrative, if at all, but at any rate one does not follow it as a narrative.

Suppose I am right and all this applies to the Bible as a narrative. Then what? Then revelation is a dramatic interaction between God as self-revealer and man as revealed to, inseparable from the I-Thou interaction by which God constitutes Himself as self-revealer and man as revealed to by responding to God as God meant to be responded to by His very interaction.

Then the Bible is meant to be read as a narrative of this dramatic interaction, and therefore the reader is to be partisan and consequently moved.

But, again, is there no neutral understanding à la Searle?

First point: Language is communicative and its paradigmatic use is situational. *Human experience itself is, paradigmatically, situational and dramatic, in terms of uncertain outcomes to be achieved.* Therefore, there is no genuine articulation of human experience if this structure of human experience is not preserved. This is what narratives do. Being a human agent is choosing among the outcomes that appear possible in the situation the one to be pursued or avoided.

Obviously one can understand preferred outcomes without preferring them oneself. But one cannot understand them without understanding them as preferred by an agent. Thus, in any case, there is no separation between outcome and preferred, for an outcome is

outcome not as state of affairs but as preferred and pursued state of affairs, much as a situation is situation in terms of a preferred outcome, with the consequent coefficient of positive and negative instrumentality of the elements of the situation for the subject.

Thus, in any case, for the involved participants, there is no possible separation between understood and desired. There is nothing like first understanding and then desiring. One understands by desiring and desires by understanding.

The witness may not desire the outcomes preferred by any of the participants. But he cannot follow the developments without grasping the outcomes preferred by the participants as preferred.

Without that, the witness does not witness the events.

The witness can be witness only because he is an agent-patient, a situational experiencer who prefers *certain* outcomes and for whom preferring outcomes makes sense. For without this the witness would have no idea of outcomes and of situation.

Whoever does not read the Scripture situationally, as a narrative, is not presentified as an ideal witness, whether or not he considers the events real.

Since the Scripture is a speech act, it has an authorial voice which involves certain preferred outcomes which articulates the preferences of the protagonist(s), or the preferences of the author, or both insofar as they genuinely coincide (which in fictional narratives is always the case). But the reader as ideal witness brings to the following of the story his own 'reader's voice.' Whether or not the reader's preferred outcomes coincide with the authorial preferred outcomes, in both cases *the reader has preferred outcomes, not just understanding of preferred outcomes. In fact, this is part and parcel of following a dramatic narrative as a narrative: making sense of preferred outcomes and resonating to characters and events on the basis of ideally preferred outcomes.*

Let me check this by reference to Searle's neutral understanding. His model of language is based on his hearing of language as a

philosopher curious about language, not as involved in the linguistic situation. His “illocutionary” or “meaning of language” is what always obtains for a philosopher curious about language. But is this what obtains for the speaker and the hearer in the paradigmatic linguistic situation?

Only if understanding and preferring are separable. But speaking is communicating a preferred outcome, and hearing is being communicated a preferred outcome either as preferable or unpreferable in terms of the hearer’s own preferred outcome. In his turn, the witness, whether ideal or real, understands the outcomes preferred by the participants only in terms of his own preferred outcomes. Even his indifference is a manifestation of his preferences in the situation as being such as not to demand preferring any particular outcome.

But this is very different from Searle’s understanding, for whom there is a common understanding by the speaker and the hearer of a certain neutral meaning independent of the outcome or outcomes preferred by the speaker, the hearer, or the witness. Words say what *they* mean. No. This is an illusion. The speaker means his preferred outcome by expressing, and the hearer hears it by expressing his preferred outcome, which may be the same or different from the speaker’s.

This might be explained by the case of sincerity. There is no such a thing as insincerely meant. By definition, as Searle admits, the meant is sincerely meant, or it is not meant. There is, however, the utterance of words to create in the hearer the illusion of a preferred outcome. Expressing a preferred outcome is pursuing the outcome—that is speaking. Hearing is as active as speaking in the interactive linguistic situation: it is pursuing a preferred outcome by expressing it communicatively. And reading, the correlative of authoring, is, in the case of narratives, ideally expressing a preferred outcome, much as the spectators in a foot-ball match, by resonating positively or negatively to the events and the characters that pursue certain outcomes. But while reading is a non-communicative activity, hearing

as an involved agent is. Hearing is responding to the outcome meant as preferred by the speaker by preferring that outcome and bringing it about, or by preferring a different outcome and attempting to bring it about.

Thus, the distinction between illocutionary and perlocutionary is illusory. *The effects of language, in the paradigmatic situation of encounter, are always perlocutionary, whether the perlocutionary effects intended by the speaker obtain or not.*

To bring an end to these notes for chapter eight with a reference to Frei: His position is that narratives are to be followed by readers as narratives, where events and characters are inseparable. I have to pay attention to this inseparability.

But it seems to me that *he considers the “content” of narratives without sufficiently considering them as speech acts*, as expressive of the preferred outcomes for the author and, consequently, *as intrinsically meant to produce on the reader’s part, if aptly followed, ideally preferred outcomes that move the reader because they are understood and are understood because the reader is moved.* Of course, “content” and “moving understanding” are correlates. Only such content can produce intrinsically such effects by being followed appropriately, much as only statements can produce assent and commands obedience or disobedience.

Why is this complement to Frei important? Because, as underscored by him, the Bible has been understood as the result of a referring speech act; more clearly, of an act meant to produce assent or dissent by referring the reader to the world he knows. Clearly this cannot be the case of fictional narratives, which is one of his strong points. If narratives mean, they mean to produce different effects by portraying characters inseparable from events. So far, so good. But his book is about the loss of *biblical* narratives. My point is that biblical narratives express, and are ideally meant to produce in their readers, or at least to re-excite in them, the moving-understanding of God’s self-revealing in which faith consists. In other words, the Bible does not only have incidentally the particular content it has.

It has that narrative content because it is meant to express and excite or re-excite the unique self-revelatory history of God and the unique response to it in which faith consists. As long as we think that revelation is a sharing of knowledge in a long statement and faith an assent to it on the basis of God's authority, we may live the Christian faith but at the price of being at odds with our understanding of it, which creates impossible problems. The reading of the Bible cannot give us faith, but at least it can give both those who believe and those who don't a more apt basis for the discussion of their differences than the one we have nowadays.

Searle's perlocutionary

He rightly affirms that often the perlocutionary effects intended by the speaker do not obtain, and nonetheless the hearer understands. What then is wrong?

Searle identifies understanding with the understanding of a witness, not with the understanding of the addressee: knowing that. But the speaker means it as a performative. The addressee is out, the addressee is saluted, the addressee is being linguistically loved when the speech act succeeds. This may become knowledge, but is not knowledge anymore than knowing that I was ashamed is the same as being ashamed or knowing that you are ashamed is the same as being ashamed. In the witness-pure contemplator, knowledge may be the effect, but it is not the effect characteristic of language, for it is not the effect meant by the speaker, and it is not the effect undergone by the addressee.

Yet the perlocutionary effect intended may not obtain. Begged by you, I may not give. It is characteristic of linguistic effects that they may not obtain, for the hearer, too, is a subject, author of his actions as the speaker is author of his speech acts. In this, however, linguistic action does not differ from any other action, for the intended effects of any action may not obtain. You intended to kill me, but you failed. The fact that I understand this and a witness understands this does not imply that you intended to share with me the piece of information that you intended to kill me. The difference

is that *linguistic actions, unlike others, are cooperative actions* that depend on the cooperation of the addressee. But Searle's point is that speaking essentially involves the willingness to inform you of my intentions, whereas killing does not. My point is that speaking essentially involves the intention of the effect to be cooperatively performed. By blackmailing you I intend you to become linguistically blackmailed, not to inform you that I am blackmailing you. But, if the effect does not obtain, what do I have to say to Searle? After all I understood what you said, and I refuse to be blackmailed. I reply that what constitutes me as a hearer is my refusing to be blackmailed, not my understanding what you said. Understanding language as an addressee consists in responding appropriately to you speaking, not in getting a piece of information about your intentions. If when blackmailed by you I do not refuse or accept to perform accordingly, I am not a hearer of language. If when saluted by you I do not refuse or accept your salutation, I am not a hearer of language. In fact, even the 'understanding' of the witness-hearer is of this kind, for he understands the blackmailing as a performative intention and the acceptance or refusal of the blackmailed as a performance in response. Someone who understands the blackmailer's words but does not understand them as threatening is an incompetent hearer. The action of refusing is as linguistic as the action of accepting being blackmailed.

Furthermore, abstractly, if we are to understand linguistic action, the speech act has to be defined by the cases in which the effect intended by the speaker obtains in the addressee. For if it were defined by the cases in which it does not obtain, begging would not take place, much as if we defined stating by the cases of insincere stating. And then, the words of begging, of blackmailing, of stating would become unintelligible in the sense in which Searle considers it intelligible, for they would mean nothing. Language means because linguistic intentions of the speaker succeed most of the time under the appropriate circumstances. In a society in which nobody consents when begged, begging would be unintelligible, all the sentences expressing begging would be unintelligible. Being a

competent speaker of the English language is being capable of begging, of consenting when begged, and of grasping as a witness the perlocutionary or performative force of begging and being begged.

This is connected with the intellectualistic fallacy.

And with statements in particular. Indeed, statements have the particular characteristic of referring the speaker to something else than the action to be performed by the hearer. "The pencil is on the table." I refer you to the world, not to yourself as performer. And, if assent is demanded, it is assent to the said, not to me directly.

This leads people to think (1) that statements are purely objective judgments or descriptions of the world to be compared to either with the world itself or with my own judgment of the world; that statements are mere propositions about the world and, thus, that one understands them by understanding them à la Searle.

- (2) That, as Searle does, this way of understanding language applies to all other speech acts and that it is the condition for the other effects which are called "perlocutionary" by opposition to the common meaning of language which is illocutionary.

The content of a judgment appears detachable from the speaker and the hearer, capable of being considered by itself.

This appears to be true only when one takes the pure contemplator's position characterized by the pure desire to know.

Certainly the pure desire to know is not the primary intention of people in linguistic situations where statements are made and heard. Insofar as statements refer to the world, they refer to it as constituted by objects of exposure. I say "The pencil is on the table" only to guide your practical action, not to inform you of a neutral matter of fact. I refer you, therefore, to an object of exposure. Consequently, I do not expect from you mere intellectual assent, but practical response to the object as stated. "The pencil (for which you are looking) is on the table." I want you, given your desire, to take it. Taking the pencil (in the ideal case), or refusing to take it, are the only appropriate responses that constitute linguistic understanding.

Thus, in everyday life, statements are not mere propositions for consideration in view of their truth.

Their case is no different from other speech acts as to their performative character. Of course, the performance involved is not the same as in begging or commanding, but it is performance nonetheless. Thus, understanding a statement as a pure understanding of the stated à la Searle is as wrongheaded as a pure understanding of the commanded.

A further step. Asking whether a statement is true is already a way of neutralizing its practical referring effect, of interrupting the communication; for it is hearing it as a mere proposition when it was meant as a statement. This may happen either because what you state contradicts my actual perception or my belief, or because I distrust you. If I am primarily interested in “reality” as to be contemplated, which was Aristotle’s case, and consider perception on the model of pure seeing and as not full knowledge, I equate a proposition with a perception, I consider the truth-value of the proposition, and I end up assenting or dissenting. The proposition represents the first stage (perceiving—which did not interest Aristotle because of its particularity and contingency—and prospective understanding or hypothesizing); the assent represents the second stage: assent to what is perceived or understood. Now, what the speaker supposedly communicates to me is an understanding of the object to which the speaker assents—a judged to be so. But *I understand by understanding à la Searle what he says, the said*, which in my turn I will take as a prospective understanding to which, depending on the circumstances, I will assent or dissent. If I assent, then I will be referred to the object as real, that is, as known contemplatively and to be known explanatorily.

“The pencil is on the table.” For Aristotle and Aquinas it is a matter of whether I can rationally assent to this neutral fact, for only on that basis can I desire the pencil and act in its regard. This truth is speculative and it yields reality. To reach this kind of truth is the supreme goal of man. It is the ultimate desirable by reference

to which all the rest is really desirable and undesirable insofar as it leads us to the fruitional contemplation in vision of that reality.

Do I deny that the pencil is on the table? No. But I deny that the pencil is on the table if it cannot be object of desire or aversion or desire to anybody in any context. That it is actually constituted as reality known by being actually averted or desired by somebody as pencil on the table. That this can only occur in a dramatic context. That from there we can abstract its reality in itself for future encounters in other dramatic contexts in the future.

My final point: Is knowing a condition for desiring or averting? The question is equivalent to: Is Searle's understanding of language a condition for responding appropriately?

The question itself presupposes a distinction between knowing and desiring, between understanding and responding. My point is that responding appropriately is understanding, that there is no understanding where there is no appropriate response, which of course varies with the roles occupied in the situation; but *the paradigmatic case of hearing is the case of the addressee, not of the witness*. He who exposed to fire does not understand fire as fearful and himself as vulnerable does not understand fire. Our understanding of fire 'in absence' is a sedimentation of our practical understanding. A physicist's understanding of fire is explanatory of the 'nature' of fire: from what fire does (and is done) to what fire's nature is. Not only is this understanding not in presence of exposure to fire, but an abstraction (however useful) from the dimension of exposure, and therefore a bad model for understanding and knowledge.

All this has to be replaced in the *dramatic* context of desired and feared outcomes.

Chapter 9: Revelation as Self-Revelation

Curator's note: Xavier's manuscript breaks off in chapter 8, whose final pages are working notes rather than finished prose. No further chapters were found among his papers. Chapters 9 through 11 are a posthumous reconstruction, drafted with AI assistance from Xavier's own outline in the chapter 8 notes and from his essays on the same questions (REVELAT and NARRATIV, 1990; FREI-APP, 1993). They attempt to complete the argument as he projected it, in his manner. They should not be quoted as his writing.

At the end of the last chapter I formulated the question toward which this whole book has been moving: of what sort have to be God's revelation and its correlative, faith, so that they have to be narratively expressed? The question, as the reader will have noticed, reverses the order in which Aquinas proceeds. Aquinas starts from a notion of revelation: revelation as the sharing by God of His knowledge with us. From that notion the character of the Bible follows: since knowledge is a matter of judgments expressed in statements, the Bible has to be a book of statements, whatever its surface appearance. I start from the other end. The Bible is there, and its fundamental literary genre is narrative. If the Bible is the privileged expression of God's revelation, and if, as I argued in the preceding chapter, the narrative sense is irreducible to the propositional sense,

then the presumption must be that revelation itself is of such a nature that only a narrative can convey it. What nature is that?

The purpose of this chapter is to answer that question with respect to revelation. The next chapter will answer it with respect to faith. I do not pretend that the answer I will propose is demonstrated by what precedes. I claim only that it accounts for the data better than the notion it is meant to replace, and that it restores to intelligibility precisely those features of the Bible and of the Christian tradition that Aquinas's notion had to treat as accidental, as mere matters of style.

Two notions of revelation

Let us have the two candidates clearly before us.

The first notion is the one we have been studying throughout this book. Revelation is the transmission by God of a body of truths, of "a doctrine revealed by God" (I, 1, 1). What God reveals is His own knowledge: the knowledge He has of Himself, primarily, and, secondarily, of what we must know and do to reach the vision of Him in which our eternal happiness consists. Since knowledge is a matter of judgments, and since judgments find their natural expression in statements, revelation consists, concretely, in statements made by God. The Bible is the record of those statements. Its implicit preface, as I put it earlier, is "This is what God has stated to us about Himself and about what we need for our salvation." The appropriate response to revelation so conceived is assent: the intellectual acceptance of the revealed statements as true, not because we see their truth, but because the One who states them can neither err nor lie.

The second notion I will now state in my own terms, though the reader will recognize in it, I hope, the understanding that the Fathers lived from and that the resisters of chapter four obscurely defended. Revelation is not, primarily, the transmission of truths. Revelation is God's self-revelation: the act by which God, entering into interaction with particular persons in particular situations, makes Himself present to them as who He is, as the One who calls, demands, promises, judges, delivers, and remains faithful. What is

revealed is not a body of statements about God but God Himself, exactly in the sense in which a person becomes known to another person: through what he does and says in the dramatic give-and-take of a shared history, not through a dossier of true propositions about him.

The difference between the two notions may seem slight. It is, in fact, abysmal. On the first notion, the interactions narrated in the Bible are the packaging of revelation: God's dealings with Abraham are the occasion, the vehicle, perhaps the pedagogical sweetening, of certain truths that could in principle be extracted and restated without loss, and this extraction is precisely what theology, on Aquinas's understanding of it, undertakes to do. On the second notion, the interactions are the revelation. To extract "truths" from them and to treat those truths as the revealed is to mistake the sediment for the spring. It is, to use the term that has accompanied us from the first chapter, a *determinatio distrahens*: a determination of the revealed that distorts it in the very act of fixing it.

Which of the two notions is the right one? The way to decide is to look at the cases the Bible itself presents as revelation. If revelation is what the first notion says it is, we should find, at the paradigmatic moments, God transmitting statements and men assenting to them. Let us look.

The case of Abraham, once more

I return, then, to Abraham, the father of the faithful, and I ask the reader's patience for returning to a scene we have already visited more than once. The repetition is not idle. Each time we have come to this scene we have brought better tools, and each time the scene has told us more.

God says to Abraham: "Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering." Is this a statement? It is not. It is a command. It is expressed in the imperative, and it does not transmit any piece of knowledge to be assented to or dissented from; it demands to be obeyed or disobeyed. Earlier, God had said to Abraham: "Go from

your country and your kindred and your father's house to the land that I will show you. And I will make of you a great nation, and I will bless you." A command again, and joined to it a promise. Now, a promise is no more a statement than a command is. A promise does not inform the hearer of a future state of affairs, as a forecast does; it binds the promiser to the hearer. He who promises does not describe the future; he commits himself, and by committing himself he opens for the one to whom the promise is made a future that would not otherwise exist. Commands and promises belong to what I called in the last chapter the involved or exposed mode of language. They are performatives. They do things, and what they do, they do between persons.

But here is the point on which everything turns. A command reveals the commander. A promise reveals the promiser. Not in the way a statement about the commander would reveal him, not by predicating attributes of him, but in the way persons reveal themselves: by doing. When God commands Abraham to leave Haran, He constitutes Himself, then and there, as the God who has a claim on Abraham; and when He promises, He constitutes Himself as the God to whom Abraham's future belongs. What Abraham comes to know of God, he comes to know through this history of demands, responses, and outcomes; I do not hesitate to use the word "know" here, provided it is understood in the sense in which we know persons and not in the sense in which we know theorems. He learns that God is faithful the way a wife learns that her husband is faithful: not by assenting to the statement "he is faithful," but by living through the years in which his fidelity is exercised, tested, and confirmed. By the time of Moriah, Abraham has such a history with God. That is why the scene of Moriah is intelligible at all. A stranger's command to sacrifice one's son can only be heard with horror; the command of the God of the promise, of the God whose fidelity has been lived, is heard—with anguish, no doubt—within that history, and the narrative gives us the history precisely so that we may hear the command as Abraham heard it.

Where, in all this, are the revealed statements? The honest answer is: nowhere. God states remarkably little to Abraham. He commands, He promises, He asks, He swears. If revelation consisted in the transmission of God's knowledge, we should have to say that to Abraham—to the very man whom Saint Paul holds up as the model of the faithful, to the recipient of the covenant on which the whole biblical history is built—almost nothing was revealed. The conclusion is absurd, and the absurdity is instructive. It shows that the first notion of revelation fails exactly where it should succeed best. The paradigmatic recipient of revelation received, on Aquinas's account of what revelation is, nearly nothing; on the account I am proposing, he received everything: God gave Abraham nothing less than Himself, as the partner of a covenant, and Abraham's whole life was henceforth lived within that self-donation.

Of course, one may reply that in the Bible God does sometimes state. He declares His name to Moses; He declares, through the prophets, His judgments on Israel. I do not deny it. But two remarks are in order. First, even these declarations occur within interactions and derive their sense from them. The name is declared to Moses out of the burning bush, in the act of commissioning him, and in answer to Moses's practical question—what shall I say to the people who send me?—not in answer to a speculative one. The prophetic oracles are addressed to a people bound by covenant, in the concrete dramatic situations of that covenant: infidelity, threat, exile, return; and they call, comfort, indict, and warn. They are performatives through and through. Second, and more importantly, the statements are never the point. What Israel possesses when the interaction has passed is not a residue of divine information but a history with its God, and when Israel wants to say who its God is, it does not recite propositions; it tells the story. "A wandering Aramean was my father..." The creed of Israel is a narrative because what Israel knows of God it knows narratively, as one knows the partner of one's own history.

Revelation and inspiration

At this point a confusion must be removed which, if I am right, has burdened theology since the Scholastics and has made the correct notion of revelation almost impossible to hold. It is the confusion between revelation and inspiration.

On Aquinas's understanding, God is "the author of Holy Scripture" (I, 1, 10). The formula is traditional, and there is a sense in which I have no quarrel with it. But observe what happens when the formula is combined with the propositional notion of revelation. If revelation is God's statements, and if God is the author of the Bible, then the Bible is the set of God's statements: revelation and the text of the Bible become materially identical. This identification, as we saw in chapter seven, is precisely the basis of Aquinas's whole treatment: the equation 'revelation = knowledge = Holy Scripture.' The theologian then relates to the Bible as a student to the utterances of an infallible teacher: every sentence of the text, being God's sentence, is a premise available for the deductions of the science of theology.

But the identification will not survive a moment's attention to what the Bible actually is and to what the Bible itself presents revelation as being. The revelation to Abraham took place between God and Abraham, in the interactions we have considered. The author of Genesis was not there. What the author of Genesis produced, centuries later, gathering the traditions of Israel, is a narrative of those interactions. The narrative is not the revelation; it is the witness to the revelation, its presentification for those who were not there. To say that the narrative was inspired is to say that God so moved and accompanied the narrator that the narrative presents the foundational interactions faithfully—that the God whom the reader meets in the story is the God whom Abraham met at Moriah. It is emphatically not to say that God dictated statements to the narrator, or that the revelation happened to the narrator in the act of writing. The Scholastics, having conflated revelation with inspiration, had to conceive the sacred writer as a secretary and the text as a dictation,

and then the implicit preface “God stated that...” became inevitable, and with it everything we have watched unfold: the Bible as a scientific book, the literal sense as propositional sense, faith as assent, theology as the deductive exploitation of divine premises.

Distinguish revelation from inspiration, and the whole picture rights itself. Revelation is God’s self-revealing interaction with Abraham, with Moses, with the prophets, with Israel—and, for the Christian, definitively and unsurpassably, in Jesus of Nazareth, in whom the self-giving of God is no longer only enacted in commands and promises but is present in person. Inspiration is the divine assistance by which the witness of those interactions, the narrative, was produced and is trustworthy. The Bible is inspired; what the Bible narrates is revelation. The text is not a deposit of statements made by God; it is the Spirit-guarded presentification of the deeds by which God gave Himself to be known.

I am aware that this distinction, so baldly stated, would have seemed less than obvious to the medievals, and I do not claim that any of the thinkers we studied in chapters three and four formulated it. But I do claim that it is what their resistances were groping toward. When Kilwardby insisted that “the truth of the Scripture is not the result of rational inquiry but of divine inspiration, exclusively,” and when de Halès maintained that the genre of the Bible is “*revelativus*” and not “*argumentativus*,” they were protesting, without the conceptual tools to say so, against the flattening of the revelatory into the propositional. The genre of the Bible is *revelativus*: the formula is better than its authors could know. The Bible’s genre is to reveal: to make present the self-revealing God—and that is why its genre is narrative, for only a narrative makes present.

How revelation reaches us

We touch here the question that the propositional notion of revelation answers so easily and, I believe, so falsely: how does revelation, which happened to Abraham and to Israel and in Christ, reach us, who were not there?

The propositional answer is straightforward: revelation is a body of truths; truths are indifferent to time; the truths revealed then are transmitted, taught, and assented to now. The transmission of revelation is the transmission of information, and the Church is, on this view, above all a teaching apparatus, handing down statements guaranteed by the divine authority that first uttered them.

The narrative answer is of a different kind, and to give it I must recall what was established in the last chapter about the intrinsic effect of narratives. A narrative is a presentification of dramatic events by means of which a competent reader is made present to those events as an ideal witness, present as if he were there, moved by the action, resonating to the characters, desiring outcomes, though unable to intervene. This being-made-present is not an ornament of narratives; it is what narratives are for; it is their proper and irreplaceable effect.

Now we can say how revelation reaches us. The biblical narrative makes the reader present, as an ideal witness, to the foundational interactions in which God gave Himself to be known. Reading of Moriah, I am there: I hear the command, I walk the three days with Abraham, I suffer his anguish, I am relieved with him at the outcome, and—this is the decisive point—the God who commands, provides, and swears is present to me exactly as He was present to Abraham, in His deeds. The narrative does not report to me that certain revelatory events once occurred; it seats me before the events themselves. This and nothing else is what it means to say that the Bible conveys revelation. The Bible does not convey information about a revelation that happened elsewhere; the Bible is the standing possibility, for every generation of readers, of witnessing the self-revelation of God.

If this seems too strong, consider the alternative through a comparison I have used before. Take Anna Karenina, and take, on the other hand, a plot summary of Anna Karenina in a history of literature. The summary transmits, if you wish, the same “information”; the same statements can be extracted from both. But the summary

moves no one, and the novel moves everyone who can read. Whatever it is that the novel gives and the summary withholds—I have called it the narrative sense—that is what would be lost if revelation were repackaged as statements. And in the case of the Bible, what would be lost is not an aesthetic surplus. It is the presence of the revealer. A God about whom I possess correct statements is precisely not the God of Abraham; He is the God of the philosophers, reached at the end of an argument or received at the end of a testimony, an object of well-founded assent. The God of Abraham is someone before whom one stands. The narrative, and only the narrative, puts me there.

Hence the transmission of revelation is not, fundamentally, the handing down of truths. It is the handing down of the story, the shared foundational story, and, with it, of the mode of reading by which the story does its proper work. I say “shared foundational story” deliberately. A foundational story is a narrative of the events that changed and thereafter determined the course of a life; we all carry such stories, and we tell them when we want to be known. Israel’s Scriptures are the foundational story of a people; the Gospels are the foundational story of the new Israel. To be a member of the people is to have this story as one’s own—to find one’s own life inscribed within its dramatic arc, between the promises already given and the outcome still awaited. The Bible, let it be remembered, ends with its desired outcome still pending. The story is unfinished, and the reader who reads it as it asks to be read does not merely witness it; he discovers that he is in it.

The witness who becomes a participant

Here, however, an objection arises which I must meet, for it goes to the heart of the matter. I said in the last chapter that the reader of a narrative is an ideal witness: present to the action but unable to intervene. I have said in this chapter that revelation is interaction, and that the reader of the Bible witnesses God’s self-revelation. But witnessing an interaction is not being a party to it. Charlemagne, hearing the Passion narrated, could cry that had he been there with

his Franks they would not have crucified Him; the cry does him honor, but it also measures his distance: he was not there, and his sword could change nothing. If the reader of the Bible is only an ideal witness, then revelation, for him, is a spectacle: something that happened between God and others, watched from a window from which no help can be given and no call can be heard. Is that Christian faith? Obviously it is not.

The objection would be fatal if the Bible were a narrative like others. But the Bible presents a peculiarity which I noted in the last chapter and whose import can now be measured: one of its characters is not, like all characters of all other narratives, enclosed in the past of the narrated events. Yaweh lives. The God who commanded Abraham is not a personage whose doings ended when the book was closed; He is, the authorial voice of the whole Scripture insists on every page, the living God, whose covenant stands, whose promises are still open, whose claim reaches every hearer of the story. The Bible is the only narrative whose central character steps out of the story to address the reader.

The consequence for the reader is this. I begin as an ideal witness: made present to Moriah, moved, resonating. But in the very act of witnessing, I discover that the God I am watching is watching me; that the command "Go" and the promise "I will bless you," which I overheard as addressed to Abraham, are, in the mouth of the living God, addressed also to me; that the story I am following is the story of the covenant into which my own baptism has inscribed me. The window from which I watched turns out to be a door. The ideal witness is summoned to become a participant. And this summons is not an accident that befalls some readers of the Bible; it is the intrinsic effect the book is meant to produce, intended by the authorial voice from the first page. That is what the resisters meant when they said, against the *modus scientialis*, that the Scripture "talks to the heart and moves to love and fear God." The Bible does not address the intellect of a contemplator, offering statements for assent. It presents the self-revealing God until the reader stands where Abraham stood: called, claimed, and awaiting his own response.

What that response is, what it is called, what it consists in, and why the Scholastics' name for it, assent, names something else—is the question of the next chapter.

Revelation, then, is essentially narrative

Let me gather the threads of this chapter, for its conclusion can now be stated in one breath.

If revelation were the transmission of God's knowledge, its natural expression would be the statement, and its adequate literary form would be the doctrinal treatise; the narrative form of the Bible would be a concession to the rude, a pedagogical detour, in principle dispensable; a *Summa* would indeed be, for the educated, a better Bible. That is the position into which, as we saw, Aquinas's principles forced him, whether or not he would have owned it in so many words.

But if revelation is God's self-revelation through interaction, if what is given is not statements about God but God Himself, present in His deeds to particular persons in a shared history, then revelation is intrinsically dramatic. It has the structure of lived life: situated, temporal, contingent, moving toward outcomes desired and feared. And we established in the last chapter that there exists exactly one literary genre whose nature it is to preserve and communicate that structure: the narrative. A drama can only be conveyed dramatically. The narrative form of the Bible is therefore not packaging but essence. The Bible is a narrative because revelation is an interaction; it could not be otherwise and still convey what it has to convey. The *determinatio distrahens* that this book has pursued from its first page stands now fully exposed: to translate the Bible into statements is not to reformulate revelation but to replace it—to substitute for the self-giving God a body of information, for presence a dossier, for the covenant a curriculum.

I do not conclude that the medieval masters, in so translating it, lost the faith. They manifestly did not; and how it is that their faith survived their theory of it is a question to which I will return in the final chapter, for the answer is full of light. Nor do I conclude that

every extraction of statements from the narrative is illegitimate; the Church's confessions of faith are such extractions, and in what sense they are legitimate and even necessary will occupy us later. What I conclude is more precise: that revelation itself, the thing the Bible exists to convey, is of the narrative order and not of the propositional order; that the Bible conveys it by making its readers witnesses, and its living Character makes them participants; and that, consequently, the response that revelation calls for cannot be what Aquinas said it was. Not assent. Something else, which Abraham did on the road to Moriah, which the Fathers called by its right name, and which we must now examine.

Chapter 10: Faith as Consent

Curator's note: This chapter, like chapters 9 and 11, is a posthumous reconstruction drafted with AI assistance from Xavier's notes and essays. See the note at the head of chapter 9. It should not be quoted as his writing.

Scio cui credidi. “I know whom I have believed.” Paul’s words to Timothy have always seemed to me the most exact confession of faith in the whole Christian literature, and the most resistant to the analysis we have watched Aquinas perform. Whom, not what. Paul does not say: I know that what has been stated to me is true. He says: I know the One into whose hands I have delivered myself. If the preceding chapter is right, if revelation is God’s self-revelation through interaction, narratively conveyed, and if the reader of the Scripture is a witness summoned to become a participant, then the question of this chapter answers itself in outline: faith is whatever it is that the summoned witness does when he takes up the summons. It remains to say precisely what that is, why the right name for it is consent rather than assent, and what becomes of the “truths of faith” once faith itself is correctly named. None of these tasks is small, and the last will bring us face to face with what is sound in Aquinas’s account. For there is something sound in it, misplaced rather than false, and we will not have finished with him until we have restored it to its place.

What Abraham did

Let us begin, as always, with the paradigmatic case, and let us this time state it with all the precision our tools allow.

God commanded Abraham to go to Moriah and offer his son. We have established that the command is a performative, not a statement; that it transmitted no knowledge; that there was, at Moriah, nothing to be assented to. What did Abraham's faith consist in? The Scripture answers with awful simplicity: "Abraham rose early in the morning, saddled his ass, and took two of his young men with him, and Isaac his son; and he cut the wood for the burnt offering, and arose and went." His faith consisted in going. Not in going as mere outward performance—a slave, hating his master, could have gone—but in going as the embodied yes of a man to the God whose claim on him he acknowledged with his whole being. The Latin of the tradition has the exact word: *ob-audire*, to hear-toward, to hear as one turned toward the caller, whence our "obey." Abraham's hearing of the command and his obedience to it were not two acts, an intellectual reception followed by a volitional execution. His obedience was his hearing, the only hearing a command can properly receive; a command heard with perfect neutrality, taken under advisement, has precisely not been heard as a command.

I will call what Abraham did consent, and I oppose it point by point to assent.

Assent is an act of the intellect; the whole man consents. Assent terminates in a proposition: one assents to the truth of what is said; consent terminates in a person: one consents to someone, to his claim, to his call, and only derivatively to the content of the call. Assent leaves the assenter where he stood; a proposition accepted adds to my stock of knowledge without engaging my future. Consent commits; he who consents has delivered something of himself, has bound his future, has become, in the very act, someone he was not before, as Abraham, consenting, became the father of the faithful, and as the man and woman who exchange consent become spouses. Assent, finally, can be compelled by evidence, and is the more

perfect the more it is compelled; consent can never be compelled by anything, and is the more perfect the more freely it is given. The two acts are not species of a genus. They belong to different orders: assent to the order of contemplation, consent to the order of exposure, the order in which we stand before persons who make demands on us, in situations whose outcome hangs on our response.

Is consent then blind, a leap of the will unaccompanied by understanding? Nothing of the sort, and the point is capital. Consent involves understanding, but understanding of the practical order, the kind we analyzed in chapter eight when we found that grasping the performative force of a speech act is not separable from responding to it. Camus has given us, in *The Fall*, the perfect counter-case, and I have used it elsewhere; it belongs here. Clamence, crossing the bridge at night, hears the cry of the girl who has thrown herself into the river. He understands the cry—understands it precisely as a call for help addressed to him, the only passerby; his whole subsequent life of corrosive self-judgment proves how perfectly he understood. And he keeps walking. Did Clamence lack some piece of knowledge? Was there a proposition he failed to assent to? Obviously not; propositionally, his equipment was complete. What he refused was not an assent but himself. He heard the call and denied it his person. Clamence is the exact photographic negative of Abraham: understanding without consent, hearing without ob-audire. Set the two figures side by side and the anatomy of faith is laid bare. Faith is not what Clamence had and misused; faith is what Clamence refused to do. It is the consent of the exposed person to the one who calls him, an understanding-responding that no accumulation of assented propositions can amount to, since one can possess them all, as Clamence possessed his, and stand in the night unmoved.

The devils, Saint James remarks, believe—and tremble. On Aquinas's analysis of faith the remark is very hard to place, and the embarrassment of his commentary on it is instructive. The devils assent to every article; their information is impeccable; on the propositional account they are believers, and James's irony is unintelligible. Name faith consent, and the verse becomes transparent:

the devils have every assent and no consent; they know all about God and say no to Him; they are Clamence perfected.

The Fathers' preposition

The reader will have recognized where we have arrived. We have arrived, with our own tools and by our own road, at the doctrine of the Fathers examined in chapter five, at the distinction, which we found running through the whole patristic literature and codified by Augustine, between *credere Deum*, *credere Deo*, and *credere in Deum*. To believe that God is; to believe God, as one believes a truthful speaker; and to believe into God: *credere in Deum*, the strange accusative of motion that the Fathers refused to surrender even when their grammarians frowned, because it said exactly what they meant: a believing that is a movement of the whole man toward God and into God, a self-transporting adherence, what Augustine glosses as *credendo amare*, *credendo in eum ire*, *credendo ei adhaerere*: by believing to love, by believing to go into him, by believing to cleave to him. When we set consent against assent, we were only rediscovering the Fathers' preposition. Their "in" with the accusative is the grammar of consent. Aquinas, as we saw, knew the triple formula perfectly well and cites it with reverence; but his system, having defined faith as an act of the intellect assenting to the First Truth, could find for the movement "into God" no constitutive role. The *credere in Deum* had to be reassigned to the will as faith's extrinsic motor: charity pushing from without an intellect assenting within, and the Fathers' single, indivisible act was sawn in two. The tradition's own word for the wholeness of that act is the heart. The Scripture does not say that Abraham's intellect assented while his will supplied the motion; it says that he walked, and the Fathers say that faith is the heart's cleaving to God. *Corde creditur*, Paul writes to the Romans: with the heart man believes. The heart, in the biblical anthropology, is not a faculty among faculties; it is the person in his undivided depth, mind and will and affection not yet parceled out. Faith is an act of the heart because consent is an act of the person, not of one of his departments.

We can now also say, with some precision, why the propositional analysis of faith is not merely incomplete but produces, when lived, a recognizable deformation. Tell the faithful for seven centuries that faith is the intellect's assent to revealed truths, and you will form believers whose center of gravity is the catalog, for whom the life of faith is custody of correct statements, whose crises of faith are crises of assent ("can I still hold article seven?"), and whose God, however officially personal, functions as the guarantor of the catalog: the First Truth, source of reliable information. The relationship is inverted at its root. For the Fathers, one trusts the statements because one has consented to God; the credenda live entirely from the credere in. For the heirs of the Scholastic analysis, one is related to God by holding statements about Him on His authority: the person is approached through the propositions. It is the difference between a marriage and a dossier. And when, in a later age, the dossier came to seem doubtful—when the propositions were exposed to the acids of historical criticism—the faith that had been taught to live in the propositions died with them; whereas a faith that had known itself as consent could have watched the dossier burn, and grieved, and stood. *Se en manos de quien estoy*: I know in whose hands I am. The unlettered Carmelite had the essence; the doctors had mislaid it.

What, then, of the truths of faith?

Here, however, I must stop and turn, for an objection has been gathering against me for several pages, and it is the strongest objection this book will face. It runs: You have made faith a consent to a person, and you have made revelation a narrative presentification rather than a body of statements. But the Church confesses. The Christian faith has always had a content, articulable in propositions, and the Church has anathematized those who denied the propositions. "I believe in one God, the Father almighty... and in one Lord Jesus Christ... true God from true God, consubstantial with the Father." Is the Nicene Creed not a catalog of statements? Did the Fathers of Nicaea—your Fathers—not fight for a proposition, indeed for a preposition and an iota? If faith is consent and not assent, the creeds are unintelligible, and your account has proved too much.

The objection deserves a careful answer, and the answer will occupy us to the end of this chapter. It has three steps.

First: consider what kind of speech act a creed is. The creed is not, in its native use, a treatise; it is a confession. Its home is the baptistery, and its grammatical subject is “I”: *credo*, I believe. The catechumen, standing in the water, facing the East, renouncing Satan, is asked: “Do you believe in God the Father almighty?” and answers “I believe”—and is plunged. This is not the classroom scene of statement and assent; it is the marriage scene of demand and consent. The creed is the articulation of the consent: it names the One to whom the catechumen is giving himself, and it names Him by His deeds: maker of heaven and earth; who for us men and for our salvation came down; suffered under Pontius Pilate; rose on the third day. The *symbolum* is, in fact, the foundational narrative compressed to its dramatic skeleton, recited in the first person as an act of allegiance. Its performative force is that of “I do” in the exchange of vows, which also, be it noted, can be written out as a proposition, and is not one. To read the creed as a catalog of statements is to make exactly the mistake, and the whole of the mistake, that this book has been anatomizing: it is to take the grammatical surface, declarative sentences, for the semantic function, which is self-committal. The *symbola fidei* were mistaken for catalogs of truths; I wrote that sentence, with grief, many chapters ago. The mistake was not Nicaea’s. It came later, when the confessions were detached from the font and filed as premises.

Second: I do not deny—I affirm—that the confession has cognitive content, and that the content matters absolutely. Consent is consent to someone; it therefore involves, as its internal moment, the identification of the one consented to. When the Church says “true God from true God,” she is not adding information to a dossier; she is protecting the identity of the Bridegroom. Arius’s Christ, a creature however exalted, is somebody else; to consent to him is to marry the wrong person. That is why the Fathers of Nicaea fought as men fight for a marriage and not as scholars fight for a thesis, and why the anathema is the form their statement took: the creed’s

propositions are the fence around the consent, drawn under attack, to keep the faithful cleaving to the right God. Doctrine, in its legitimate office, is the guardian of the Name: the specification of whom the narrative presents and whom the consent embraces. It arises when the narrative's identification of God is contested, and it functions rightly when it sends the believer back into the narrative and the consent with his allegiance undeceived. It functions wrongly: it becomes *determinatio distrahens*, the moment it presents itself as the revealed itself, as the content which the narrative existed to package and which, once extracted, can retire the narrative. The test is always the direction of service: statements in the service of the story and the consent, or story and consent demoted to occasions of the statements. On one side of that line stand the Fathers, Nicaea included; on the other side stands the Bible read as a quarry of premises, prefaced by "God stated that..."

Third: we can now give assent its due and its place, and thereby render to Aquinas what is Aquinas's. Assent is not an intruder in the life of faith. The believer, reflecting on his consent, and he must reflect, being a rational creature living among contested identifications, forms judgments: that God is; that He raised Jesus from the dead; that the One I have consented to is such as the story presents Him. To these judgments he assents, and his assent is firm with the firmness of his consent, unshakable not because the evidence compels but because his person is given. Assent, in the believer, is real; it is derivative; it is the reflective shadow that consent casts when faith turns to look at itself. Abraham, on the road back from Moriah, would have assented to the statement that God had commanded him and had provided the ram, of course; the assent is the *post factum* register, in the contemplative order, of what was lived in the order of exposure. The Scholastics' error was one of primacy: they took the shadow for the body. They found in the believer's life genuine assents, described them with matchless precision; no one has ever analyzed the reflective moment of faith more finely than Aquinas; and then installed the reflective moment as the essence, defining faith by what faith does when it is momentarily

doing nothing. It is the same error, in the same direction, that we have found at every level of the system: reflection promoted over exposure, the contemplator's position mistaken for the paradigm, the propositional residue mistaken for the living act. The error of a whole epistemology, visited upon the analysis of faith.

Faith and its narrative

One task remains for this chapter: to close the circle with the preceding one, and to say how faith as consent is related to the Bible as narrative, for if I am right, the relation must be internal, and each of my two theses must need the other.

It does, and they do. Consent is given to a person; a person is identified by his history; and a history is possessed only narratively. I can consent to the God of Abraham, of Isaac, and of Jacob, and to the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, only if that God is presented to me—presentified—in the interactions that identify Him; abstract from the story and there remains no one to consent to, only a First Cause to be inferred or a First Truth to underwrite propositions, objects, respectively, of demonstration and of assent, but not possible terms of consent. Conversely, the narrative asks for consent as its ideal completion: we saw at the end of the last chapter how the Bible's living Character turns the ideal witness into an addressee. The narrative without consent collapses into literature; consent without the narrative starves, having no face before it. The Bible and faith are correlative, exactly as the Scholastics said of revelation and faith, but the correlation runs through presentification and consent, not through statement and assent. Whence, at last, the full answer to the question that opened chapter nine: revelation and faith must be narratively expressed because revelation is a self-giving and faith is a self-giving, and selves are given only in the dramatic order, and the dramatic order is spoken only in stories.

The transmission of faith obeys the same law, and the Bible itself shows it. How did Abraham's household come to the God of Abraham? Not by demonstration, and not by dictation. They trusted Abraham, which is to say consented to him, in the measure proper

to human trust, and through his narrative were made witnesses of his encounter, until the God of the story claimed them and their consent was no longer lent through Abraham but given in person. So the son asks at Passover, “What does this rite mean?”, and the father answers not with a doctrine but with the story: “We were Pharaoh’s slaves in Egypt, and the Lord brought us out with a mighty hand.” So the Church has always initiated: the catechumen is not first equipped with the propositions and then, information complete, invited to feel something; he is led through the narrative: lectionary, liturgy, the great figures traced from Adam to Christ in the paschal night, until, made witness, he is ready to be made participant, and the water asks him for his consent. *Fides ex auditu*: faith comes from hearing. From hearing the story told by those who have consented to its God, and the hearing that answers it, when it answers, is Abraham’s kind: *ob-audire*.

Faith, then, is consent: the whole person’s self-committing yes to the self-revealing God, narratively met, reflectively confessed, propositionally guarded, but in its essence none of these—in its essence the walking to Moriah. The Fathers taught it; the resisters of the thirteenth century felt it slipping and could not say why; Aquinas, who lived it, described something else. What remains is to ask what became of theology when the description replaced the thing, and what theology might be, if faith is what we have found it to be. That is the business of the final chapter.

Chapter 11: The First Eclipse

Curator's note: This chapter, like chapters 9 and 10, is a posthumous reconstruction drafted with AI assistance from Xavier's notes and essays. See the note at the head of chapter 9. It should not be quoted as his writing.

Hans Frei, in the book to which mine owes so much, tells the story of an eclipse. In the course of the eighteenth century, he shows, a whole way of reading the Bible was lost: the reading that took the biblical narrative as one cumulative, realistic story rendering an inhabitable world, a world into which readers had for centuries fitted their own lives. After the Enlightenment, the direction of fit reversed: the Bible's world now had to accredit itself before the world we otherwise know, its narratives reclassified as evidence, good or bad, for a history reconstructed behind them, or as vehicles of ideas extractable from them. Frei dates the eclipse, describes it, and mourns it. What he does not explain, or so it has always seemed to me, is why it happened—why the narrative reading, once so universal and so sturdy, collapsed almost without defenders in a single century.

The thesis of this final chapter is that the eclipse Frei describes was the second eclipse, and that its cause lies in the first, which this book has been examining from its opening page. What the eighteenth century harvested, the thirteenth had planted. Before the Bible could be dissolved into evidence for something else, it had first to be conceived as a book whose business is to state—for only statements can be evidence, only statements can be checked against

the facts, only statements can fail the check. That conception is not Enlightenment work. It is Scholastic work. It is the determinatio distrahens whose anatomy we have traced: revelation equated with knowledge, the literal sense equated with the propositional sense, narrative reduced to a series of statements, faith reduced to assent. The men of the Enlightenment inherited the equation intact and merely altered one term: where the Scholastic had said “these statements are certain, for God is their author,” the critic said “let us verify these statements, as we verify all others.” The step is short, and it is downhill. Nobody could have taken it if five centuries of theology had not first transformed the Bible from a presentification into a deposition.

I will spend this chapter making that thesis precise, drawing the consequences, and then, since a book of accusations owes its reader an accounting, saying as exactly as I can what I think theology is, once we no longer believe it to be a science of revealed premises. But I want to begin with a debt of honesty, by asking the question that any patient reader of the preceding ten chapters is entitled to press on me: if the Scholastic analysis of faith was as wrong as I have claimed, how is it that the Scholastics were men of such manifest and massive faith? For they were. Aquinas composed the office of Corpus Christi; he died, they tell us, asking that the Song of Songs be read to him; the *adoro te devote* is his. This is not the physiognomy of a man whose relationship with God was assent to guaranteed information. If his theory of faith was false, how did his faith escape his theory?

Why their faith survived their theory

The answer, once seen, illuminates the whole terrain, and it has been implicit since chapter eight. There I distinguished, within our relationship to the Scripture, between what I called practical comprehension and cognitive interpretation: between the comprehension exercised in actually following the narrative and consenting to its God, and the reflective account one gives, after the fact, of what that comprehension is. The two can diverge. They diverged in

Aquinas, and in the whole culture of the medieval schools, on the widest scale. And they could diverge because the narrative reading of the Bible, in the thirteenth century, did not live principally in books. It lived in the liturgy.

Consider what a medieval Christian, the theologian included, and the theologian more than most, actually did with the Bible. He did not, week by week, verify it; he prayed it. The psalter by heart; the lectionary's annual circuit through the story, from Advent's waiting to the fire of Pentecost; the great figures walking in procession through the year; the paschal night in which the whole narrative from Genesis to the empty tomb was recited over the water in which the catechumens were about to be immersed into the story. The liturgy is nothing else than the Church's institutionalized narrative reading: the presentification of the foundational events, and the reader made present to them not even as ideal witness only, but as respondent, for at every turn the narrative is interrupted to demand his amen. A man formed by that practice consented daily to the God of the story. His faith was fed at the spring, whatever his theory said about the water. Thomas at Corpus Christi's matins and Thomas at the lectern of the *Summa* were the same man, but they were doing profoundly different things, and only for the second had he a theory. His practical comprehension remained Abraham's and the Fathers'; his cognitive interpretation had become Aristotle's. The *determinatio distrahens* was real, but it operated, so to speak, downstream of his own life of faith; it distorted what he said faith was, not what his faith was.

This is why I said, at the end of chapter nine, that the answer to the question of how the masters' faith survived their theory is full of light. It shows where the narrative reading resided and how it was protected; and, by the same token, it shows under what conditions the theory would finally become lethal. So long as the liturgical-narrative practice stood intact, the propositional theory of revelation was a misdescription with limited effects, quarantined in the schools. Let the practice weaken, let the story cease to be the inhabited medium of a people's life, and the theory stands

alone, and men will draw its conclusions. That is what the interval between Aquinas and Reimarus supplied: the slow displacement of the narrative from the center of Christian existence, until, when the critics arrived to ask their question—are these statements true?—there was no longer a living practice to make the question sound as strange as it should sound. The first eclipse prepared the second not by abolishing the narrative reading but by de-legitimizing it: by installing, at the level of theory, the conviction that what the Bible really offers is statements, so that the narrative could henceforth be defended only as ornament, accommodation, or style. Ornaments are dispensable. In the eighteenth century, the bill for the thirteenth came due.

The scientialis reading and its two heirs

Let me now draw the line from the first eclipse to the second with more care, because the continuity I am asserting runs beneath what is usually presented as the great rupture between the age of faith and the age of criticism.

The Scholastic reading of the Bible, as we have exhaustively seen, is of the genre I have called, borrowing the medievals' own word, *scientialis*: the Bible is a book whose fundamental sense is propositional, whose propositions are certified by their Author, and from whose propositions conclusions may be drawn. The Enlightenment's reading of the Bible—here is my claim—is the same reading with the certification withdrawn. The critic agrees with the Scholastic about what kind of book the Bible is; that is precisely why he can put to it the question of evidence. He agrees that its narratives are, at bottom, assertions about matters of fact; he merely observes, correctly given the shared premise, that assertions about matters of fact are to be assessed by the canons that govern all such assertions, and he proceeds to assess them. What the eighteenth century called the "higher criticism" is the Scholastic doctrine of the literal-historical sense, armed with philology and stripped of deference. Reimarus is Aquinas's heir in exactly the sense in which a creditor is an heir.

And the heir had a twin. For there arose, in reaction to criticism, the reading that would eventually be called fundamentalist or literalist: the anxious insistence that every biblical assertion, taken precisely as assertion, is factually inerrant, and that the faith stands or falls with the certification of the whole file. It is customary to regard the critic and the fundamentalist as opposites. They are not opposites; they are rival executors of the same estate. Both received from the Scholastic centuries the identical conception of the Bible, a body of divinely-authored statements, and they differ only in their audit. Neither can so much as frame the possibility that the Bible's fundamental genre is not assertion at all; that its narratives are not a deposition about the past awaiting our verdict but a presentification demanding our presence; that the question "exactly what facts does this text certify?" might be, not the deepest question, but a category mistake: the tribute every age pays to Aristotle when it has forgotten it is paying tribute. The bitter modern war over the Bible is a civil war within the scientialis reading; and it cannot be won by either side, because it is fought over the estate of a mistake.

Frei saw much of this, and my debt to him is on every page of this book's second half. But Frei, if I may say so with the reverence owed him, dated the fall too late; and, a graver matter, he tried to rescue the narrative reading while remaining neutral about its truth. His "realistic narrative" renders a world; he leaves in suspense whether the world so rendered is the real one, whether the reader is invited to inhabit it or only to imagine it. I do not believe the suspense can be maintained. One cannot read the Bible narratively without reading it either religiously or non-religiously: either the ideal witness hears, in the living Character, the One who addresses him, and then witnessing becomes consent and the reader inhabits the world of the text as the real world, or he does not so hear, and then the biblical world is a world imaginarily visited, as Troy is, and the reading, whatever its richness, is of another kind altogether. There is no third, neutral, narrative-but-uncommitted reading; the claim of the text does not permit it, any more than the girl's cry from the river permitted Clamence a neutral hearing. Frei restored

to legitimacy the imaginative visiting of the biblical world, and for this every reader of the Bible must thank him. He did not restore—his method forbade him to restore—the legitimacy of inhabiting it. That further step cannot be taken by literary theory. It is taken, if at all, the way Abraham took it: by the reader who, made witness, consents. All that a book can do, and all this book has attempted, is to clear away the theoretical structures which for seven centuries have declared, first in Aristotle's name and then in reason's, that there is nothing there to consent to, only statements to be filed and audited.

The resisters vindicated

It is time to pay this book's oldest debt. In chapters three and four we listened at length to the men who resisted the transformation of *sacra doctrina* into a science: de Halès with his *modus revelativus*, Kilwardby, Stephen of Tournai, the Non-Aristotelians and Anti-Aristotelians whom the triumph of the Thomist synthesis reduced to a museum of scruples. I said then that their objections, dismissed as backwardness, seemed to me to conceal a sound instinct that lacked only a theory. The theory has now been supplied, and we can say with precision what their instinct was worth.

When de Halès insisted that the Scripture's genre is *revelativus* and not *argumentativus*, that the Bible "talks to the heart and moves to love and fear God" while science addresses the naked intellect, he was registering, in the vocabulary available to him, exactly the distinction between performative presentification and assertion, that is, between a text whose intrinsic effect is the moving of the reader-witness and a text whose intrinsic effect is assent. When Kilwardby maintained that the Bible cannot proceed by universal truths, that its matter is irreducibly particular—deeds, persons, times—he was defending, without the concept, the narrative sense: the sense that lives only in the particular and dies in the universal, the sense of which Aristotle's epistemology can render no account whatever, since for Aristotle the particular as particular is unknowable. When Stephen of Tournai complained that in the new theology one no

longer recognizes the face of the Scripture, he said more than he could justify: for a face is precisely what statements do not have and narratives do: the face of the One presentified in His deeds. Their obscure sense of incompatibility, which I invoked at the beginning of chapter eight, was the practical comprehension of competent readers of the Bible protesting against a cognitive interpretation that falsified it. They could not win, because a felt incongruity is helpless against a developed epistemology; one does not stop an army with a wince. But they were right. Seven centuries of consequences: the schools' Bible of premises, the critics' Bible of documents, the fundamentalists' Bible of inerrant data, and the long hemorrhage of readers for whom the book has become unreadable because they were taught it asserts what they cannot believe. Seven centuries have been needed to show how right.

And Bonaventure? He remains what he was in chapter one: the most poignant figure of the story, the man who saw the chasm and built a bridge over it out of the very material that made the chasm. He knew there was a *determinatio distrahens*; he said so; he felt, as Aquinas seems never to have felt, that the *credibile ut credibile* suffers violence when it is made *credibile ut intelligibile*. But because the only intelligibility he could theorize was Aristotle's, he could protect the revealed only by ceding the intellect to the other side: faith holding the substance, science holding the light. And his synthesis, as we saw, resolves into a courteous partition that would end, generations later, in the doctrine of double truth he would have died rather than embrace. His instinct, like the resisters', awaited a different theory of understanding: one in which the narrative is not a defective mode of the intelligible but a plenary mode of its own; in which being moved is not the enemy of comprehension but, for texts of this genre, its very organ. Given that theory, Bonaventure's *determinatio distrahens* becomes a precise truth: the passage from the narrated to the demonstrated is a change of object, a loss, exactly as he sensed. It needs no compensating surrender of the intellect to Aristotle, because the intellect was never Aristotle's to confiscate.

What, then, is theology?

I have promised not to end in mere demolition. If theology is not what the thirteenth century decided it was—a science, or quasi-science, drawing conclusions from revealed premises—what is it? Has this book, in striking at the scientific ideal, struck theology itself?

I do not think so, and the elements of the answer are all in hand.

Recall the two offices we found doctrine legitimately exercising in the last chapter. The confession articulates consent: it compresses the foundational narrative to its dramatic skeleton and utters it in the first person, before the font, as an act of allegiance. The definition guards the confession: when the identity of the God of the story is contested, as when an Arius reads the same narrative and presentifies a different Christ, the Church draws a line, in the propositional order, to keep the consent aimed at its true Object. Here, already, is reflective intellectual work internal to faith and necessary to it; and neither office makes the propositions primary, for both exist in the service of the narrative and the consent, and both point back into them.

Theology is the sustained, disciplined extension of these two offices. It is faith's own reflection: *fides quaerens intellectum*, exactly as Anselm said before the great mutation, and as Augustine practiced before him. Its task is threefold. It keeps the narrative readable: the endless labor of language, history, and exegesis by which each generation is enabled to be made witness by a text that time keeps estranging, a labor in which, be it said clearly, the critical scholarship of the last centuries has its honorable and permanent place, for the presentification is served and not betrayed by everything that lets us hear the story as it asks to be heard. It keeps the consent aimed: the dogmatic labor of identification, testing every proposed reading against the rule of faith, guarding the Name. And it keeps the reflection honest: the properly philosophical labor—the labor this book has attempted for one disastrous case—of examining the conceptual instruments with which faith describes itself, lest an alien epistemology, borrowed in all innocence, quietly replace the

thing described. Theology so conceived has full title to rigor, to argument, to system; it can be done well or badly, and its history shows summits enough. What it does not have, and must stop claiming, is the Aristotelian title: it is not a science deducing from certified premises, because the revealed is not premises; its first principles are not propositions per se nota to God and believed by us, but the living God narratively given and consented to; and its conclusions return it, always, to the story and the font, or they are idle. Judged by inclination and by knowledge, said Aquinas, distinguishing the saint's wisdom from the doctor's; and we saw what his system did with the distinction. Reverse the primacy, and the distinction becomes true: the theologian's judgment by knowledge is a specialized instrument in the service of the whole Church's judgment by inclination, by connaturality with the God of the narrative, and severed from that service it does not rise to a higher objectivity; it sinks to an expertise about documents.

The reader will notice that on this account the theologian is not situated before the Bible as any other of the faithful, plus a method. He is situated as any other of the faithful, absolutely; the method comes after, and remains after. There is no *determinatio distrahens* in theology so conceived, for nothing is passed from one epistemological regime to another: the theologian reflects, from within the consent, on the consent and its Object, and his most technical page is answerable to the paschal night. The *determinatio distrahens* begins at the precise moment the reflection claims autonomy, claims to possess, in its extracted propositions, the revealed itself, so that the narrative becomes raw material and the consent becomes an application. That moment, and not reflection as such, is the fall this book has chronicled.

Conclusion

I began this book with a question about Aquinas: whether he realized that in submitting the Bible to the regime of Aristotelian science he was distorting its nature, and the nature of revelation, and of faith. The question can now be answered in full, and the

answer is the one the first chapter already suspected: he did not realize it, and he could not have realized it, because the instrument of the distortion was the very instrument with which he did his realizing. The Aristotelian epistemology was not, for Aquinas, one theory among others; it was the shape of rationality itself, the light in which everything appeared and which therefore never appeared itself. Within that light he worked with a fidelity, a power, and a serenity that no one who has spent years in his company, as I have, and the reader will have felt that my quarrel is a lover's quarrel, can regard without awe. The failure was not of intelligence and not of faith. It was the failure of a light to see itself; and the price of the failure was paid, slowly, by the book the light was turned on: the Bible, transformed from the presentification of the living God into the best-certified file of statements in the world, and delivered in that form to the centuries that would learn, first to systematize the file, then to doubt it, then to close it.

Against that transformation this book has argued a single thesis in many forms. Revelation is God's self-giving in interaction, and its expression is therefore narrative, for only narrative presentifies. Faith is the exposed person's consent to the God so given, and it is therefore no species of assent, for assent is owed to statements and there is no statement at Moriah. The Bible is the shared foundational story by which the self-giving reaches every generation, making readers witnesses and witnesses respondents. Doctrine is the guardian of the story's Name, theology the discipline of its service, and both are corrupted at the root when they promote themselves from servants of the presentification to proprietors of its alleged propositional content. The categories of the Bible (call, promise, covenant, obedience, presence) and the categories of Aristotle (substance, demonstration, assent, science) are not rival answers to one question; they belong to different orders, the order of exposure and the order of contemplation; and the patient burden of these eleven chapters has been that the medieval attempt to translate the first into the second, undertaken in perfect good faith by the greatest minds of an age, translated them out of existence.

If I am right, what follows is not a program—programs are cheap—but a direction, and it can be stated in a sentence. The recovery of the Christian understanding of faith will not come from a better theory of religious propositions, nor from their more ingenious defense, nor from their more candid abandonment; it will come, if it comes, from wherever the Scripture is again read as what it is: prayed, celebrated, told to the young, inhabited, until the theory follows the practice home. The practice has never wholly ceased; the spring the Scholastics' theory could not describe, and the critics' theory could not find, has continued to flow in every place where the story is told by those who consent to its God. Theory is not nothing; were theory nothing, this book would be nothing; but its office is humble: to stop saying, in reason's name, that the spring is a file. I have tried to discharge that office. *Scio cui credidi*: the sentence with which the last chapter began may stand as the conclusion of the whole. Faith knows whom, not that. A book can at most show why the whom was never a that; it cannot perform the knowing. That is done—it has always only been done—by walking to the mountain.